

Author's Note

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Chapter 1: A Familiar Door Opens

The late morning sun cast a soft glow over Mikazuki Villa, its wooden frame warm and inviting beneath the clear sky. A gentle breeze stirred the trees, rustling the leaves like whispers of old memories. In front of the villa's gate, two figures appeared — one serene, the other vibrant.

Kasumi adjusted her ribbon with a flourish, her eyes scanning the quiet yard. "So this is it," she said, voice light with curiosity. "Yachiyo's home. The place where Kamihama's magical girls gather."

Beside her, Lunaria stood still, her dark indigo hair catching the sunlight like silk. Her gaze was thoughtful, her dark eyes reflecting the quiet strength of the place. "It feels peaceful," she murmured. "Like it's held many stories."

Just then, the front door creaked open. Iroha, Yachiyo, and Kuroe stepped out, their expressions shifting from surprise to recognition.

Iroha smiled warmly. "Why, if it isn't Kasumi and Lunaria. It's so good to see you here!"

Kasumi beamed and gave an energetic wave. "Right back at you, Iroha! You're looking well."

Then she turned to Kuroe with a playful grin. "Hey Kuroe! I told you we'd meet again soon, didn't I? And it looks like you're getting closer to Iroha too. Good for you!"

Kuroe blushed, rubbing the back of her neck. "Thanks... A lot's happened recently. Iroha and I are starting to work together again. I hope we can keep it up."

Her gaze shifted to the unfamiliar girl beside Kasumi. "I don't think we've met. Are you a friend of Kasumi?"

Lunaria smiled gently and bowed with quiet grace. "Nice to meet you. You can call me Lunaria. I'm a close friend of Kasumi."

Kuroe's eyes widened. "Wait... you're Lunaria? The flutist from the Kamihama school talent show? Your performance was incredible. It was so beautiful, so moving... I felt more at peace than I have in a long time. Thank you."

Lunaria chuckled softly. "I'm glad my music reached you. That's all I ever hope for."

Yachiyo stepped forward, her posture calm but alert. “Kasumi. Lunaria. What brings you here?”

Kasumi grinned. “We all agreed to share what we learn about the Rumors of Kamihama, remember? Back when we ate at Banbanzai after the talent show.”

She turned to Yachiyo, her tone growing more serious. “Yesterday, I learned more about the Wings of the Magius after visiting the memory museum. A lot of strange and sketchy things — some of it might even tie into the Rumors. I thought it was time we compare notes.”

Yachiyo studied her for a moment, then nodded. “Ah, that’s right. I didn’t expect you to reach out so soon. I appreciate your openness. Come in.”

They entered the villa together, the door closing behind them with a quiet click. The living room was sunlit and still, the air filled with the scent of tea and old wood. A sense of quiet anticipation settled over the space.

Kasumi glanced around. “Where are the others?”

Iroha sat down, her voice tinged with concern. “Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno went to the memory museum yesterday. They haven’t come back.”

Yachiyo added, her tone more guarded, “I suspect the Wings of the Magius convinced them to stay. Manipulated them, maybe.”

Kasumi frowned. “Strange... Touka and Mifuyu didn’t try to recruit me when I visited. Did your friends join willingly?”

Yachiyo shook her head. “I don’t think so. Not entirely.”

There was a pause, the weight of uncertainty settling in.

Then Iroha asked, “What about Mami? We met her at the talent show. Is she coming?”

Kasumi gave a small shrug. “She’s busy. She won’t be joining us today.”

Lunaria remained quiet, her gaze drifting to the window, as if sensing something beyond the horizon — something yet to unfold.

The sunlight filtered through the windows of Mikazuki Villa, casting soft patterns across the floor. The air was quiet, but the tension in the room had begun to rise — not hostile, but heavy with memory.

Kasumi leaned forward slightly, her tone shifting from playful to thoughtful. “Yesterday... I went to the memory museum. As you know — and to your disapproval — Mifuyu invited Iroha, Tsuruno, Sana, and Felicia. I happened to show up just as they were heading out, and they agreed to let me tag along.”

Yachiyo’s expression darkened. Her fingers curled slightly against her teacup. “That Mifuyu... always trying to recruit people into that group. She hasn’t changed.”

Kasumi continued. “Touka gave a lecture. She called it a lesson in truth. Two dark truths, to be exact. First: a magical girl’s soul is literally in her soul gem. If it breaks... she dies.”

Yachiyo’s jaw tightened. Her eyes dropped to the floor.

Kasumi’s voice softened. “Second: the final fate of magical girls is to become witches when they succumb to despair.”

Iroha and Kuroe glanced at Yachiyo, sensing the shift in her energy. Kuroe subtly moved closer, while Iroha reached out and gently placed a hand on Yachiyo’s arm.

“To reinforce those truths,” Kasumi said, “Touka showed us memories. Mifuyu’s... and yours.”

Yachiyo’s fists clenched at her sides. Her breath hitched.

Kasumi hesitated, then spoke with care. “Kanae... she used too much magical power fighting a witch to protect your team. Her soul gem shattered.”

Yachiyo closed her eyes. Her shoulders trembled slightly.

“And Mel... after your team failed to defeat a witch and couldn’t get a grief seed, her soul gem was already too tainted. She succumbed to despair and became a witch.”

Yachiyo opened her eyes, and they were sharp with pain. “They had no right to show that. Not like that. Not to make a point. Using my painful memories to coerce girls into joining their cause?” Her voice cracked. “Disgusting...”

Iroha gently squeezed her arm. Kuroe remained silent but steady, her presence a quiet comfort.

Kasumi bowed her head slightly. “I’m sorry. I didn’t know what we were walking into. But it made me think — about how much the Wings of the Magius are willing to expose... and how much they’re still hiding.”

She looked up again. “Touka talked about the Automatic Purification System. The APS. She said it would spread across the world soon. That all magical girls would be liberated.”

Yachiyo’s voice was low, almost bitter. “Liberated... from despair?”

Kasumi nodded. “That’s the promise. But after I left the museum, I ran into Kuroe — we talked briefly — and then I found Mitama’s shop.”

Kuroe perked up. “Oh yeah, I remember. You said we’d meet again soon.”

Kasumi smiled. “And here we are.”

She turned back to Yachiyo. “Mitama told me she’s been adjusting magical girls’ soul gems to attune them to the APS. When they reach despair, they don’t become witches — they become doppels.”

Yachiyo’s eyes narrowed. “Did she say anything about side effects?”

Kasumi sighed. “I asked. She said there are side effects... but she couldn’t share them.”

Yachiyo leaned forward, her voice sharper now. “Did she test you?”

Kasumi chuckled. “She was suspicious. She did some check-in tests. Tried to figure out if I was a magical girl.”

Yachiyo’s gaze lingered, searching. “And what did she find?”

Kasumi winked. “If you want to know... you can ask Mitama.”

Yachiyo sighed, but a small smile tugged at her lips. “Still keeping that secret to yourself, Kasumi? You and Lunaria both?”

Lunaria chuckled softly, her voice like moonlight. “Some mysteries are meant to unfold slowly.”

Iroha and Kuroe laughed gently, the tension easing.

Yachiyo leaned back. “As a matter of fact, I saw Mitama yesterday too. We talked about the side effects of doppels. I’ll share what I learned once you’re done.”

Kasumi nodded. “Thanks. I’ll wrap up.”

She folded her hands in her lap. “The Wings of the Magius’ system... it sounds promising. It could work. But they’re secretive. Too many details are hidden from their own members. And they can’t control the doppels. That’s dangerous.”

She looked around the room, her gaze lingering on each face. “I think there are very bad side effects. And I think we need to know what they are — before it’s too late.”

The room fell quiet again, the air thick with reflection. Kasumi’s words lingered like smoke, and all eyes turned to Yachiyo.

She sat straighter, her gaze steady but distant. “After Iroha, Tsuruno, Sana, and Felicia went to the memory museum... I went there too. Uninvited.”

“I had to. Something felt wrong. When I arrived, I found Mifuyu watching over you, Iroha — you were still asleep, caught in the memories of my past. Of hers too.”

Iroha nodded softly. “I remember... fragments. Pain. Loss.”

Yachiyo’s voice grew colder. “I confronted Mifuyu. We had our usual argument about who was right and who was wrong. I kept telling her that what the Wings of the Magius are doing is dangerous, manipulative. But Mifuyu kept insisting that not everyone could be as strong as me. That weak magical girls need something — anything — to believe in. Some kind of hope to escape the misery of this life.”

She paused, her tone bitter. “Eventually, she realized we were going in circles again. So she used her magic to teleport away.”

Kasumi frowned. “Seems like you two have been going back and forth for a long time.”

“Indeed,” Yachiyo said quietly. “And I woke Iroha up. We tried to find a way out of the museum together.”

Her fingers curled slightly against her lap. “I told Iroha I planned to disband our Mikazuki Villa group.”

Kuroe’s eyes widened. “You... what?”

Yachiyo looked down. “I didn’t say it out loud. But I was convinced. Tsuruno, Sana, Felicia — all gone. Just like before. My modeling unit... my old teammates... Kanae, Mel. I’ve always been the one left behind.”

Her voice trembled. “I thought my wish was cursed. That it caused their disappearances. So I decided to stop working with others. To protect them... from me.”

Kuroe’s expression softened. Iroha reached out again, her voice gentle. “I promised I’d never leave you.”

Yachiyo looked at her, and for a moment, her eyes shimmered. “You did. And I saw your resolve. I started to open up. Just a little.”

She exhaled. “But then... members of the Wings of the Magius confronted us. Tried to capture us. The ground broke beneath us during the fight. Iroha fell.”

Iroha nodded slowly. “I remember falling. The light fading.”

“I couldn’t save you,” Yachiyo whispered. “I escaped. But I felt... hollow. Angry. Like an old wound had been torn open again.”

Her voice cracked. “I remember calling you a liar as I walked back to Mikazuki Villa. In my grief. After you promised to stay. After I started to open myself up again.”

Iroha looked at Yachiyo warmly, her gaze steady. She remembered Yachiyo’s face — filled with desperation and despair — as she fell into the collapsing ground.

Yachiyo shook her head. “I was alone again. Back at Mikazuki Villa. Angry. Sad. I decided I would take down the Wings of the Magius myself.”

“I went to Mitama’s shop and confronted her. Asked if she was working with the Wings. If she was adjusting soul gems to attune them to the APS system.”

“And?” Lunaria asked softly.

“She admitted it,” Yachiyo said. “She said she did adjust soul gems. That the APS prevents magical girls from becoming witches — but turns them into something else. Doppels. Or more precisely, Doppel witches.”

Kasumi’s brow furrowed. “Did she say why?”

“She claimed neutrality. Said she didn’t know much about the Wings’ plans. But I couldn’t forgive them. Not after everything.”

Kasumi replied, “Interesting... even someone like her, who’s essential to the APS, doesn’t know what the Wings are really planning? How much are their leaders hiding?”

Yachiyo’s voice grew firm. “I asked where their headquarters was. Hotel Faint Hope. She said I’d need a Magius emblem to enter. So I decided to hunt down any member of the Wings of the Magius and take their emblem for myself. I would break in.”

The room fell silent again, the weight of Yachiyo’s story settling over them like dusk.

Kasumi finally spoke, her voice low with awe. “Wow... That is some dedication and resolve...”

Yachiyo’s voice remained steady, but her eyes grew distant again, as if retracing each step.

“After I left Mitama’s shop, I wandered for a while. I didn’t know where to go next. I was angry, exhausted... and alone.”

She paused. “That’s when I saw it. The small Kyubey.”

Iroha and Kuroe both glanced at each other knowingly.

“It wasn’t the same as the one that made contracts with us,” Yachiyo continued. “This one doesn’t speak. It just... appears. Always at strange, convenient times. I’d seen it before, but never understood its purpose.”

Her gaze sharpened. “And then I saw Kuroe. She was following it.”

Kuroe looked down, her voice quiet. “I was trying to figure out what it wanted. I didn’t expect to run into you.”

Yachiyo’s tone darkened. “You were wearing the Wings of the Magius uniform. The black feather. I didn’t stop to ask questions. I chased you. Cornered you.”

Kuroe nodded. “I remember. I was so scared.”

“I was ready to interrogate you,” Yachiyo said. “To demand answers. But before I could, Mifuyu appeared.”

Her voice grew colder. “She asked me to stop. To hear you out. I refused.”

Kasumi leaned forward slightly. “What did she say?”

“She said the Wings of the Magius wouldn’t abandon magical girls. That they were trying to save them. I told her I’d lost too many friends because of them — Iroha, and maybe even Tsuruno, Sana, and Felicia. I couldn’t trust them anymore.”

Yachiyo’s hands tightened in her lap. “Words weren’t enough. So I prepared to fight.”

Lunaria’s voice was soft. “And Mifuyu?”

“She didn’t want to fight. But she knew she had no choice.”

Yachiyo's eyes flickered. "We both summoned our doppels. Hevelius for her. Campanella for me. The battle was... intense."

She paused, remembering. "I won. Mifuyu fell. She looked up at me — while I was still under the influence of my doppel — and gave me a sad smile. She thought it was the end."

Her voice trembled. "I was about to strike the final blow. But something stopped me. I remembered everything. Kanae. Mel. Iroha's promise. I couldn't lose another friend."

She exhaled. "I forced my doppel back. Returned to my magical girl form."

Kuroe looked at her gently. "You spared her."

Yachiyo nodded. "She thanked me. Said she was grateful I still saw her as a friend."

"She began preparing teleportation magic — for herself and for Kuroe. But the small Kyubey ran outside the field. And Kuroe followed."

Kuroe added, "I didn't think. I just moved."

Yachiyo continued, "Only Mifuyu teleported away. And the small Kyubey kept going. So we followed."

Her voice softened. "It led us to the **Eternal Sakura**."

Kasumi's eyes widened. "Is that... one of the rumors of Kamihama?"

Yachiyo nodded. "Kuroe said Nemu asked her to find it. That it was created to protect Iroha."

She paused, her voice barely above a whisper. "I had hope. Maybe Iroha was still alive."

Her gaze grew distant again. "We saw a figure begin to emerge from the tree. Iroha."

"But it wasn't her."

Kuroe's voice was quiet. "It was Giovanna."

Yachiyo nodded. "Her doppel. It consumed us."

The room fell silent, the weight of Yachiyo's story pressing down like snowfall.

Yachiyo's voice softened, her gaze drifting toward the window as if the memory were still unfolding beyond the glass.

"After Giovanna consumed us... everything changed."

She paused. "Kuroe and I found ourselves in Mikazuki Villa. But it wasn't the real one. It felt like a dream — warm, quiet, almost too perfect."

Kuroe nodded slowly. "Everyone was there. Iroha, Sana, Felicia, Tsuruno... and they all knew me. Like we'd been friends for years."

Yachiyo continued, “We lived through a day together. Fought witches. Ate dinner. Laughed. It was... peaceful. Almost healing.”

She glanced at Kuroe. “You and Iroha had a long talk that evening.”

Kuroe smiled faintly. “It meant a lot to me. I’ve always wanted to earn Iroha’s trust. To be someone she could rely on. And in that moment... it felt like I already was.”

“She told you that you were friends,” Yachiyo said. “That she hoped all of us at Mikazuki Villa would always be together.”

Iroha’s eyes shimmered. “I remember that dream. It felt so real.”

Yachiyo’s voice grew quieter. “But as everyone prepared for bed, Kuroe and I started to notice something strange. The teddy bear — Ui. She was always there. Watching.”

Kuroe’s expression darkened. “She wasn’t just a toy. She was behind everything.”

Yachiyo nodded. “We confronted her. And that’s when Giovanna appeared.”

Her tone sharpened. “She said she created a new Ui. A new reality. All to make Iroha happy. And she wouldn’t let us take that away.”

Kasumi leaned forward. “So you fought her?”

Yachiyo’s eyes flashed. “We did. It was intense. Giovanna was powerful — not just in strength, but in emotion. She was born from Iroha’s deepest despair.”

Kuroe added, “But we used connect. We reached each other. And that gave us the strength to win.”

Yachiyo nodded. “The moment we defeated her... the dream shattered.”

She looked up, her voice filled with quiet awe. “We were back at the Eternal Sakura. It was blooming. Beautiful. And from its blossoms... Iroha appeared.”

Iroha smiled softly. “I descended slowly. Like waking from a long sleep.”

Yachiyo’s voice warmed. “We ran to her. She opened her eyes. And she was back.”

The room was silent for a moment, the weight of the memory settling like petals on still water.

Yachiyo continued, “Which brings us to now. The three of us decided to go directly to the Wings of the Magius’ headquarters. To bring back our friends — Tsuruno, Sana, and Felicia. And for Iroha to meet Nemu.”

Iroha nodded. “Nemu told Kuroe to find the Eternal Sakura. She created it to protect me. Maybe she knows more about Ui. About everything.”

Yachiyo looked around the room. “We were just leaving the villa... when we ran into you two.”

She smiled at Kasumi and Lunaria.

Kasumi grinned. “Talk about timing.”

Lunaria’s gaze was gentle. “It seems the threads are weaving together.”

Chapter 2: Infiltrate the Wings of the Magius

The morning light had shifted, casting long shadows across the floor of Mikazuki Villa. The air was still, the warmth of shared stories lingering like the scent of steeped tea. A quiet understanding had settled between the five girls — not perfect trust, but something close. A fragile truce, stitched together by memory and resolve.

Kasumi stood first, her usual buoyancy tempered by something softer. She bowed slightly, her voice calm and sincere. “Thank you, all of you. For being open with us. For trusting us with your stories. I know it’s not easy to revisit those memories, especially when they’re still fresh.”

Lunaria, standing beside her, offered a gentle nod. “It means more than you know. To be welcomed into your circle like this... to be allowed to listen, and to share. That kind of openness is rare.”

Yachiyo inclined her head, her posture still guarded but respectful. “And thank you both. What you’ve shared... it’s helped us see things more clearly. Even if we don’t agree on everything, I appreciate your honesty.”

Iroha smiled, her warmth undimmed. “We’re all trying to protect each other. That’s what matters most. Even if we’re coming from different places, I think we all want the same thing.”

Kuroe added quietly, “Even if we don’t have all the answers yet... it feels like we’re getting closer.”

Just then, the soft patter of paws interrupted the moment. The small Kyubey padded into the room, its movements silent and deliberate. It stopped in front of Kasumi and Lunaria, tilting its head with that same unreadable curiosity.

Kasumi blinked. “Is that...?”

Lunaria’s eyes softened, recognition flickering in her gaze. “The one they mentioned. The Kyubey that doesn’t speak. The one that always shows up at the right time.”

Without a word, both reached out and gently placed their hands on its head.

The moment they touched it, something shifted.

A pulse of recognition surged through them — not just surprise, but something deeper. Something ancient. Something sacred.

Their eyes widened. Kasumi and Lunaria exchanged a glance, then closed their eyes.

In that instant, they understood.

This is Ui.

Iroha's younger sister.

The realization struck like lightning. Not a theory. Not a guess. A truth, clear and undeniable. They could feel it — the soul, the presence, the quiet warmth that lingered beneath the surface. The small Kyubey wasn't just a guide. She was someone. She was trying to help.

Their thoughts connected, flowing like water.

She's been helping them, Lunaria thought. Guiding them. Watching over them.

But how? Kasumi replied. *How did Ui's soul end up here?*

Then, a voice — energetic, innocent, and curious — echoed in their minds.

You... can hear me?

Kasumi and Lunaria froze.

I haven't spoken to anyone like this since... before I became a witch.

Their breath caught.

You became a witch? Kasumi asked gently.

Yes, Ui replied. *It's a long story. It relates to the Wings of the Magius. I remember everything... but I haven't been able to tell anyone. Not until now.*

Kasumi and Lunaria were stunned. They had stumbled into something far deeper than they expected — a soul preserved, a mystery embodied, a voice long silenced.

Lunaria's thoughts were calm but urgent. *Yes, we want to hear everything. About you. About the Wings. But not now. If we keep talking, the others will notice. We'll talk more later.*

Of course, Ui whispered. Thank you... for hearing me. I look forward to talking with you soon.

The connection faded.

Kasumi and Lunaria opened their eyes, their expressions unreadable. The small Kyubey blinked once, then sat quietly between them.

Across the room, Yachiyo, Iroha, and Kuroe watched closely.

Yachiyo's voice was measured, her eyes sharp. "Are you two alright?"

Kasumi blinked, then smiled with practiced ease. "We're fine. Just... startled. It's strange to see a Kyubey that doesn't speak or make contracts. It's not what we're used to."

Lunaria nodded, her tone serene. "It's different. But peaceful. There's something gentle about it."

Yachiyo's gaze narrowed. She felt the same unease she'd felt back at Banbanzai, after the talent show — that quiet exchange, that flicker of something hidden. She reached out telepathically to Iroha and Kuroe.

Their reactions weren't normal. The way they sat like that silently with their eyes closed for a few seconds. They're hiding something again.

I noticed it too, Iroha replied. I wonder what they felt when they touched the young Kyubey. Something changed.

Neither of them seem to have soul gems, Kuroe added. So maybe touching a different type of Kyubey had some strange effect on them? Or maybe they're not like us at all.

Kasumi stepped forward, her tone light but purposeful. "We'd like to come with you. To Hotel Faint Hope."

Yachiyo hesitated. Her instincts flared. "It's dangerous. You don't have soul gems. We're breaking into the headquarters of the Wings of the Magius. There could be traps, security, or worse."

Kasumi waved a hand, brushing off the concern with a smile. "Don't worry about us. Focus on yourselves. If something happens to us, don't try to rescue us. We're not your responsibility."

Lunaria added, her voice calm and clear, "We've traveled the world. Met magical girls from every corner. We've seen things and been in tight situations before. We'll be fine. Just worry about yourselves."

Yachiyo's suspicions deepened. She reached out again, her thoughts sharp and focused.

How can they be so confident? No normal humans would be able to infiltrate the Wings of the Magius' HQ safely. What have they done in their travels? What are they hiding?

Maybe they have abilities that could get them out of trouble, Iroha replied. They've always been vague about their past.

So they may be magical girls after all? Kuroe added.

Yachiyo's thoughts settled into resolve. *Let them come. But if something happens to them... we don't intervene. This might be our chance to learn who they are and what they're really capable of.*

Iroha and Kuroe nodded.

Agreed.

As Yachiyo, Iroha, and Kuroe exchanged silent thoughts, a parallel conversation unfolded just as quietly between Kasumi and Lunaria.

Should we tell them? Kasumi asked, her mental voice tinged with hesitation. *About Ui?*

Lunaria's response came slowly, her tone thoughtful, deliberate. *Not yet. If Iroha knew... she'd be desperate to reach Nemu. She'd push too hard, too fast. And we still don't know Ui's full story. What she says about the Wings of the Magius could provoke Yachiyo into taking even harsher action.*

Kasumi's thoughts flickered with concern. *Right. It could endanger everyone. Especially without a concrete plan. We don't even know what kind of defenses the Wings have in place... or how to reach Nemu once we're inside.*

We'll tell them, Lunaria promised. *But only when it's safe. When we understand more. When the time is right.*

Kasumi nodded silently, her gaze drifting to the small Kyubey now perched on Iroha's shoulder. Ui's presence was quiet, but unmistakable. Watching. Waiting. Her tiny paws clung gently to Iroha's collar, her ears twitching with each shift in the wind.

Yachiyo broke the silence aloud, her voice firm. "Alright. Let's move."

They left Mikazuki Villa together, the five of them walking in a loose formation. The morning air was crisp, tinged with the scent of dew and distant city smoke. Their footsteps echoed faintly against the pavement, the rhythm of their march steady but tense.

The small Kyubey rode comfortably on Iroha's shoulder, her eyes scanning the horizon with eerie calm. Kuroe led the way, her Magius emblem glowing faintly like a compass, pulsing with soft light as it tracked the portal's location.

As they moved deeper into the outskirts of Kamihama, the streets grew quieter. The buildings thinned. The air felt heavier, charged with something unseen — a pressure that settled in their chests and made the hairs on their arms stand on end.

Then, without warning, the portal shimmered into view.

It hovered just above the ground, a swirling vortex of violet and silver light, humming with unstable magic. The edges crackled like static, and the air around it rippled with heat and cold at once.

But they weren't alone.

From the swirling light, two figures stepped forward — Tsukuyo and Tsukasa Amane.

Their arrival was silent, but their presence was thunderous.

Tsukuyo's eyes narrowed the moment she saw Yachiyo. Her voice was low, venomous. "You again. Always interfering. Always clawing at things you don't understand."

Tsukasa stepped forward, her tone sharper, more brittle. "We won't let you ruin everything. Not this time."

Their gazes turned to Kuroe, and their expressions twisted with betrayal.

"You led them here?" Tsukuyo spat. "You traitor."

Kuroe took a step back, her voice trembling. "I... I didn't betray anyone. I just did what Nemu told me. I followed her instructions. I did nothing wrong!"

"You expect us to believe that?" Tsukasa snapped. "You've chosen your side. And it's not ours."

Yachiyo stepped between them, her stance firm, her voice cutting through the tension like a blade. “Enough. Iroha, Kuroe — go. Get through the portal. I’ll hold them off.”

Iroha hesitated, her eyes wide. “But—”

“Go!” Yachiyo shouted, her eyes blazing with resolve.

Iroha and Kuroe turned and sprinted toward the portal, the ground vibrating beneath their feet as the magic intensified.

Yachiyo glanced to her left — and froze.

Kasumi and Lunaria were gone.

They had been right beside her. She’d felt their presence. Heard their footsteps. But now... nothing.

No trace. No sound. No flicker of magic.

And the Amane sisters hadn’t reacted. Hadn’t noticed their disappearance at all.

Yachiyo’s thoughts raced. *They vanished without a trace. Not even the sisters sensed them. What did they do? How did they move like that?*

She clenched her fists, her grip tightening around her lance. *They have powers. Abilities they haven’t shown us. And I will find out what they are.*

The Amane sisters raised their hands in unison, summoning one of Alina’s cubes. The air twisted violently, and from the cube emerged a witch — Durbar.

Its form was jagged and chaotic, a swirling mass of ink-black limbs and glowing red eyes. Its presence was suffocating, like a storm pressing against the skin.

Yachiyo narrowed her eyes. “I do not have time for witch hunting now,” she muttered, her voice low and furious.

Graceful trails of water swirled around her as she transformed into her magical girl form. Her hair lifted with the surge of magic, her cape fluttering like a banner in the wind. She twirled her lance once, the blade gleaming, and charged at Durbar with a battle cry that echoed through the alley.

Meanwhile, Iroha and Kuroe stumbled through the portal, their bodies jolted by the shift in space. They landed hard on smooth stone, the air around them cool and damp. The corridor was dimly lit, the walls etched with strange, spiraling symbols that pulsed faintly with residual magic.

The silence was absolute — no footsteps, no wind, no sound beyond their own breathing.

Then — voices.

“You made it,” Kasumi said cheerfully, her voice echoing lightly in the stone chamber.

Lunaria stood beside her, arms folded, smiling with quiet amusement.

Iroha and Kuroe stared, stunned.

“How... how did you get here so fast?” Iroha asked, her voice breathless.

“We didn’t even see you go through the portal,” Kuroe added. “Or sense you.”

Kasumi shrugged, her tone playful but evasive. “Adventurer’s instinct. When there’s an opening, you take it. That portal was calling to us.”

Lunaria nodded, her expression serene. “We’ve traveled a lot. You learn to move quickly when the moment presents itself. Sometimes you don’t wait for permission — you just move.”

Iroha and Kuroe exchanged a glance. The explanation was... convenient. Too convenient.

There was no way ordinary humans could have slipped through unnoticed. No way they could have bypassed the portal’s magical signature without triggering something.

And they were sure Yachiyo would notice too.

Something was off.

Something was hidden.

But for now, they were inside. Together.

And the truth — whatever it was — would have to wait.

The underground corridor stretched ahead like a forgotten artery, dimly lit by flickering lanterns embedded in the walls. The air was cool and metallic, tinged with the faint scent of ozone and stone dust. As the group moved forward, the small Kyubey suddenly perked up, its ears twitching sharply.

Without warning, it hopped off Iroha’s shoulder and scampered toward a narrow alcove in the wall. A soft chime echoed as a hidden panel slid open, revealing a sleek, silver train nestled in a recessed track. Its surface shimmered faintly with magical runes, and its doors opened with a quiet hiss.

Kasumi tilted her head. “Well, that’s not ominous at all.”

Lunaria smiled, her voice low and amused. “Or it’s exactly what we need.”

The small Kyubey hopped aboard without hesitation, settling into a seat near the front. Its tiny paws curled beneath it, eyes half-lidded in serene focus.

Kasumi and Lunaria exchanged a glance, then connected telepathically.

Looks like Ui knows something, Kasumi thought. She’s leading us somewhere important.

She’s guiding us, Lunaria agreed. Not just through the HQ... but toward something she wants us to see.

The others boarded silently, the train’s interior surprisingly warm and softly lit. The seats were cushioned in deep violet fabric, and the windows showed only shifting shadows as the train began to move.

As the train glided forward, Kuroe glanced down at her Magius emblem. Her breath caught.

It had turned black.

She held it up, her voice trembling. “My emblem... it changed.”

Iroha leaned closer, her brow furrowed. “What does that mean?”

Kasumi studied it with quiet intensity. “It’s likely a mark of betrayal. The Wings of the Magius must have sensed your shift in allegiance.”

Lunaria added, “We’ll need to be careful. If the emblem is tied to their systems, it could trigger traps or alert others.”

Kuroe nodded, her fingers curling around the emblem protectively. “I’ll be careful. I promise.”

The train hummed beneath them, a low, steady rhythm that filled the silence. Outside the windows, the shadows began to shift — glimpses of stone chambers, glowing glyphs, and distant figures flickering past like ghosts.

Iroha turned to Kuroe, her voice gentle. “Can I ask you something?”

Kuroe blinked. “Of course.”

“Why did you join the Wings of the Magius?”

Kuroe looked down, her voice quiet. “There weren’t many witches in Takarazaki. Not enough to keep me going. And I’m... not strong. I can’t fight witches alone. The Wings told me they could save magical girls like me. That I wouldn’t have to suffer anymore. I just wanted to be free.”

Iroha listened, her gaze soft. “I understand. It’s hard. Being a magical girl... it’s not what we thought it would be.”

She reached out, placing a hand over Kuroe’s. “But I have friends who support me. Who fight beside me. That’s why I never felt the need to join them.”

Kuroe looked up, her eyes wide.

Iroha smiled. “When this is over... I hope you’ll leave the Wings. Come to Mikazuki Villa. I’m sure Yachiyo, Tsuruno, Sana, and Felicia would be happy to have you. The more the merrier.”

Kuroe’s breath caught. Her heart swelled with warmth, a feeling she hadn’t felt in a long time. She gave a soft, trembling smile and took Iroha’s hands in hers.

“Thank you,” she whispered. “For your kindness. I won’t let you down.”

Kasumi and Lunaria watched in silence, their expressions gentle.

Lunaria’s voice echoed softly in Kasumi’s mind. *Seems like happy things are ahead for them.*

Kasumi nodded. *Let’s make sure they get there.*

The train continued on, deeper into the heart of Hotel Faint Hope — and whatever truths waited beyond.

Chapter 3: The Cost of Liberation

The train slowed with a soft hiss, its magical hum fading into silence. The doors slid open, revealing a corridor carved from polished obsidian, its walls slick with condensation and etched with faint, glowing runes. The air was colder here — not the chill of wind, but the sterile cold of something unnatural. It smelled of burnt incense, rusted metal, and something faintly sweet, like spoiled fruit.

The small Kyubey hopped off first, her tiny paws making no sound against the stone. Her ears twitched once, then she padded forward with quiet urgency.

The others followed, their footsteps echoing in the silence. The corridor widened into a chamber, and standing near its entrance was a familiar silhouette.

“Rena?” Iroha’s voice broke the stillness, startled and concerned.

Rena turned, her usual sharpness dulled by exhaustion. Her eyes were rimmed with fatigue, her posture tense. “Iroha... I didn’t expect to see you here.”

“What are you doing?” Iroha asked, stepping forward. “Are you with the Wings?”

Rena hesitated, then nodded slowly. “We were. Me, Kaede, and Momoko. We thought they were trying to help magical girls. But now... Kaede and I are trying to get out.”

From behind her, Kaede emerged, staggering slightly. Her skin was pale, her eyes glassy and unfocused. She clutched her side, breathing in shallow gasps.

“Kaede!” Kuroe rushed forward, Iroha close behind. “What’s wrong?”

Rena moved to support her, her voice tight. “She’s been relying on her doppel too much. It’s starting to corrupt her. She’s not well.”

Kaede gave a weak smile, her voice barely audible. “I thought... it would help. I didn’t know it could hurt me.”

Iroha’s heart clenched. She had always suspected there were side effects. The way her own doppel felt — like something barely contained, something that whispered in the back of her mind — had never sat right with her.

“This confirms it,” she murmured. “There’s a cost.”

Kuroe looked down at her hands, flexing her fingers. *I’ve used mine a lot too*, she thought. *If Kaede’s being corrupted... what about me?*

Behind them, Kasumi and Lunaria stood quietly, their eyes fixed on Kaede. Their thoughts flowed between them like a quiet stream beneath the surface.

This confirms what we feared, Kasumi said. They can't control their doppelgangers. Not truly. The corruption is just another form of despair — slower, quieter, but just as lethal.

It's like the soul gem all over again, Lunaria replied. A different shape, but the same poison. The same descent.

The small Kyubey turned a corner and darted ahead, her pace quickening. Without a word, the group followed, their footsteps growing more cautious.

They entered a vast chamber — and froze.

The room was massive, its ceiling lost in shadow. The walls pulsed faintly with magical energy, and suspended from the ceiling and embedded in the walls were dozens of glowing spheres. Each one contained a witch or a witch familiar, their forms twisted and grotesque. Some writhed silently, others floated in eerie stillness. Tubes fed into the spheres, pulsing with dark energy — concentrated despair, harvested and refined.

Rena's voice was hollow. "This is it. The grief-seed farm."

Kaede nodded weakly. "They raise witches here. Feed them negative emotions. Then kill them when they're ripe. It's efficient. Predictable."

Iroha stared, horrified. "But... if the doppel system works, like Touka said... why would they need this?"

No one answered.

Kuroe looked away. "We weren't told everything. We were just told it was necessary."

Kasumi and Lunaria stepped closer to one of the spheres, their eyes reflecting the flickering light. The witch inside twitched, its body a mass of tangled limbs and glowing eyes.

This is... impressive, Kasumi thought. Systematic. Controlled. They've industrialized despair.

But Iroha's right, Lunaria replied. If the APS works, why raise witches? Unless... they're using them for something else.

Kasumi's thoughts darkened. *I don't think they have any reason to let the witches go free and cause destruction. That would be wasteful. Could it be... they're feeding the witches to something? Or someone?*

You mean something like the shadow monster?, Lunaria whispered. Something that consumes witches. Something that grows stronger from them. What a terrifying prospect...

They stepped back, their expressions unreadable, the flickering light casting long shadows across their faces.

Iroha turned to Rena, her voice low but urgent. "Where's Momoko?"

Rena hesitated, her gaze drifting toward the floor. “She’s with Mitama right now. They’re having tea... but it’s not just a casual visit. Momoko wanted to talk to her about Kaede. About the side effects of using doppels.”

She glanced at Kaede, who was still leaning against the wall, her breathing shallow, her eyes distant.

“She’s worried,” Rena continued. “She saw what Kaede’s going through. The way her doppel’s been affecting her. And she thought Mitama might know something — anything — that could help.”

Iroha’s fists clenched at her sides. Her heart was pounding, not just from anger, but from fear. “Then we need to move. We need to find Nemu. And we need to stop this.”

Her voice rang through the chamber, steady and resolute.

At the far end of the room, the small Kyubey stood perfectly still, her gaze steady and unblinking. The flickering light from the grief-seed spheres cast long shadows across her tiny form, but she didn’t flinch.

She was waiting.

She was ready to lead them deeper.

And whatever lay ahead — answers, danger, or something far worse — they would face it together.

The corridor narrowed into a vaulted chamber, its walls lined with flickering lanterns and old, rusted pipes that pulsed faintly with magical energy. The air was thick with tension, the kind that made skin prickle and breath slow. The small Kyubey paused at the threshold, her ears twitching sharply.

Then — a low thud.

A massive figure lumbered into view, blocking the path ahead. It was shaped like a giant teddy bear, its plush fur matted and stitched with glowing runes. Its eyes glowed red, and its arms were reinforced with metallic bands. A worker bear Uwasa.

Kuroe’s breath caught. “Security guard Uwasa,” she muttered. “I’ve seen these before. They’re brutal.”

The Uwasa roared — a guttural, static-laced sound that rattled the chamber walls and sent dust cascading from the ceiling. Its massive plush body surged forward, limbs swinging with unnatural speed, its red eyes glowing like warning sirens. The runes stitched across its fur pulsed violently, reacting to the presence of intruders with a rhythm like a war drum.

Iroha stepped forward, her crossbow already drawn. The weapon shimmered with soft pink light, each bolt infused with healing magic and precision. She fired in rapid succession, the arrows slicing through the air with a melodic hum. Each impact sent ripples of light across the Uwasa’s body, disrupting its magical armor and slowing its advance. The creature snarled, its momentum faltering as the bolts embedded in its limbs glowed and pulsed.

Kuroe didn't hesitate. She spun her batons in a blur, the tips glowing with volatile violet energy. One baton flew from her hand, detonating mid-air in a burst of flame and static, scattering the Uwasa's momentum and forcing it to stagger sideways. The explosion left a trail of scorched fur and flickering runes.

But the Uwasa retaliated. It slammed its oversized paws onto the ground, sending out concentric shockwaves that cracked the stone floor and rippled toward them like a tsunami of force.

Kuroe reacted instantly, slamming a baton into the ground. A shimmering wall of reinforced magic erupted upward, absorbing the shockwave with a resonant hum. The barrier shimmered like glass, refracting the Uwasa's energy into harmless light.

But the creature was relentless. Its limbs elongated, twisting unnaturally like serpents. It slithered around the barrier and wrapped itself around Kuroe, squeezing her tightly with crushing force.

Kuroe yelped, her breath knocked from her lungs. Her body lifted off the ground, dragged toward the creature's gaping maw. Her soul gem pulsed erratically, dark energy swirling around her as wings of shadow began to form on her back.

She closed her eyes, bracing herself to summon her doppel.

"No — stop!" Iroha shouted, her voice cutting through the chaos. "I got you!"

Kuroe's eyes snapped open, startled.

Iroha fired a volley of magic arrows, each one glowing with concentrated healing and kinetic force. They struck the Uwasa's limbs with surgical precision, causing the creature to roar in pain and recoil. The runes on its fur flickered violently.

Kuroe seized the moment. She summoned two batons and sliced through the weakened limbs, freeing herself in a burst of violet sparks. She landed beside Iroha, panting, her knees trembling.

The Uwasa stumbled back, its eyes narrowing with fury. Its limbs began to regenerate, threads of magic stitching its body back together.

Iroha extended her hand. "You don't have to fight alone anymore. Let's do this together."

Kuroe hesitated. The dark energy around her soul gem began to fade. She looked at Iroha's outstretched hand — steady, warm, unwavering.

Then she smiled. A soft, grateful smile. She nodded and took Iroha's hand.

The moment their fingers touched, a surge of light enveloped them. Their souls intertwined, and the world around them shifted.

They were back in Takarazaki.

The streets were quiet, bathed in twilight. Two girls stood side by side, facing a witch's labyrinth. Younger. More uncertain. But together.

Through the connect, their hearts opened.

Iroha saw Kuroe's deepest wish — not power, not glory, but closeness. Trust. She saw the fear Kuroe carried every day: the fear of dying alone, of being too weak to protect herself. She saw how the Wings of the Magius had offered her hope, a promise of safety, of liberation. She saw all the times Kuroe had transformed into a doppel, driven by despair. And she saw how much Kuroe longed to be part of something real. Something like Mikazuki Villa. She wanted to be Iroha's cherished friend.

Iroha's heart ached. *I never knew Kuroe was bottling up all of these feelings... Her wish is so pure. If only I was there for her all this time...*

Kuroe saw Iroha's life — the warmth of shared meals, the laughter during shopping trips, the quiet strength of Yachiyo, the playful chaos of Felicia, the gentle kindness of Sana, the radiant energy of Tsuruno. A life built on trust and support. A life Kuroe had never known, but now yearned for.

Her heart filled with hope. *I wish I was with Iroha, during all of those fun moments with friends...*

Their connect pulsed with clarity. They felt each other's magic, each other's core, each other's essence. Each other's prayers, sadness, rage, hatred, joy, pleasure. And lastly — wishes.

They opened their eyes.

The Uwasa had fully regenerated and crouched low, ready to spring.

Iroha raised her crossbow, now glowing with a dual aura of pink and violet. Kuroe summoned two batons, their edges crackling with hybrid energy. They stepped forward in perfect sync.

“Ready?” Iroha asked.

“Yes! Let's do it!” Kuroe replied.

The Uwasa lunged, its limbs whipping forward like spears.

Iroha smiled calmly. “Let's see what this does now.”

She fired. Her arrows struck the creature's arms, legs, and torso — and then exploded in bursts of radiant light.

Kuroe's eyes widened. “Exploding projectiles... That's my power! You combined my power with yours!”

Iroha turned, her smile warm. “Looks like we synced perfectly. Your turn!”

The Uwasa grew more limbs, elongating them into a net of grasping tendrils.

Kuroe leapt into the air, spun, and hurled her batons. Mid-flight, they multiplied — a rain of violet bolts that pierced the limbs and nailed them to the ground. The creature shrieked, thrashing against its restraints.

“And that looks like my crossbow attacks!” Iroha laughed. “That was amazing, Kuroe!”

Kuroe landed beside her, breathless but exhilarated. “Thank you... I never thought fighting could feel like this. Fun. Exciting.”

Iroha nodded. “That’s because we’re fighting together. Supporting each other. I hope you can see now why I never needed the Wings of the Magius.”

The Uwasa’s limbs began to glow, magical energy building rapidly.

“What is it doing?” Iroha asked.

“Be careful,” Kuroe warned, her eyes narrowing.

The creature roared, unleashing torrents of magical shockwaves through the air and ground.

Kuroe stepped in front of Iroha and slammed a baton into the floor. “Come on!” she shouted, focusing her magic.

A translucent dome erupted around them, shielding them from the blast. Inside, sparkling waves of healing and energy flowed through the air like fireflies.

Iroha reached out, her fingers brushing the sparkles. “So beautiful...” she whispered. “This is a combination of your defensive magic and my healing magic. I feel stronger. More alive.”

“I never knew I could do something like this...” Kuroe murmured, awestruck.

She turned to Iroha. “Let’s finish this. You take the final blow.”

Iroha smiled. “Let me use the power you’ve given me.”

She raised her crossbow, now glowing with pink and black energy — a fusion of their magic. She fired.

The arrows became laser beams. Pink bolts sliced through the air, while black baton-shaped bullets followed, detonating on impact. The explosion lit up the chamber in a cascade of radiant light.

When the smoke cleared, the Uwasa was gone.

They had won.

Iroha lowered her crossbow, letting it vanish in a flash of pink light. She ran to Kuroe and hugged her tightly. “We did it! That was amazing!”

Kuroe stood frozen, startled by the warmth. She wasn’t used to being embraced after a fight. Or praised.

She looked down at her soul gem. Its glow was steadier than before. Something inside her shifted — a quiet affirmation.

She was earning Iroha’s trust.

She smiled and embraced her back. “Yes... We did it... Together.”

From a safe distance, Kasumi and Lunaria stepped forward, their expressions bright with admiration.

“That was awesome!” Kasumi exclaimed, throwing up two enthusiastic thumbs. “Your connect wasn’t just strong — it was transformative, explosive! You two must’ve teamed up before, huh? That kind of synergy doesn’t come out of nowhere.”

Lunaria smiled, her tone more measured but no less sincere. “You didn’t just combine your powers. You evolved them. That’s what happens when magical girls truly understand each other — when their hearts align. Connect isn’t just a spell. It’s a reflection of trust.”

She stepped closer, her gaze thoughtful. “I look forward to seeing how your magic continues to grow. The deeper your bond, the more your abilities will surprise even you.”

Iroha and Kuroe turned to each other, their eyes soft with affection and quiet awe. They didn’t speak — they didn’t need to.

In that moment, they both knew.

They wanted to be together at Mikazuki Villa.

To fight side by side.

To live, not just survive.

And to never be alone again.

As the echoes of battle faded, Iroha and Kuroe stood side by side, their breathing steady but their thoughts restless. The air still shimmered faintly with residual magic, the scent of scorched fabric and ozone lingering like a warning.

Kasumi and Lunaria, Kuroe whispered telepathically. They seemed to know a lot about connect. Too much.

I noticed, Iroha replied. The way Lunaria described our evolution... it felt like she’d experienced it herself.

But they don’t have soul gems, Kuroe thought. And I can’t sense any magical signatures from them. Not even a flicker. And even so, they did not show any fear when the security Uwasa attacked us.

Iroha’s gaze drifted toward the two girls, who now stood quietly at the edge of the corridor, their expressions unreadable. So what are they? Magical girls without soul gems? Or something else entirely?

Mitama checked Kasumi once, didn’t she? Kuroe asked, her brow furrowed.

Yes, Iroha replied. But this morning, before we left, Kasumi told Yachiyo that if she wanted to know what Mitama found... she’d have to ask her directly.

Kuroe’s frown deepened. I wonder what Mitama found...

Before they could reflect further, a sharp gasp shattered the quiet.

Kaede clutched her chest, her knees buckling. Her soul gem pulsed erratically, flickering between light and shadow. Dark veins of magic spiderwebbed across her arms, pulsing with sickly energy. Her eyes glazed over, and a low, distorted voice rasped from her throat.

“No... I don’t want to...”

Her body convulsed violently — and then, with a sound like tearing fabric and shattering glass, her doppel burst forth.

Zola erupted from within her like a nightmare made flesh. A mass of shadow and twisted limbs unfurled, its form towering and grotesque. Its body was a patchwork of thorny vines and stitched cloth, its face a black void with two glowing white dots for eyes and a crescent grin that stretched too wide, too wrong.

“Kaede!” Rena screamed, rushing forward. “It’s me! You’re okay! Just breathe!”

But Kaede — or rather, Zola — didn’t respond.

“Kaede?” Rena’s voice cracked, her steps faltering. Her eyes were wide with confusion, her hands trembling.

Zola turned toward her, its head tilting with eerie curiosity. Then, without warning, thorned vines erupted from the ground, coiling around Rena’s legs and arms with terrifying speed.

“Kaede!? What are you doing? It’s me, Rena — your friend!”

Zola’s grin widened. It let out a hollow, inhuman laugh — a sound like wind through a broken music box — and the vines constricted, lifting Rena off the ground.

“Ahhh... Stop... Please...” Rena gasped, struggling against the crushing grip.

Kuroe reacted instantly. She slammed her baton into the ground, summoning a wall of violet energy between Rena and the doppel. The vines recoiled, hissing against the barrier.

Iroha raised her crossbow and fired a trio of glowing arrows. They struck the vines binding Rena, disintegrating them in bursts of healing light. Rena fell to the ground, coughing, but unharmed.

“Thank you... both of you,” she said, scrambling to her feet and retreating to their side.

She looked at Zola, her voice shaking. “She’s not reverting. Usually, when we use our doppels, we come back. Our soul gems clear. But this... this is different. What’s wrong with her?”

Iroha, Kuroe, and Rena braced for combat, their weapons glowing with urgency. The air thickened with magical pressure, the scent of ozone and corrupted magic choking the room. Zola’s form twitched, her vines writhing like serpents, her laughter echoing off the walls.

Then — a voice, calm and clear.

“This is what I meant,” Mitama said, stepping into the chamber. “The side effects of using your doppel too much.”

Everyone turned.

Mitama stood at the entrance, her expression unreadable, her posture composed. Beside her was Momoko, her face pale, her eyes locked on Kaede's monstrous form with a mix of horror and helplessness.

Mitama walked forward, her heels clicking softly against the stone floor. She reached into her coat and pulled out a shimmering handkerchief — delicate, embroidered with intricate runes that shimmered with pale blue light.

Without a word, she began to move the cloth in slow, deliberate arcs around Zola. The doppel's form shimmered, refracted through layers of magical distortion. Mitama's fingers traced a circle in the air, her movements precise, her magic quiet but absolute.

Zola let out a final, distorted shriek — a sound that was part scream, part sob — before her form began to collapse inward. Her limbs folded like paper, her body compressing into a single point of light.

And then — silence.

In her place hovered a containment sphere, identical to the ones they had seen in the grief-seed farm. Inside, Zola's form was suspended in stasis, her chaotic energy sealed away. The sphere pulsed faintly, like a heartbeat muffled by glass.

No one spoke.

Mitama turned, her face unreadable, and placed the sphere onto a wheeled cart. The others followed her in silence, their footsteps echoing hollowly down the corridor.

They entered a sterile room, its walls lined with open slots and softly glowing panels. The air was cold and dry, tinged with antiseptic and magic. The hum of containment fields buzzed faintly in the background.

Above the entrance, glowing letters spelled out the truth:

Doppel Syndrome Isolation Ward

Mitama slid the sphere into an empty slot. It clicked into place with a soft chime, and the panel lit up with Kaede's name.

"There," she said, her voice calm, almost clinical. "Kaede is now safe."

Iroha stared at the sphere, her breath caught in her throat. Kuroe's hands trembled at her sides. Rena's eyes were wide, her mouth slightly open, as if trying to form words that wouldn't come. Even Momoko stood frozen, her expression stricken.

The truth settled over them like frost.

This was the cost.

This was the end result of relying too heavily on their doppels.

Kasumi and Lunaria exchanged a glance, then connected telepathically.

We expected this, Kasumi thought. It's no different than witchification. The girl loses herself. The doppel takes over.

They're just witches in disguise, Lunaria replied. The Wings of the Magius must know this. The question is... how do they plan to cure it?

Or do they? Kasumi wondered. *Maybe containment is all they ever intended.*

They said nothing aloud.

They would continue observing.

For now.

Chapter 4: The Weight of Neutrality

The silence in the isolation ward was suffocating. The soft hum of containment fields buzzed in the background, but no one moved. The glowing sphere that held Zola pulsed faintly in its slot, casting a sickly light across the sterile walls.

Momoko was the first to speak.

“What is the meaning of this?” Her voice cracked with disbelief, but quickly sharpened into anger. “Why didn’t you tell us? Why didn’t you tell anyone this could happen?”

Mitama didn’t flinch. She walked slowly to a nearby couch — a plush, out-of-place thing in the otherwise clinical room — and sat down with practiced grace. Her expression was unreadable, her tone flat.

“I did tell you,” she said. “I said there were side effects. But no one paid much attention.”

Momoko’s fists clenched. “Of course we didn’t pay attention! You never explained what the side effects were. You and the Wings of the Magius just kept saying the APS and the doppel system would liberate us. That we’d be free.”

Mitama crossed one leg over the other, folding her hands in her lap. “I’m not a member of the Wings. I’ve said that before. I’m neutral. I provide adjustments. I don’t dictate ideology.”

Her voice was calm, almost bored. “If magical girls choose to ignore what their doppels are doing to them, that’s not my responsibility.”

Momoko took a step forward, her voice rising. “There it is again. That same excuse. ‘Neutrality.’ You use it to dodge every confrontation, every consequence. You knew this could happen. You watched it happen. And you still did nothing.”

Mitama didn’t respond. Her gaze drifted toward the glowing sphere, her expression unreadable.

Kuroe stood frozen, her eyes locked on the containment unit. Her soul gem trembled faintly in her hand, its glow flickering like a dying ember. She stared at it, her breath shallow.

That could be me, she thought. That could be me next.

Her fingers curled around the gem, as if trying to hold herself together.

Iroha stepped forward, her voice quiet but firm. “Mitama... is there a way to bring Kaede back? To turn her back to normal?”

Mitama tilted her head slightly, as if considering the question. “I don’t know,” she said. “If the Wings’ plan goes as expected, then... yes. All of these girls should return to normal.”

“Should?” Rena’s voice cracked like a whip. She stepped forward, her eyes blazing. “You’re saying you don’t know? That even the leaders of the Wings don’t know?”

Mitama didn’t answer.

Rena’s voice rose, trembling with fury. “Then why are they preaching salvation? Why are they telling girls like us that this is the way out — that this is how we’re saved — if they don’t even know if it works?”

She turned to the isolation sphere, her hands clenched into fists. “This... this is no different than becoming a witch. Kaede’s gone. Her body’s still here, but her mind — her soul — it’s trapped. And you’re calling this ‘safe’?”

Her voice broke. “This isn’t salvation. It’s just a prettier cage.”

She turned back to the others, her eyes wet but defiant. “I made the right call. Running away from the Wings... it was the only thing I’ve done right.”

No one spoke. The truth hung in the air, heavy and undeniable.

Kasumi and Lunaria stood at the edge of the room, silent observers. Their eyes flicked between Mitama and the others, their expressions unreadable.

They’re unraveling, Kasumi thought, her gaze flicking between Momoko’s and Rena’s rising fury and Mitama’s impassive calm. The truth is catching up to them — fast.

Yes, Lunaria replied, her mental voice quiet, almost meditative. *And the tension is rising. I hope it doesn’t escalate into something... irreversible.*

Kasumi’s eyes narrowed slightly. *Yeah, I hope so too. This many magical girls in one place — all emotionally raw, all armed — fighting in a place like this?*

Her gaze drifted to the containment spheres lining the walls, each one pulsing faintly with sealed despair.

It wouldn’t end well.

Lunaria nodded silently, her expression unreadable.

They said nothing aloud.

They would keep watching.

For now.

The sterile hum of the isolation ward lingered in the air, but it was no longer the only sound. Rena's voice rang out, sharp and trembling.

"You're a monster."

Momoko stepped forward, her eyes burning. "How can you be so apathetic? These girls... these doppelified magical girls — they trusted you. You adjusted their soul gems, helped them attune to the APS. And now you act like they're not your problem at all. Do their lives mean nothing to you?"

Mitama didn't respond right away. She sat still, her gaze lowered, her hands folded neatly in front of her.

Then she looked up and stood.

Her eyes met theirs — and this time, they weren't empty.

They were heavy. Sad.

"I see," she said quietly. "It's easy for you to call me a monster."

Her voice trembled, just slightly. Her hands clenched at her sides.

"You don't understand anything."

Rena and Momoko faltered. The heat in their voices cooled. They hadn't expected emotion — not from Mitama. Not like this.

"What do you mean?" Momoko asked, her voice softer now.

Mitama turned slowly, her gaze sweeping across the room. Her eyes lingered on each isolation sphere, each flickering pulse of sealed despair.

She took a breath. Then another.

And then she closed her eyes.

"I'll show you."

The room dimmed.

A soft ripple of magic spread outward from Mitama's soul gem, enveloping the others in a gentle wave. Iroha, Kuroe, Momoko, and Rena felt their consciousness shift — not violently, but like falling into a dream.

They opened their eyes.

They were no longer in the sterile isolation ward. The air around them had shifted — softer, heavier, tinged with something ancient and sorrowful. They were floating, not in space, but in a realm suspended between memory and magic. Above and below stretched a vast, ethereal landscape, bathed in soft starlight and endless twilight. The sky was neither day nor night, but something in between — a dusky canvas of violet and silver, where stars pulsed like quiet heartbeats.

Tents dotted the horizon, each glowing faintly with a different hue. Some shimmered with warm gold, others flickered with icy blue or deep crimson. They were arranged in no particular order, scattered like constellations across a dreamscape of mist and silence. The ground beneath them was not solid, but a gentle ripple of light — like walking on the surface of a still lake.

“This is where I go,” Mitama’s voice echoed, soft and distant, yet unmistakably hers. “Every time I attune to a magical girl.”

She walked among the tents, her figure graceful and solitary, her long coat trailing behind her like a shadow. The others followed, their steps light, their senses overwhelmed by the quiet beauty of the place. It was peaceful — but not comforting. There was a weight here. A sadness that hung in the air like fog.

Each tent represented a soul — a girl she had helped. A girl she had seen. Iroha, Kuroe, Momoko, and Rena looked around, their eyes wide. The tents pulsed gently, like breathing. Some were bright and steady. Others flickered, unstable. A few were nearly dark.

Mitama stopped at one.

The curtain fluttered gently, as if stirred by a breeze that didn’t exist.

She reached out and pulled it aside.

Inside was darkness.

Not empty — but full. Full of pain. Despair. Memories twisted by grief. A girl sat inside, her back to them, her shoulders trembling. She was smiling, laughing even, but the sound was hollow. Her eyes shimmered, but they were drowning. Her soul gem sat beside her, cracked and dim, pulsing with a rhythm that felt like a countdown.

“I see everything,” Mitama whispered. “Even when they don’t say a word. Even when they smile and pretend they’re fine.”

She stepped inside the tent, and the darkness surged toward her. Shadows clung to her limbs, whispering, pulling, trying to drag her down. Her breath caught, her form flickering as if the weight of the girl’s despair was physically pressing against her.

The others watched in stunned silence.

Iroha’s hand flew to her mouth. Her eyes shimmered with tears, not just for the girl in the tent — but for Mitama. *She’s not just seeing this... she’s feeling it. Carrying it.*

Kuroe's breath hitched. "She's absorbing their pain," she murmured. "Not just observing it. She's letting it touch her."

Momoko's voice was quiet, almost reverent. "I thought she was detached. Cold. But she's been walking through this... every day?"

Rena's fists unclenched, her anger dissolving into something softer. "She's not just helping them. She's drowning with them."

They watched as Mitama struggled to stay upright, her body trembling under the weight of the girl's suffering. The shadows whispered things none of them could hear — but they could feel the pressure, the ache, the loneliness.

Mitama stepped back, trembling, and closed the curtain.

"I realized the only way to keep helping... was to close my heart."

The tent faded. Another appeared. Then another. Hundreds. Thousands. The landscape shifted, revealing rows upon rows of glowing tents, each one a story, a burden, a girl on the edge.

"I became the coordinator," Mitama said. "The one who never flinched. Who never cried. Who never judged. Because if I did... I wouldn't survive."

Iroha's hand instinctively reached for her own soul gem, her heart aching. She had always seen Mitama as distant, enigmatic — but now she saw the truth. Mitama wasn't cold. She was drowning in empathy, and had built walls to keep herself from collapsing.

Kuroe's eyes shimmered. She had always feared being alone, feared becoming like Kaede. But now she saw that Mitama had been alone all along — surrounded by pain, yet never allowed to share her own.

Momoko's breath caught. She had accused Mitama of apathy, of indifference. But now she saw the cost of neutrality. It wasn't cowardice. It was survival.

Rena's fists unclenched. Her anger softened into something quieter. She had called Mitama a monster. But monsters didn't cry. Monsters didn't carry the weight of hundreds of broken souls.

Mitama turned to face them, her eyes glistening.

"When the Wings of the Magius reached out to me," she said, "I felt hope for the first time since I became a coordinator."

The realm shimmered, and the tents began to fade, replaced by a vast, open space — a field of stars and silence.

"If their plan worked... if the APS could truly liberate magical girls... then maybe I wouldn't have to see so much suffering. Maybe I could help without breaking."

She looked at Iroha, Kuroe, Momoko, and Rena.

Her voice trembled.

“I still want to believe. That this will work. That these girls will come back. That I didn’t help build a system that only traps them.”

Her eyes shimmered with tears — small, but real.

“I helped the Wings out of desperation. Because I didn’t know what else to do.”

The realm pulsed once, then began to dissolve. The tents faded into mist. The stars dimmed.

And the girls opened their eyes.

They were back in the isolation ward.

But something had changed.

They had seen Mitama’s heart. They saw Mitama as a witness, a bearer of pain, a girl who had chosen to keep walking through the darkness so others wouldn’t have to walk alone.

And now, they carried a piece of it with them.

Kasumi and Lunaria stood at the edge of the group, just a few paces behind the others. Though they kept a quiet distance, they were close enough to feel the emotional shifts radiating from Iroha, Kuroe, Momoko, and Rena — close enough to hear the tremble threading through Mitama’s voice.

Mitama’s confession still lingered in the air like incense — fragile, fragrant, and impossible to ignore.

Kasumi’s gaze drifted toward the others, who stood in stunned silence. Iroha’s hands were clasped tightly in front of her. Kuroe’s eyes shimmered with quiet fear. Rena and Momoko looked shaken, their anger softened into something more vulnerable.

So she finally showed them, Kasumi thought, her mental voice low and reflective. *The truth behind her silence. The weight she’s been carrying all this time.*

Lunaria nodded, her eyes sweeping across the rows of glowing spheres. *Most magical girls’ pain — their outbursts, their despair — it’s not weakness. It’s the residue of suffering. Of surviving things no one else sees.*

Kasumi’s gaze lingered on one of the spheres, its pulse slow and steady. *Each of these girls carries a burden. Some wear it openly. Others bury it so deep they forget it’s there. But Mitama saw it all. And she chose to keep going.*

Lunaria’s expression softened. *Now that they’ve seen her truth... how will they respond?*

Kasumi didn’t answer right away. Her eyes flicked toward Iroha and Kuroe, still watching Mitama with quiet awe.

I hope they carry it with grace, she finally replied. *Not just her pain — but the understanding that comes with it.*

They stood in silence, the hum of the ward surrounding them like a heartbeat.

They would not interfere.

But they would remember.

And they would keep watching.

For now.

The silence in the isolation ward was no longer cold. It had shifted — softened — like the hush that follows a storm, when the air is thick with the scent of rain and the world feels momentarily suspended. The hum of containment fields still pulsed faintly in the background, but it no longer dominated the space. Something else filled the room now: understanding.

Momoko stepped forward first.

Her boots echoed softly against the polished floor, but her expression was gentle, her movements unhurried. She stopped in front of Mitama, who stood still, her hands folded, her eyes still damp from the tears she hadn't meant to show.

Without a word, Momoko reached out and wrapped her arms around her.

Mitama stiffened — not out of rejection, but surprise. Her breath caught in her throat, and for a moment, she didn't move. She had spent so long behind a curtain of professionalism, of distance, that the warmth of another person's embrace felt foreign. But slowly, her shoulders relaxed, and she allowed herself to lean into it.

"Thank you," Momoko whispered. "For showing us. For trusting us with your pain."

She pulled back just enough to meet Mitama's eyes. "And I'm sorry. For what I said earlier. I didn't understand. I called you a monster when I didn't even try to see who you really were."

Mitama opened her mouth, but no words came. Her throat felt tight, her heart full.

Rena stepped forward next, her arms crossed, but her posture less defensive than before. She looked at Mitama, then away, then back again.

"I... I said the same thing," she muttered. "Called you a monster. I was angry. Scared. But I get it now. Why you act the way you do. Why you had to shut everything out."

She rubbed the back of her neck, her voice softening. "I'm sorry too."

Mitama blinked, her vision blurring again. She hadn't expected this. Not from them. Not after everything.

"You don't have to be alone," Momoko said, her voice steady. "You've carried so much by yourself. But you don't have to anymore."

Rena nodded. "We can help. We want to. If you'll let us."

“We’d like to be your friends,” Momoko added, smiling.

Mitama’s lips parted, trembling. She raised a hand to her cheek and wiped away the tears that had begun to fall again — not from pain this time, but from something gentler. Something warmer.

“Thank you,” she said, her voice barely above a whisper. “I... I’ve never had anyone say that to me. Not like this.”

She looked down at her hands, as if seeing them for the first time. “I’ve always interacted with magical girls through business. Adjustments. Grief seed exchanges. I was useful, so they came to me. But I never thought... I never thought anyone would want to stay.”

She looked up again, her eyes shining. “I’m happy. Truly. Thank you.”

She turned then, her steps slow and deliberate, and walked toward the isolation sphere that held Zola. The others followed her gaze as she approached the glowing orb, its surface pulsing with a faint, rhythmic light. Inside, Kaede’s doppel form floated in stasis, her features distorted by shadow and sorrow.

Mitama reached out and placed her hand gently against the sphere.

“There’s nothing I can safely do for her right now,” she said. “If I tried to adjust her soul gem in this state... I’d be pulled in. Consumed by Zola.”

Her voice was calm, but tinged with regret.

“All we can do is wait. If the Wings of the Magius’ plan works... if it really works... then maybe she’ll come back.”

The others stood in silence, the weight of helplessness settling over them like a second skin. The isolation ward, once sterile and clinical, now felt suspended in time — a place where grief and hope mingled in equal measure. Iroha looked to Kuroe. Kuroe to Rena. Rena to Momoko. No one had an answer. No one knew what to do next.

Then, softly, Iroha spoke.

“Yachiyo came to Hotel Faint Hope with me, Kuroe, Kasumi, and Lunaria,” she said, her voice steady but quiet. “She stayed behind to hold off the Amane sisters so the rest of us could get in. Let’s wait for her. She’ll know what to do.”

Momoko’s eyes widened. “Wait... Yachiyo’s coming here?”

Iroha nodded.

“What does she plan to do?” Momoko asked, her voice tinged with urgency.

Kuroe stepped forward, her gaze thoughtful. “She wants to find Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno. They didn’t come back after visiting the Memory Museum yesterday. Yachiyo’s worried the Wings manipulated them into joining. She wants to bring them home.”

Rena let out a dry chuckle. “Good to know I’m not the only one trying to leave this place.”

Mitama closed her eyes and chuckled softly, the sound tinged with melancholy. “Ah... Yachiyo. I imagine she’ll give me an earful when she sees all the doppelified girls here. She always did have a sharp tongue when it came to things like this.”

Momoko walked over and placed a hand gently on Mitama’s shoulder. “Don’t worry. If she comes here, I’ll talk to her. I’m sure she’ll listen. We were teammates once. She’ll understand if we speak honestly.”

Mitama opened her eyes and looked at Momoko with quiet warmth. “Thank you, Momoko... my friend.”

She paused, the word lingering on her tongue like something unfamiliar but welcome.

“Ah, it still feels strange,” she added with a small laugh. “I suppose I’ll have to get used to calling people friends.”

Momoko and Rena both laughed, the sound light and genuine.

“Yes,” Momoko said, “and maybe work on suppressing your apathy and business mindset when appropriate.”

Rena smirked. “You’re not a grief seed vendor right now. You’re one of us.”

Mitama smiled, her eyes soft. “I’ll try.”

Kasumi and Lunaria stood nearby, watching, listening. They had said nothing during the exchange, but their eyes had followed every word, every gesture. There was a quiet joy in their expressions — the kind that came from seeing something fragile begin to heal.

Mitama turned to them now, her posture relaxing.

“It’s nice to meet you again, Kasumi,” she said with a small smile.

Kasumi brightened immediately, her voice warm and full of life. “Nice to see you too! Your story... it was really touching. I’m glad you shared it. And I hope you get the support you need from your new friends.”

She glanced at the rows of isolation spheres, her smile fading just slightly. “And what I said yesterday still stands. I really do hope the Wings’ plan works. For the sake of all the girls here.”

Mitama chuckled softly, the sound light but sincere. “Thank you. I hope so too.”

Her gaze shifted to Lunaria, and her smile deepened with recognition.

“And you... I remember you. From the talent show. You performed after Kasumi, didn’t you?”

Lunaria nodded, her expression gentle.

“I watched the broadcast with Touka and Mifuyu,” Mitama continued. “Your performance... it felt like you were speaking directly to my soul. It soothed something I didn’t even know was hurting.”

Lunaria’s smile warmed, and she bowed gracefully. “I’m glad it reached you. That’s what I hoped it would do.”

Momoko and Rena, who had been quietly listening, stepped forward. They hadn’t met these two before, but they recognized them from the talent show — the same one they had watched live, though not with Iroha’s group.

“I’m Momoko Togame,” Momoko said, offering her hand. “It’s nice to meet you both.”

“Rena Minami,” Rena added, giving a small wave. “You two were amazing on stage.”

Kasumi grinned. “Thanks! I’m Kasumi Hoshizora. And this is my good friend Lunaria.”

Lunaria bowed her head slightly. “It’s a pleasure.”

For a moment, the ward felt less like a prison and more like a gathering place — a quiet sanctuary where pain was acknowledged, and connection was possible. The containment spheres still pulsed softly in the background, reminders of the battles yet to be won. But here, in this moment, there was warmth. There was understanding. There was friendship.

They didn’t know what would happen next.

But for now, they were together.

And that was enough

The warmth in the isolation ward lingered, fragile but real. The containment spheres still pulsed softly in the background, but the tension that had once filled the room had thinned, replaced by something gentler — the quiet hum of connection.

Momoko tilted her head, curiosity flickering in her eyes. “So... I heard you’re an adventurer,” she said, turning to Kasumi. “Is that true? You’ve traveled the world?”

Kasumi’s eyes lit up instantly. She straightened her posture, placed one hand dramatically on her hip, and beamed.

“Indeed I have!” she declared, her voice theatrical and full of flair. “From the snowy peaks of the Himalayas to the sun-drenched ruins of Machu Picchu, from the neon-lit alleyways of Shinjuku to the whispering sands of the Sahara — I’ve wandered, stumbled, danced, and occasionally tripped my way across this beautiful planet! And my good friend Lunaria here has been with me through all of it!”

Lunaria chuckled softly beside her, her expression fond. “She’s not exaggerating. Well... not much.”

Kasumi continued, her eyes sparkling. “I’ve bartered with witches in the backstreets of Prague, learned underwater breathing techniques from a sea-bound shrine maiden in Okinawa, and once — I kid you not — helped a magical girl in Iceland tame a frost monster that lived inside a glacier. It sang opera. Badly.”

Momoko blinked. “Wait, what?”

Rena leaned forward, eyes wide. “You’re joking.”

Kasumi grinned. “I never joke about opera-singing ice monsters.”

Lunaria nodded solemnly. “It was... memorable.”

The room burst into laughter — not loud, but genuine. Even Mitama smiled, her shoulders relaxing as the tension melted further.

But then Kasumi’s tone shifted, her voice softening.

“One reason I travel,” she said, “is to learn. Not just about cultures and landscapes — but about magical techniques, rituals, and fighting styles. I try to understand how magical girls live, how they survive, how they carry their burdens.”

She looked around the room, her gaze gentle but steady. “Wherever I go, I try to keep up with magical girls and their struggles. I listen. I learn. I remember.”

Iroha’s heart stirred. She remembered Kasumi saying something similar at Banbanzai, after the talent show — how she wanted to understand magical girls, not just observe them. Kuroe glanced at her, and they exchanged a quiet smile. Mitama, too, nodded slowly, recalling the conversation she’d had with Kasumi in her shop just yesterday.

Momoko and Rena were silent for a moment, taken aback by the sincerity in Kasumi’s voice.

“You’ve met magical girls all over the world?” Momoko asked.

Kasumi nodded. “Some I helped. Some helped me. I still remember all their names.”

Rena looked her up and down, then glanced at Lunaria. “But... are you magical girls?”

Momoko leaned in. “You don’t have soul gems. And you don’t emit any magical energy. So... who are you? Why are you here?”

Before Kasumi or Lunaria could answer, Mitama chuckled softly.

“It’s no use asking,” she said, her voice light but knowing. “I asked Kasumi the same question yesterday. I even ran some check-ins and tests. Everything points to her not being a magical girl.”

Momoko blinked. “Seriously?”

Mitama nodded. “But she knows a lot. More than most. Probably from her travels. She understands magical girls — their struggles, their burdens. And most importantly, she’s empathetic. Her performance at the talent show was proof of that.”

She turned to Lunaria, her gaze thoughtful. “And if Lunaria is Kasumi’s friend, I assume she’s the same.”

Kasumi and Lunaria exchanged a glance, then smiled.

“Thank you for the explanation,” Kasumi said. “And for not digging deeper.”

Lunaria added, “Everyone has their secrets, after all.”

Kasumi’s eyes twinkled. “Just like your story, Mitama. You kept it secret until now.”

Mitama laughed, the sound soft and self-aware. “True. But since I revealed mine... will you kindly do the same?”

Kasumi placed a hand over her heart, mock solemn. “Alas, we cannot.”

Lunaria bowed her head slightly. “At least... not yet.”

There was a pause — brief, but full of meaning.

Iroha’s eyes sparkled. Kuroe’s lips curled into a quiet smile. Mitama tilted her head, intrigued.

“Not yet,” Mitama repeated, her voice warm. “I’ll take that as a promise.”

Kasumi winked. “You’re welcome to.”

For a moment, the ward felt like something else entirely — not a place of containment, but a place of possibility. The girls stood together, not as strangers, but as companions on the edge of something new.

They didn’t know what would happen next.

But for now, they were together.

And that was enough.

The warmth in the isolation ward lingered, but curiosity had begun to stir beneath it — quiet, insistent, like a breeze rustling through tall grass. Momoko and Rena found themselves studying Kasumi and Lunaria more closely now, their eyes tracing the contours of their expressions, the way they stood with effortless poise, the way their smiles never faltered.

There was something about them — something that didn’t quite fit.

No soul gems. No magical aura. No visible weapons or transformation marks. And yet, they moved with the calmness of seasoned veterans, spoke with the insight of those who had seen too much, and carried themselves with the grace of people who had nothing to prove.

Momoko leaned slightly toward Rena, her voice low. “They’re not magical girls. But they’re not normal either.”

Rena nodded slowly. “I know. I can feel it.”

Then — a ripple of thought.

Iroha's voice, soft and clear, echoed in their minds.

Thank you, Mitama, she said telepathically. For sharing your experience with Kasumi. It's good to know she doesn't seem to be a magical girl, at least from your check-ins. Even if that doesn't tell us much about who she and Lunaria truly are.

Kuroe joined her, her tone thoughtful. *Yachiyo and I have had suspicions too. We've seen things. Felt things. But so far... there's no trace of evil intent from either of them.*

They've been kind, Iroha added. Empathetic. And they've helped us.

That's why we agreed to bring them with us, Kuroe continued. We hoped that by staying close, we'd learn more about who they are. What they can do.

There was a pause — not of hesitation, but of memory.

They told us, Iroha said, that if something bad were to happen to them... we shouldn't try to rescue them. We should leave them be.

Which means, Kuroe added, they have some way of protecting themselves. Some ability we don't understand.

Momoko's eyes narrowed slightly. *That's... unusual.*

Mitama's mental voice joined them, calm and curious. *There's more, isn't there?*

Iroha nodded, her thoughts steady. *When Kuroe and I reached the entrance of Hotel Faint Hope, the Amane sisters opened a portal. Yachiyo stayed behind to hold them off, told us to go through quickly.*

We did, Kuroe said. But when we entered... Kasumi and Lunaria were already inside.

We didn't see them enter, Iroha added. Neither did Yachiyo. And the Amane sisters didn't react either.

There was a beat of silence.

No normal human could move that fast, Kuroe finished.

Momoko, Rena, and Mitama absorbed the information in quiet awe.

So they have some kind of special power, Momoko thought. Even if it's not magical energy. Speed, at the very least. Enough to escape when needed.

But what kind of speed? Rena wondered. And how does it work?

Mitama's thoughts were calm, almost amused. *They're still smiling. As if none of this concerns them.*

Indeed, Kasumi and Lunaria stood nearby, their expressions warm and serene. They hadn't interrupted. Hadn't reacted. If they suspected the girls of having a secret telepathic exchange — and most likely they did — they gave no sign of discomfort. No sign of offense.

They simply waited.

As if they had nothing to hide.

Or perhaps, as if they had everything to hide — but trusted the others enough to let the questions come.

Kasumi tilted her head slightly, her eyes meeting Iroha's with quiet affection. Lunaria's gaze drifted toward Kuroe, then to Mitama, her smile soft and knowing.

They didn't speak.

They didn't need to.

And somehow, that silence said more than words ever could.

We should keep tabs on them, Mitama's voice echoed gently in the minds of Iroha, Kuroe, Momoko, and Rena. Kasumi and Lunaria. They'll reveal something eventually. Especially here, in the Wings of the Magius headquarters.

Her tone was calm, but beneath it lay a thread of caution.

If Yachiyo is trying to bring Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno back to Mikazuki Villa... Touka won't take that lightly. She doesn't tolerate "traitors."

The word hung in the air like a blade.

Magical girls who defy her... who try to leave... they're punished with isolation. Just like the girls in this ward.

Kuroe flinched.

Her breath caught, and she looked down at her soul gem, fingers curling around it protectively. The memory of the Amene sisters calling her a traitor still echoed in her mind — sharp, cruel. Her Magius emblem had gone black.

I hope nothing bad happens, she thought, her voice trembling. Not to me. Not to any of us.

Iroha turned to her, her eyes soft and steady.

We'll be okay, she said. Once Yachiyo gets here, we'll figure things out. We'll be together. And even if something does happen... maybe we'll finally get a glimpse of what Kasumi and Lunaria really are.

Kuroe looked at her, and for a moment, the fear in her eyes softened.

Thanks, she whispered. I feel better now.

The others nodded, their thoughts quiet but resolute.

Momoko's gaze lingered on Kasumi and Lunaria, who stood nearby, still smiling, still serene. Rena crossed her arms, her expression thoughtful. Mitama's eyes narrowed slightly, not in suspicion, but in quiet calculation.

They didn't know who Kasumi and Lunaria truly were.

But they knew enough to wait.

To watch.

To trust — cautiously, but sincerely.

Chapter 5: Reunion

The air was thick with smoke and magic.

Yachiyo stood in the center of the ruined labyrinth, her breath steady, her lance dripping with the remnants of battle. The witch Durbar lay cleaved in two, her grotesque form dissolving into shadow and ash. The final echo of her scream faded into silence, leaving only the hum of residual energy and the stunned gasps of the Amane sisters.

“How...?” Tsukuyo whispered, her voice trembling.

“How could you defeat Durbar so easily?” Tsukasa added, her eyes wide with disbelief.

Yachiyo didn't answer.

She stepped forward, her boots crunching against the fractured floor as Durbar's labyrinth began to unravel around her. The walls shimmered, then collapsed into mist. Her eyes locked onto the grief seed that pulsed faintly on the ground — the last remnant of Durbar's despair. She knelt, picked it up, and pressed it to her soul gem. A soft glow enveloped her, purifying the darkness that had begun to creep along its edges.

Then she stood.

Her gaze turned to the sisters — sharp, unflinching, and full of intent.

They were next.

The Amane sisters recoiled, their hands trembling. They had seen Yachiyo fight before, but never like this. Never with this kind of precision. This kind of fury.

Yachiyo dashed forward, her movements a blur. Before either sister could react, she struck — not with the blade, but with the blunt end of her lance. One blow to Tsukuyo's belly, another to Tsukasa's neck. Both girls crumpled to the ground, unconscious.

Yachiyo knelt beside them, her expression unreadable. She reached into Tsukasa's coat and retrieved her Magius emblem — a small, glowing badge etched with runes. She held it up, and a portal shimmered into existence before her, its edges flickering like candlelight.

She stepped through.

The world shifted.

Yachiyo found herself in a long, elegant hallway — the kind that belonged in a luxury hotel. The walls were paneled with polished wood, the floor carpeted in deep crimson. Soft lighting glowed from ornate sconces, casting warm shadows across the corridor. The air smelled faintly of lavender and old paper, like a place meant to soothe but not to comfort.

But Iroha and Kuroe were nowhere in sight.

Yachiyo's brow furrowed. *They must have gone deeper in, she thought. Or I entered through a different portal.*

She walked slowly, her footsteps muffled by the carpet. Her eyes scanned each door, each corner, but her thoughts drifted inward.

I've lost friends before, she thought. Mel. Kanae. So many.

Her grip tightened on her lance.

I can't lose anyone else.

She paused at a junction, her heart pounding.

Iroha. Kuroe. Sana. Felicia. Tsuruno. Please be safe.

She turned the corner — and stopped.

There, standing in the middle of the hallway, were three familiar figures.

Sana. Felicia. Tsuruno.

Yachiyo's breath caught. Her eyes filled with tears before she could stop them. She ran forward, her lance clattering to the floor, and pulled all three girls into a tight embrace.

"You're alright," she whispered. "Thank goodness. I thought... I thought something happened to you."

Sana blinked, surprised. Felicia grinned. Tsuruno laughed softly.

"It's good to see you too, Yachiyo," Felicia said. "But... what are you doing here?"

"Where's Iroha?" Sana asked gently.

"Did you join the Wings?" Tsuruno added, tilting her head.

Yachiyo pulled back, wiping her eyes. "No. I came here with Iroha and Kuroe. We're here to find you — to bring you home. Back to Mikazuki Villa."

She paused, her voice softening.

"And... if possible, Iroha wants to meet with Nemu. One of the leaders. Nemu told Kuroe to find the rumor of the Hidden Sakura — something she created to protect Iroha. Nemu was one of Iroha's childhood friends. Like Touka. Iroha hopes Nemu might know something about Ui."

The girls fell silent.

Felicia was the first to speak.

“I’m not leaving,” she said, her voice firm. “Not yet. Not until I learn how to not become a witch.”

Yachiyo’s eyes dimmed. “Felicia...”

“I don’t trust the Wings completely,” Felicia continued. “But their plan — their promise of salvation — it’s the only thing that makes sense right now. I want to understand it.”

Yachiyo stepped closer, her voice low. “The doppels they promote... they’re dangerous. You must have felt it yourself, right? How they get harder to control the more you use them?”

Felicia nodded. “I know. But at least the doppel system stops us from becoming witches, right? That’s something.”

Yachiyo opened her mouth, but no words came.

She looked to Sana and Tsuruno.

They both nodded.

“We don’t feel as strongly as Felicia,” Sana said. “But... the Wings’ promise gives us hope. Hope that maybe we won’t have to keep living in fear.”

Tsuruno added, “It’s not perfect. But it’s something.”

Yachiyo stood in silence, her heart heavy.

She had found them.

But they did not want to come home.

Yachiyo stood in silence, her heart heavy, her thoughts tangled. She had found her friends — but not the answers she needed. Felicia’s resolve, Sana’s quiet hope, Tsuruno’s cautious optimism... they all stood before her, and yet the distance between them felt vast.

She opened her mouth, searching for words.

And then — a ripple of thought.

Yachiyo? Iroha’s voice, soft and familiar, echoed in her mind.

Can you hear us? Kuroe added.

Yachiyo blinked, startled. Her grip tightened on her lance.

Iroha? Kuroe? she replied telepathically. *Yes... I can hear you. I’m with Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno.*

A wave of relief washed through the connection.

You found them, Iroha said, her voice warm. *Thank goodness.*

We have something to share, Kuroe added. Something important. For all of you.

Yachiyo nodded, then turned to the others.

“Give me a moment,” she said aloud. “I’m extending the telepathic link.”

She closed her eyes, focused, and gently reached out. The connection expanded, threading through the minds of Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno like a soft breeze.

Can you hear us? Iroha asked.

Yes, Sana replied, her voice quiet.

Loud and clear, Felicia muttered.

This is so weird, Tsuruno added, half amused.

Iroha’s tone shifted, growing more serious.

We’ve learned something about the Wings of the Magius. About the doppel system. About what’s happening behind the scenes.

There was a pause.

They have witch farming facilities, Kuroe said. Places where they contain witches and familiars in isolation spheres. They feed them negative emotions. And then... they kill them. For grief seeds.

The silence that followed was deafening.

Yachiyo’s breath caught.

Sana’s eyes widened.

Tsuruno’s smile faded.

Felicia’s fists clenched.

Systematic grief seed farming? Yachiyo thought. *But if the doppel system prevents magical girls from becoming witches... why would they need this?*

Exactly, Iroha said. *It doesn’t add up.*

We think there might be another reason, Kuroe added. *Something more serious. Something they haven’t told anyone.*

Felicia’s voice cut through the telepathic link, sharp and trembling.

How dare they.

Her fists shook at her sides, her soul gem pulsing faintly with emotion.

How dare the Wings of the Magius raise witches like that. Like livestock. Like tools.

Her breath was ragged, her thoughts burning. *Witches are monsters. They destroy everything. And now the Wings are feeding them? Keeping them alive?*

Yachiyo turned toward her, her expression softening. Felicia's hatred was fierce, raw — and deeply personal. She didn't need to understand the origin of it to feel its weight.

Each of those witches, Yachiyo said quietly, used to be a magical girl. Someone like us. Someone who broke. And now they're being trapped. Raised. Just to be killed.

Her voice trembled.

It's terrible.

Sana's thoughts were quiet, but heavy. *I thought the Wings wanted to save us. All of us. But this...*

Tsuruno's voice was subdued. *It doesn't feel like salvation. It feels like something else.*

The telepathic link pulsed with emotion — grief, anger, confusion. The truth had cracked something open. And though the answers were still out of reach, the questions had begun to take shape.

They stood together in the quiet hallway, the soft lighting casting long shadows around them. The scent of lavender and old paper lingered in the air, but it no longer felt soothing. It felt like a mask.

The telepathic link pulsed again, steady and clear.

That's not all, Iroha said, her voice quieter now, but tinged with urgency.

After we entered the portal, Kuroe added, we ran into Rena and Kaede. But something was wrong. Kaede... she lost control.

Yachiyo's breath caught.

Her doppel — Zola — completely took over, Iroha continued. *She wasn't herself anymore. It was like watching a witch emerge from inside her.*

Mitama and Momoko appeared just in time, Kuroe said. *Mitama contained Kaede inside an isolation sphere and placed her in something called the Doppel Syndrome Isolation Ward.*

There was a pause — heavy, reverent.

Mitama explained that if magical girls use their doppels too much, Iroha said, *they become "doppelified." Their doppel takes complete control. They lose themselves. And they have to be contained.*

Yachiyo's eyes darkened. Her grip on her lance tightened.

To us, Kuroe said, *doppelified magical girls are no different than witches.*

Mitama doesn't know if the Wings' plan will turn them back to normal, Iroha added. *But she's still holding onto hope.*

Yachiyo grimaced.

She had known. She had felt it in her bones — the danger of relying on the doppel system. She had confronted Mitama about it just the day before, pressing her for answers. But Mitama, ever the neutral coordinator, had deflected. Had smiled. Had said little.

And now the truth was laid bare.

Felicia's voice rang out, sharp and resolute.

Then I'm done.

She stepped forward, her fists clenched, her soul gem pulsing with conviction.

I can't stay here. Not after hearing all this. I'm going back to Mikazuki Villa.

Yachiyo turned to her, her heart swelling.

Sana nodded. *Me too.*

Tsuruno smiled softly. *I'm with you.*

Yachiyo's eyes shimmered. She hadn't known how to reach them. How to convince them. But Iroha and Kuroe had done it — not with persuasion, but with truth.

Thank you, she said, her voice warm. *I wouldn't have known how to bring them back otherwise.*

We're glad, Iroha replied. *Mitama isn't hostile. She's letting us stay in the Isolation Ward. It's peaceful there. You should come.*

Momoko's excited to see you again, Kuroe added with a small smile.

Yachiyo nodded. *We'll head there now.*

There was a pause, then a gentle ripple of amusement through the link.

One last thing, Iroha said. *We've all been sharing bits and pieces about Kasumi and Lunaria. Nothing urgent. We'll tell you later.*

Sana chuckled. *So we're finally going to learn more about those two.*

Felicia snorted. *About time.*

Tsuruno grinned. *I've been curious since the talent show.*

Yachiyo smiled, her heart lighter than it had been in days.

Let's go, she said.

And together, they turned down the hallway and got on a train — toward the Doppel Syndrome Isolation Ward. Toward reunion. Toward answers. Toward whatever came next.

The train glided forward with a low hum, its interior dimly lit by soft golden lamps that flickered gently with each turn. Yachiyo sat near the window, her lance resting across her lap, her eyes scanning the passing corridors of the Wings of the Magius headquarters. Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno sat nearby, quiet, contemplative. None of them spoke. The silence between them was not strained — it was heavy, reverent, filled with the weight of everything they had just learned.

The train curved through a wide tunnel, and the walls began to change. The polished wood gave way to glass — thick, reinforced panels that revealed the world beyond. What they saw made their breath catch.

Rows of isolation spheres floated in a vast chamber, suspended like stars in a dark sky. Each sphere contained a witch or a familiar, their twisted forms barely visible through the shimmering surface. The air outside the train was tinged with violet light, pulsing softly with magical energy. Machines lined the walls, humming quietly, feeding the spheres with something unseen.

Yachiyo leaned forward, her hand pressed to the glass.

“This is it,” she whispered. “The witch farming facility.”

Sana’s eyes widened. Tsuruno’s lips parted in disbelief. Felicia’s fists clenched.

They had heard Iroha and Kuroe describe it. But seeing it — seeing the witches suspended like specimens, like fuel — was something else entirely.

Then the train entered a new chamber.

And everything changed.

The space opened into a vast, cathedral-like expanse. The ceiling stretched impossibly high, vanishing into shadow. The walls were carved with strange, organic patterns — veins of white and silver that pulsed faintly, like the heartbeat of something alive.

And in the center of it all stood the witch.

It was enormous. Towering. Its body gleamed with an unnatural whiteness, smooth and pristine like polished ivory, yet disturbingly organic — a fusion of insect and deity. Its wings, vast and symmetrical, unfurled behind it like a ceremonial fan, etched with golden patterns that shimmered in the dim light. A radiant structure rose behind its back, resembling a halo or sunburst, casting long shadows that stretched across the chamber like reaching arms.

Its face was humanoid, but distant — serene, expressionless, and cold. The eyes were closed, as if in prayer or slumber, and its posture was unnaturally still, suspended in a state between life and ritual. It did not move. It did not speak. It simply existed — dormant, waiting.

There was something sacred about it. Something divine. And yet, the longer they looked, the more that divinity felt wrong. Twisted. Like a god sculpted from despair.

Yachiyo’s breath caught in her throat.

Sana gasped.

Tsuruno's eyes widened.

Felicia stood, her soul gem flaring.

"What... is that?" Yachiyo murmured.

None of them had ever seen a witch like this. It was larger than anything they had imagined. Larger than Walpurgisnacht. Larger than despair itself.

Then the witch's mouth opened.

It was slow. Silent. A yawning void of pale light.

And from the far end of the chamber, several isolation spheres began to move.

They floated forward, drawn by an invisible force. Each sphere contained a witch — twisted, broken, pulsing with darkness. They drifted toward the mouth of the great white witch, one by one.

And then they were gone.

Swallowed.

Consumed.

Yachiyo's hand flew to her mouth.

Sana trembled.

Tsuruno stared, frozen.

Felicia screamed.

"No!"

She lunged toward the window, her fists glowing, her voice raw with rage. "You monsters! You're feeding them! You're feeding witches to that thing!"

Sana grabbed her arm. Tsuruno wrapped her arms around her waist.

"Felicia, stop!" Sana cried. "You can't—"

"Calm down!" Tsuruno shouted. "We don't know what it is!"

Felicia struggled, her eyes wild. "I don't care! I won't let them do this!"

Yachiyo closed her eyes, her heart pounding.

She pictured Mel.

Her friend. Her teammate. Her light.

She pictured Mel's witch form — twisted, broken, lost.

And she imagined that form being fed to this thing.

Her hands trembled.

Then — a voice.

Bright. Cheerful. Echoing from the Magius emblems pinned to each of their clothes, the sound rang out with unnatural clarity, cutting through the heavy silence of the train like a bell in a cathedral.

“Hello, fellow magical girls!” Touka’s voice chimed, clear and melodic, almost sing-song in its cadence. “I hope you’re all having a wonderful day!”

The train fell still.

No one spoke. No one moved. The only sound was the soft hum of the tracks beneath them, and the voice that now filled the air like perfume — sweet, cloying, and impossible to ignore.

Touka continued, her tone light, almost playful, as if she were announcing a school festival rather than the culmination of a world-altering plan.

“I have exciting news! The liberation of all magical girls is near! Nemu and I are preparing to awaken an artificial witch named Embryo Eve. She will spread the doppel system across the entire world!”

Yachiyo’s eyes narrowed, her breath catching.

“In just three days,” Touka said, “Embryo Eve will be ready. When she awakens, all witches — even Walpurgisnacht herself — will no longer be a threat. We’ll finally be free. No more despair. No more fear. Just happiness.”

The emblems pulsed once — a soft, synchronized glow — then dimmed.

“Have a great day, everyone!” Touka chirped.

And then she was gone.

Their eyes went wide.

None of them spoke, but the realization hit all at once — a silent, collective breath drawn in horror.

So this was Embryo Eve.

The enormous white witch they had seen, dormant and divine, was not a natural creature born of despair. It was artificial. Constructed. Created, somehow, by Touka and Nemu — the leaders of the Wings of the Magius. And it was being fed. Fed with witches. Fed with former magical girls.

Yachiyo’s gaze remained fixed on the fading view beyond the train’s window, her jaw tight, her thoughts racing. Sana sat beside her, hands folded in her lap, her expression unreadable. Felicia leaned forward, her fists still clenched, her soul gem pulsing faintly with residual anger. Tsuruno stared ahead, her brow furrowed, her usual spark dimmed by the weight of what they had just seen.

None of them had answers.

Only questions.

How does awakening Embryo Eve save magical girls? Yachiyo thought. How does spreading the doppel system across the world prevent despair?

Will magical girls still become doppelified if they use their doppels too much? Sana wondered. Like Kaede did?

Felicia's thoughts burned. *They're feeding witches to a monster. And calling it salvation.*

Tsuruno's mind echoed with doubt. *Touka and Nemu... do they even care what they're sacrificing?*

The train continued forward, its rhythm steady, its path unwavering. But inside, the silence was thick — not with peace, but with contemplation. The kind that settles after a revelation too large to process all at once. The kind that makes the air feel heavier, the light feel dimmer.

Touka and Nemu had a plan.

A grand plan.

But at what cost?

Yachiyo closed her eyes, her thoughts drifting to the girls she had lost. To the ones who had fallen. To the ones who had become witches. She imagined their faces. Their laughter. Their final moments. And she imagined them being fed to Embryo Eve — consumed, erased, repurposed for a future they would never see.

Her heart ached.

Sana looked down at her hands, her voice a whisper in her own mind. *Is this really the only way?*

Felicia's anger had cooled, but the fire remained. *They're using us. All of us.*

Tsuruno exhaled slowly. *We need to know more. We need to understand what they're really planning.*

The train began to slow.

The Isolation Ward was near.

But the questions would follow them.

And the storm was only beginning.

The train came to a slow halt, its doors sliding open with a soft hiss. Yachiyo stepped out first, her boots clicking against the polished floor of the Doppel Syndrome Isolation Ward. The air was sterile, humming faintly with containment magic. The lighting was dim, tinted with violet and silver, casting long shadows across the rows of glowing spheres that lined the chamber.

Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno followed close behind, their eyes wide as they took in the sight.

The isolation spheres pulsed softly, each one containing a magical girl who had succumbed to her doppel — girls suspended in stasis, their expressions frozen in anguish or eerie calm. Some floated peacefully, their forms curled inward like sleeping children. Others writhed, their bodies twisted by despair, their soul gems dark and unstable.

Although Iroha and Kuroe had warned them, seeing it in person was something else entirely.

Felicia's breath hitched. "So many..."

Sana's hands trembled. "They were just like us."

Tsuruno's voice was barely a whisper. "And now they're trapped."

Yachiyo's gaze swept across the ward, her heart tightening. She had seen witches. She had fought them. But this — this was different. These were not monsters born of despair. These were magical girls who had been promised salvation... and instead found themselves sealed away like dangerous artifacts.

Then — movement.

Iroha ran toward them, her eyes wide with relief, her arms outstretched.

"Yachiyo! Sana! Felicia! Tsuruno!"

She reached them and pulled them into a tight embrace, her voice trembling with emotion. "You're okay. Thank goodness. I was so worried."

Yachiyo wrapped her arms around Iroha, her expression softening. Sana smiled and hugged her back. Felicia grinned, her earlier rage momentarily forgotten. Tsuruno laughed, the sound light and genuine.

Kuroe approached quietly, her posture shy but hopeful.

"Hi," she said. "I'm Kuroe. Iroha's friend."

Sana turned to her first, her smile warm. "Nice to meet you, Kuroe."

Felicia gave her a nod. "Welcome to the group."

Tsuruno offered a fist bump. "Glad you're here."

Kuroe's eyes shimmered. She had been alone for so long — drifting, surviving, clinging to the Wings for support. But now, she had friends. Real friends. Just like Iroha.

She didn't need the Wings anymore.

But Yachiyo's gaze had shifted.

She had spotted Mitama.

And the anger returned.

Her steps were swift, her expression hard. She marched across the ward, her lance clutched tightly in one hand, her eyes locked onto the coordinator who stood calmly near the containment spheres.

Mitama turned as Yachiyo approached. She closed her eyes and smiled — not smugly, not dismissively, but with quiet acceptance.

She knew what was coming.

Momoko stepped beside her, her posture protective but gentle.

“Yachiyo,” she said, her voice warm. “It’s good to see you again.”

Yachiyo nodded, her tone clipped. “You too, Momoko. But step aside.”

Momoko hesitated. “Mitama isn’t blameless. I know that. But she’s not heartless either.”

Yachiyo’s eyes narrowed. “She’s one of the reasons these girls are trapped here.”

Mitama opened her eyes.

And for the first time, Yachiyo saw something unexpected.

Sadness.

Real, unguarded sadness.

Mitama didn’t deny it. She didn’t deflect. She simply looked at Yachiyo with eyes that had seen too much — eyes that had once been bright, now dulled by years of quiet suffering.

Momoko spoke gently, her voice steady.

“She had her reasons. Before she partnered with the Wings, she was drowning. Every magical girl she helped... she carried their pain. Their despair. She had to shut herself off just to survive.”

Yachiyo’s grip on her lance loosened.

“When the Wings told her about their plan,” Momoko continued, “about salvation, about the APS and the doppel system... it gave her hope. For the first time since she became a coordinator.”

Mitama nodded slowly. “I agreed to help. Out of desperation. I adjusted soul gems to attune them to the APS. I thought... maybe this would save them.”

Her voice trembled.

“I didn’t know. Not at first. That using doppels too much would lead to this. To containment. To becoming something like a witch.”

She looked at the spheres around her.

“I still hope... that the Wings’ plan will work. That these girls will come back.”

Yachiyo stood in silence.

She had come ready to fight. Ready to accuse. But now, faced with Mitama’s quiet honesty, her anger began to shift.

She thought of her own walls. Her own coldness. The way she kept people at a distance — not out of cruelty, but out of fear. Fear of loss. Fear of grief.

She had lost so many.

Mel. Kanae. Others whose names she still whispered in her sleep.

She looked at Mitama.

“I don’t approve of what you’ve done,” she said. “Of the methods. Of the choices.”

Mitama nodded. “You don’t have to.”

“But I understand you now,” Yachiyo continued. “And maybe... I’m not so different.”

Mitama’s eyes softened.

She smiled — not the neutral, professional smile she wore like armor, but something real. Something sincere.

“Thank you,” she said. “You have every right to disagree. Just like I’ve disagreed with you. But at least now... we understand each other.”

Yachiyo nodded.

And for the first time, the space between them felt less like a battlefield.

And more like a bridge.

The quiet hum of containment spheres filled the air, a soft, rhythmic pulse that echoed like distant heartbeats. The room had settled into a fragile calm — not peace, exactly, but something close. Yachiyo and Mitama stood side by side, no longer adversaries, their shared understanding hanging between them like a bridge newly built.

Then, from the entrance of the ward, a familiar voice rang out.

“Well, it seems everyone’s here.”

The words were light, almost casual, but they carried a weight that made every head turn.

Mifuyu stood in the doorway, her posture graceful, her expression unreadable. Her silver hair shimmered faintly in the ward’s violet light, and her eyes swept across the room — taking in Iroha, Kuroe, Momoko, Mitama, and finally, Yachiyo.

There was a pause.

Yachiyo stepped forward, her gaze steady.

“Mifuyu,” she said. “Why are you here? Are you still trying to convince us to join the Wings of the Magius? Even after everything we’ve seen?”

Her voice was calm, but beneath it lay a quiet storm.

“We saw Embryo Eve,” Yachiyo continued. “On the way here. We saw witches — former magical girls — being fed to it. Touka’s broadcast said it would awaken in three days. That it would spread the doppel system across the world.”

She paused, her eyes darkening.

“I don’t think it’s right. Feeding witches to an artificial witch to achieve your goals. I keep thinking about Mel. About her becoming a witch. The thought of her getting fed to an artificial witch makes me shudder with rage.”

The room fell silent.

Iroha’s breath caught. Kuroe’s eyes widened.

They had heard Touka’s declaration — the promise of liberation, of happiness. But they hadn’t known the cost. Not until now.

Embryo Eve wasn’t just a symbol. It was a mechanism. A creature built to consume.

And the witches it devoured had once been girls like them.

Kasumi and Lunaria exchanged a glance, their expressions unreadable. A ripple of telepathy passed between them — quiet, swift.

So it’s similar, Kasumi thought. *To the shadow monster.*

Yes, the similarities are striking, Lunaria replied. *The shadow monster consumes witches to grow stronger. And it connects to soul gems, corrupts them, and turns magical girls into witches.*

Is that what Touka, Nemu, and Alina are planning? Kasumi wondered. *To use Embryo Eve the same way?*

If so, Lunaria said, *then things are about to get very interesting.*

Mifuyu closed her eyes and sighed.

“I’m not here to recruit anyone,” she said softly. “Not anymore.”

She stepped further into the room, her gaze drifting to the containment spheres.

“When I heard Touka’s broadcast... I came to see if anything had changed. If the doppelified girls were recovering. But they’re still the same. Still trapped.”

She opened her eyes and looked at Yachiyo.

“Ya-chan,” she said, her voice tender. “Even I don’t know the full plan. I’m just... holding onto hope. That it’ll work. That something good will come of it.”

She turned to Mitama, her expression softening.

“I’m like her. We both want the same thing. A way — any way — to end the suffering of magical girls.”

Yachiyo looked at her.

And for a moment, the years between them fell away.

She saw the girl she had once fought beside. The friend who had laughed with her, cried with her, stood with her through battles and heartbreak. She saw the hope in Mifuyu’s eyes — fragile, flickering, but real.

“I don’t agree with the Wings,” Yachiyo said. “I don’t think their plan will work. I think it will hurt more girls than it saves.”

She paused.

“But thank you. For not trying to recruit us. For letting us choose.”

She stepped forward and offered her hand.

“You’re free to keep hoping. And to stay. If that’s what you want.”

Mifuyu smiled — a real smile, soft and luminous.

“That’s all I wanted, Ya-chan. For you to understand. For us to talk.”

She took Yachiyo’s hand.

And they shook — not as enemies, not as strangers, but as old friends finding each other again.

The room was quiet.

Then Momoko smiled. Iroha’s eyes shimmered. Kuroe exhaled softly. Felicia grinned. Sana and Tsuruno exchanged a glance and nodded.

Even Mitama’s expression softened.

And for a moment, the ward felt less like a place of containment.

And more like a place of healing.

The stillness in the ward had settled into something softer now — not the brittle silence of grief or the tense quiet of confrontation, but the hush that follows understanding. The kind of silence that allows for breath, for reflection, for the first fragile steps toward healing.

Iroha stepped forward, her voice gentle but clear.

“Mifuyu... do you know where Nemu is?”

Mifuyu turned to her, surprised by the question.

“I want to ask her about Ui,” Iroha continued, her gaze distant. “She and Touka were my childhood friends. I asked Touka about Ui when we were in the Memory Museum... when you were there too. But Touka said she doesn’t know who Ui is.”

Her voice faltered slightly at the end, and her eyes dropped to the floor.

Mifuyu’s expression softened. She stepped closer, her tone laced with quiet regret.

“I’m sorry, Iroha,” she said. “Nemu isn’t in the HQ right now. I heard she’s been traveling a lot lately, making sure everything is in place for the final phase of the plan. But I don’t know exactly what she’s doing.”

Iroha’s shoulders slumped, her hands curling at her sides. The hope that had flickered in her chest dimmed, just a little.

Kuroe stepped beside her, placing a hand gently on her arm.

“You’ll get the chance,” she said. “Maybe when the Wings carry out their plan in three days. You’ll see her then. And you’ll get to ask.”

Iroha looked at her, and a small smile returned to her lips.

“Thank you, Kuroe.”

Across the room, Kasumi and Lunaria exchanged a glance. A ripple of telepathy passed between them — silent, swift.

We may need to tell her soon, Kasumi thought. About Ui.

Agreed, Lunaria replied. If she tries to go back into the HQ alone to find Nemu... it could be dangerous. Especially now, with the Wings preparing to awaken Embryo Eve.

We’ll need to choose the right moment, Kasumi said. And decide how much to say.

Lunaria nodded, her expression unreadable.

Yachiyo looked around at the group — at the faces she had fought for, worried for, nearly lost. Her voice was steady, but there was a softness to it now.

“Should we go home?” she asked. “Back to Mikazuki Villa?”

Iroha nodded. “Yes.”

Sana smiled. “I’d like that.”

Felicia grinned. “Finally.”

Tsuruno gave a thumbs-up. “Let’s go.”

Kuroe hesitated, then nodded as well. “I’d like to see it.”

But not everyone was ready to leave.

“I’m staying,” Rena said, her voice firm. “Kaede’s still here. I’m not going anywhere until she’s back to normal.”

Momoko stepped forward. “Same here. We’re a team. I’ll stay with her.”

Yachiyo nodded, her expression warm. “I understand. I hope she recovers soon.”

She turned to Mitama and Mifuyu.

“What about you two?”

Mitama folded her hands in front of her, her voice calm. “I’ll remain here. If anything happens, I want to be close. As a coordinator... I still have a responsibility.”

Mifuyu nodded. “I’ll stay too. I want to see the plan through. I still hope it will work.”

Yachiyo met their eyes, her gaze steady but warm with understanding.

“Very well,” she said. “I wish both of you the best.”

She turned to Mifuyu, her expression softening.

“You’re always welcome at Mikazuki Villa. If you ever want to come back.”

“Maybe after everything is over,” Mifuyu said, her voice wistful. “That sounds nice. Just like good old times.”

Yachiyo nodded, and then turned to Mitama.

“You are also welcome, anytime.”

Mitama smiled — a rare, genuine smile that reached her eyes. “Thank you. That means more than you know.”

Finally, Yachiyo turned to Kasumi and Lunaria.

“And what about you two?”

Kasumi smiled, her tone light. “We’ll stay here. There’s still more to learn about the Wings’ plan.”

Lunaria nodded. “We’ll keep our eyes open. And we’ll find a way to connect with you later.”

Yachiyo studied them for a moment.

They looked unchanged. Unshaken. As if nothing they had seen — not the doppelified girls, not Embryo Eve, not Touka’s broadcast — had surprised them. As if they had already known. Or seen worse.

What have they witnessed on their travels? Yachiyo wondered. What do they know that we don’t?

And yet, they spoke with such quiet confidence. As if slipping in and out of the Wings’ stronghold was nothing to them. As if danger was something they had long since made peace with.

Yachiyo smiled.

“I wish you both the best,” she said. “And I hope we can talk again. Maybe next time... you’ll tell me more about yourselves.”

Kasumi chuckled. “We’ll definitely meet again.”

Lunaria added, “And maybe we’ll have more to share.”

With that, the moment settled.

Yachiyo turned to her companions — Iroha, Sana, Felicia, Tsuruno, and Kuroe — and nodded.

“Let’s go home.”

They offered their farewells — to Rena and Momoko, to Mitama and Mifuyu, to Kasumi and Lunaria. There were no grand speeches, no dramatic goodbyes. Just quiet smiles, soft waves, and the unspoken promise that this wasn’t the end.

Together, they stepped toward the exit of the Doppel Syndrome Isolation Ward.

Toward home.

Toward whatever came next.

Chapter 6: Going home, a future to fight for

The corridors of the Wings of the Magius headquarters stretched long and quiet, lit by soft sconces that cast pale gold light across the polished floors. Yachiyo led the way, her steps measured, her lance held low but ready. Behind her, Iroha, Sana, Felicia, Tsuruno, and Kuroe moved in silence, their footsteps muffled, their eyes scanning every corner.

They avoided the main halls, slipping through side passages and service corridors, careful not to draw attention. The air was still, but heavy — as if the building itself was holding its breath.

No one spoke aloud.

Instead, a ripple of telepathy passed between them.

Now’s a good time, Iroha said. To share what we know about Kasumi and Lunaria.

Kuroe nodded. *It’s not urgent, but it’s worth talking about.*

Back when we entered the portal, Iroha continued, Yachiyo was holding off the Amane sisters. Kuroe and I went through first. But when we arrived... Kasumi and Lunaria were already inside.

We didn’t see them enter, Kuroe added. Didn’t sense them either. It was like they were just... there.

Yachiyo’s voice joined the link, calm but thoughtful.

I noticed the same thing. Even the Amane sisters didn’t react. And I didn’t see them pass through the portal. No normal human could move that fast.

Sana blinked, her thoughts tinged with surprise. *Wait... this is the first time I'm hearing about this.*

Felicia's mental voice flared with curiosity. *So they're fast. Like, really fast. But how fast are we talking?*

Tsuruno chimed in. *Fast enough to slip past magical girls without being noticed? That's not just speed. That's something else.*

They all paused, considering the implications.

Mitama ran some tests, Iroha said. She checked Kasumi's soul gem, her contract signature, her magical energy. There was nothing.

She's not a magical girl, Kuroe confirmed. At least, not in any way Mitama could detect.

But she's not normal either, Iroha added. None of us think she is. Not Kasumi. Not Lunaria.

Mitama said they're bound to reveal more, Kuroe continued. Especially if they stay in the HQ. She even half-joked with them — said, 'I shared about myself, now it's your turn.'

And they said, Iroha recalled, 'We can't. At least not yet.'

The words lingered in the link.

Not yet, Yachiyo repeated. That sounds like a promise.

Sana's thoughts were quiet, contemplative. *I wonder what they're waiting for.*

Felicia's tone was sharper. *Or what they're hiding.*

Tsuruno's voice was softer. *Maybe they're protecting something. Or someone.*

They walked in silence for a moment, the corridor narrowing as they approached a stairwell that led to the outer levels. The air grew cooler, tinged with the scent of stone and night.

Thank you, Yachiyo said. For the update.

Sana nodded. *I'm glad we know more now.*

Felicia grinned. *I want to see what they can really do.*

Tsuruno smiled. *I want to hear their story.*

Kuroe looked ahead, her voice quiet. *I think we all do.*

Iroha's thoughts were steady. *Someday, they'll tell us. About their travels. Their abilities. Whether they're magical girls or something else entirely.*

Yachiyo glanced back at her friends, her expression softening.

Someday, she echoed.

And together, they continued forward — toward the exit, toward the night, and toward the answers that still waited in the shadows.

The exit shimmered before them — a portal etched with runes, pulsing faintly with containment magic. Yachiyo stepped forward first, her Magius emblem glowing softly. The portal recognized her and parted without resistance. Sana followed, then Felicia and Tsuruno, each passing through with ease, their emblems accepted.

Iroha and Kuroe stepped forward together.

And the alarm screamed.

A shrill, piercing sound echoed through the corridor, followed by a mechanical voice:

“Unauthorized departure detected. Traitor attempting to exit. Portal lockdown initiated.”

The portal began to close.

Iroha froze, her eyes wide. “What—?”

Kuroe’s breath caught. She understood immediately.

Her emblem had turned black.

The moment she entered the portal with Iroha — while Yachiyo had been holding off the Amane sisters — the Wings had branded her a traitor. The Amane sisters had said it. She hadn’t wanted to believe it. But now, the system confirmed it.

She had betrayed the Wings.

And now, they were sealing her in.

Without hesitation, Kuroe shoved Iroha forward.

“Go!” she shouted. “Get out!”

Iroha stumbled, caught off guard. Iroha spun around, her hand reaching back instinctively. “Kuroe!”

The portal narrowed.

Kuroe smiled — a soft, sad smile.

“Don’t worry,” she said. “I’ll catch up. I promise.”

Iroha’s eyes shimmered. “I believe in you. Good luck!”

And then she was gone.

The portal sealed shut.

Kuroe turned.

The corridor behind her was no longer empty.

Black-feathered magical girls lined the corridor like sentinels, their eyes cold, their weapons gleaming in the low light. The air was thick with tension, the kind that prickled against the skin and made every breath feel heavier. At the center of the formation stood Ryou Midori — a white feather, her uniform immaculate, her posture rigid with authority. Her gaze was sharp, calculating, and utterly devoid of sympathy.

“Well, well,” she said, her voice laced with disdain. “The traitor shows her face.”

She stepped forward, the weight of her bazooka resting casually on her shoulder, as if she had all the time in the world to crush whatever resistance remained.

“You’ll be arrested,” she continued, her tone clipped and final. “And brought before Touka and Nemu. They’ll decide what to do with you.”

Kuroe didn’t flinch.

She closed her eyes, her breath steadying as the reality of the moment settled into her bones.

I’m sorry, Iroha, she thought. I didn’t want this. But I won’t give up.

Her fingers curled around her soul gem, and with a surge of will, she opened it.

Darkness erupted.

Black, muddy wings burst from her back, vast and dripping with shadow. The air around her warped, thickened, as her doppel awakened — a presence heavy and defiant, its aura pulsing like a heartbeat made of grief and resolve. The corridor dimmed, the light swallowed by the wings’ unnatural sheen.

She stood tall.

She was so close.

So close to living with Iroha and the others at Mikazuki Villa. So close to the life she had dreamed of — quiet mornings, shared meals, laughter that didn’t feel borrowed. She couldn’t fall here. Not now. Not when everything she wanted was just beyond this fight.

Ryou’s eyes narrowed.

“Fire!”

The bazooka roared, a burst of explosive magic tearing through the air, aimed directly at Kuroe’s chest.

Kuroe didn’t move.

Her wings folded inward, wrapping around her like a cocoon of shadow and steel. The blast struck with a deafening boom, the shockwave rattling the walls, smoke billowing outward in thick, choking clouds.

Ryou grinned, her stance relaxed. “That should do it.”

But as the smoke cleared, her expression shifted.

The cocoon remained.

Unharméd.

Its surface shimmered with a dark, oily sheen, pulsing with quiet menace.

“What...?” Ryou whispered, her voice cracking.

Then — retaliation.

Black bullets burst from the cocoon like a swarm of hornets, streaking through the air with deadly precision. Ryou dove to the side, her boots skidding across the floor. Several black-feathered girls weren’t fast enough. The bullets struck, and their bodies crumpled to the ground, unconscious before they hit the floor.

Ryou’s teeth clenched.

“How are you this strong?” she shouted. “You were a weakling before!”

The cocoon split open.

Kuroe stepped forward, her wings unfurling with a hiss of shadow. Her eyes glowed — not with rage, but with something deeper. Something steadier.

“I have a promise to keep,” she said, her voice low and unwavering. “I can’t fall here.”

A group of magical girls charged from her left, their weapons raised, their cries sharp with fury.

Kuroe turned, her left wing sweeping out like a shield. The attacks struck, but the wing held — absorbing the blows with a dull, resonant thud. Her right wing curled into a fist, and with a single, fluid motion, she struck. The impact sent the girls flying, their bodies crashing into the walls with a burst of magical sparks.

Ryou snarled.

“All units — together! Take her down!”

The corridor erupted.

Boots thundered against the floor. Spells lit the air with bursts of color and heat. Battle cries rose like a wave, crashing toward Kuroe with relentless force.

She took a deep breath.

Her aura flared — black and fierce, swirling around her like a storm. But within the darkness, faint flickers of pink shimmered — remnants of her connect with Iroha, threads of memory and hope woven into the chaos.

A reminder.

A tether.

She charged forward.

Her own cry rising to meet theirs, raw and resolute.

The clash was immediate.

Wings met blades. Spells collided midair. The corridor became a blur of motion and sound — a battlefield carved from desperation and dreams. Kuroe moved with purpose, her strikes precise, her defenses fluid. Every blow she landed was a step closer to freedom. Every dodge was a refusal to fall.

She wasn't just fighting for survival.

She was fighting for a future.

The soft hum of containment spheres filled the air, casting a gentle rhythm through the Doppel Syndrome Isolation Ward. The violet glow of the room flickered faintly against the polished floor, and the silence that lingered was no longer heavy — it was contemplative, expectant.

Kasumi stretched her arms overhead with a cheerful sigh, her movements light and fluid, like someone preparing for a morning jog rather than a deep dive into the heart of a magical conspiracy.

“Well,” she said brightly, “I think it’s time Lunaria and I head out. There’s still so much to see.”

Lunaria stood beside her, calm and composed, her gaze drifting toward the sealed exit. She nodded once, her voice soft but clear.

“We want to continue our investigation,” she said. “There’s one place in particular we’d like to visit.”

Mitama tilted her head. “Where are you going?”

Mifuyu stepped forward, her arms crossed gently. “I hope you are not planning something too crazy.”

Lunaria’s eyes met theirs, serene and steady.

“We want to see Embryo Eve,” she said. “The artificial witch Touka mentioned. The one Yachiyo said is being fed witches. In all our travels... we’ve never seen anything like it.”

Momoko raised an eyebrow. “You’ve seen a lot, haven’t you?”

Rena leaned against the wall, her tone dry but thoughtful. “Guess that goes to show how brilliant Touka, Nemu, and Alina are. Setting up something as massive as the APS and the doppel system...”

Kasumi nodded, her expression bright. “It’s certainly ambitious. But we’ll see what it really looks like up close.”

She turned to the group, her smile playful.

“We’ll contact all of you and Yachiyo’s group when we learn more. Until then — tata!”

Lunaria offered a graceful bow. “Farewell. We wish you all the best.”

Mitama, Mifuyu, Momoko, and Rena returned the farewell with warm smiles and quiet waves. There was no tension in the goodbye — only curiosity, and the quiet hope that something new might be uncovered.

As the door closed behind Kasumi and Lunaria, Mitama turned to the others, her eyes gleaming with amusement.

“Well,” she said, “I suppose we’ll find out more about them soon enough.”

She raised her hand, and a soft shimmer of magic pulsed from her soul gem. A projection appeared in the air — a translucent image of the vast chamber where Embryo Eve rested. The artificial witch loomed in the center, its porcelain body radiant and still, surrounded by containment spheres of other witches and glowing runes.

“I hope they learn something,” Mitama said. “And maybe... we’ll learn something about them too.”

Mifuyu chuckled. “They’re certainly not ordinary.”

Momoko grinned. “I bet Kasumi will try to poke Embryo Eve just to see what happens.”

Rena rolled her eyes. “Or Lunaria petting it like a pet.”

They laughed — not loudly, but with genuine warmth. The tension of earlier had faded, replaced by quiet speculation and the comfort of shared company.

For now, all they could do was wait.

And wonder.

The hallways of Hotel Faint Hope stretched on like veins through a sleeping giant — polished marble floors gleaming under soft lamplight, gilded sconces flickering with enchanted flame, and velvet-lined walls that whispered of elegance and secrecy. The air was perfumed faintly with lavender and old paper, a scent that clung to the corridors like memory.

Kasumi and Lunaria moved through it with practiced ease, their steps light, their senses sharp. Whenever the sound of approaching footsteps echoed from around a corner — the click of boots, the rustle of cloaks — they slipped into alcoves or behind ornamental curtains, vanishing like shadows. They didn’t need to speak aloud. Their telepathic link hummed quietly between them, a familiar thread of thought woven through years of shared adventure.

This place is massive, Kasumi mused, her tone tinged with wonder. *I thought it was just a fancy hotel. But it’s like a city.*

The Wings have built something vast, Lunaria replied. *I wonder how many members they truly have. How deep this place goes.*

Kasumi's eyes sparkled. *Do you think they have an amusement park? An ice skating rink? A giant pool or water park? Movie theater? Musical concerts? Sports arenas and courts? Fancy kitchens to cook in? You know — fun stuff? The Wings of the Magius must have fun activities for their members, right?*

Lunaria chuckled gently, the sound like wind brushing through silk. *You should have asked Mitama or Mifuyu earlier. If you had, maybe we'd be exploring the fun parts of the HQ now.*

Kasumi pouted dramatically, then burst into laughter. *Next time for sure! We'll throw a grand party here! Live music, great food, games, and activities!*

And you'll belly flop into the pool, Lunaria teased.

Kasumi grinned. *Only if you promise to catch me.*

They reached a platform and paused.

A train glided into view, sleek and silent, its surface etched with silver runes. The doors opened with a soft hiss, and they stepped aboard. The interior was plush — velvet seats, golden trim, and windows that shimmered with protective enchantments. The ride was smooth, almost luxurious, the train humming like a lullaby as it carried them deeper into the heart of the HQ.

Kasumi leaned against the window, her breath fogging the glass. *This is kind of fun.*

Enjoy it while it lasts, Lunaria replied with a faint smile.

The train curved through a wide tunnel, and the scenery shifted.

They passed through a witch farming facility.

Rows of isolation spheres floated in the air, suspended like stars in a dark sky. Each sphere contained a witch or familiar, their twisted forms barely visible through the shimmering surface. Machines lined the walls, humming quietly, feeding the spheres with streams of negative emotion. The entire chamber pulsed with quiet efficiency — an assembly line of despair.

Kasumi's eyes widened. *This must be what the others saw.*

Lunaria nodded, her gaze steady. *It fits their description perfectly.*

Kasumi whistled. *The Wings really know how to industrialize suffering. The shadow monster would love this place. It's like a buffet.*

Lunaria chuckled softly. *Endless courses of despair. Served fresh.*

Then the train entered a new chamber.

And everything changed.

The space opened into a vast, cathedral-like expanse. The ceiling stretched impossibly high, vanishing into shadow. The walls were carved with flowing patterns of light and stone, and the air shimmered with quiet magic. In the center of it all stood Embryo Eve.

The artificial witch loomed like a monument — pale, radiant, and still. Its wings unfurled behind it like ceremonial fans, etched with golden patterns that shimmered in the dim light. A halo-like structure rose behind its head, casting long, divine shadows across the chamber. The silence around it was reverent, almost sacred.

Kasumi and Lunaria stared, their thoughts quiet.

It's beautiful, Kasumi whispered.

And eerie, Lunaria added. *I've never seen anything like it.*

How did Touka, Nemu, and Alina create this? Kasumi wondered. *It's like a god carved from porcelain.*

It's dormant, Lunaria said. *Three days until it awakens. What happens then?*

Will it function like the shadow monster? Kasumi asked. *Feeding. Connecting. Corrupting.*

If it does, Lunaria replied, *things will get very interesting... and very dangerous. Chaos and destruction would reign.*

They didn't wait for answers.

Without a word, they stood and leapt from the train — a distance no normal human could cross. Lunaria's body moved with supernatural grace, her cloak billowing like wings. Kasumi followed with untamed energy, her leap wild and joyful. Both propelled by something deeper than magic.

Lunaria landed first, her feet touching Embryo Eve's surface with the elegance of a falling petal.

Kasumi followed — and promptly belly flopped and face planted.

Lunaria chuckled, the sound warm and familiar.

Kasumi groaned, lifting her head and giving a thumbs-up. *Nailed it.*

They sat together on the witch's surface, the air around them humming faintly with dormant power. The texture beneath their hands was smooth and cold, like polished bone. They reached out, placing their palms against Embryo Eve's body.

And everything shifted.

A pulse of recognition surged through them — not from the witch, but from something deeper. Something familiar. Something sacred.

Their eyes widened.

Just like that morning, when they touched the small Kyubey in Mikazuki Villa.

It's Ui, Lunaria whispered. *This is Ui's witch.*

Kasumi's breath caught. *Her soul is in the small Kyubey. But her body... it's here.*

They stared at each other, stunned.

Someone did something, Lunaria said. Something strange. Or something went terribly wrong.

Touka, Nemu, and Alina must be involved, Kasumi replied. But Touka told Iroha she doesn't know who Ui is.

She lied, Lunaria said. Or she's hiding something.

The silence around them deepened, thick with revelation.

Then — an explosion.

Far behind them, in the direction they had come from.

They turned, eyes narrowing.

Smoke rose in the distance, faint but unmistakable.

Something's happened, Kasumi said. Something bad.

More likely than not, Lunaria replied, it's Iroha's group. Trying to leave.

They didn't move.

Not yet.

We'll intervene only if necessary, Lunaria said. Just like with Mami. When the breakpoint comes.

Kasumi nodded, her expression thoughtful. *I'm very curious how they'll deal with this. I hope we get to see their strength, their resolve... their connection.*

They sat in silence, watching the distant smoke curl through the air.

The storm was coming.

And they were ready to witness it.

The air in the Doppel Syndrome Isolation Ward was calm, almost serene. The soft hum of containment spheres pulsed in the background, a steady rhythm that underscored the quiet conversation between Mitama, Mifuyu, Momoko, and Rena. They sat together near the center of the ward, their eyes fixed on the shimmering projection Mitama had conjured — a translucent window into the grand chamber where Embryo Eve slumbered.

The image floated above the floor like a suspended dream, casting pale light across their faces. Within it, the train glided silently along its track, and inside, two familiar figures sat side by side.

“There they are,” Mitama murmured, adjusting the projection's focus with a flick of her fingers.

“Kasumi and Lunaria.”

“They're really going for it,” Momoko said, leaning forward. “Let's see what they're up to.”

“They said they wanted to investigate,” Mifuyu added. “Maybe we’ll finally learn something about them.”

The four watched in silence as the train curved through the witch farming facility, then entered the vast cathedral-like chamber. The camera’s angle widened, revealing the full majesty of Embryo Eve — radiant, motionless, divine.

And then it happened.

Kasumi and Lunaria stood.

And leapt.

The four girls gasped in unison.

“What—?” Rena blinked. “Did they just—?”

“They jumped,” Mifuyu said, her voice hushed. “From the train. That’s... crazy.”

“No ordinary human could make that leap,” Mitama said, her eyes narrowing. “Even most magical girls couldn’t reach Embryo Eve from there in a single jump.”

The projection followed their arc through the air — Lunaria’s body moving with supernatural grace, her cloak trailing behind her like wings of shadow and silk. Kasumi followed, her leap wild and joyful, limbs flailing with abandon.

Lunaria landed first, her feet touching Embryo Eve’s surface with the elegance of a falling petal.

Kasumi landed second — and promptly belly flopped, her face smacking the surface with a dull thud.

There was a beat of stunned silence.

Then—

Momoko burst out laughing. “Oh my god. Did she just—?”

“She did,” Rena said, eyes wide. “She face-planted.”

Mifuyu covered her mouth, trying not to laugh. “I... I didn’t expect that.”

Mitama chuckled, shaking her head. “They really are different.”

“Lunaria’s landing was like something out of a dream,” Mifuyu said. “And Kasumi...”

“Was that on purpose?” Rena asked. “Like... is that her thing?”

Momoko grinned. “I told you! I said she’d try to poke Embryo Eve just to see what happens. I didn’t think she’d go full belly flop.”

“Well, at least Embryo Eve’s still dormant,” Mifuyu said, smirking. “That would’ve been a very awkward way to start the apocalypse.”

They laughed again, the sound light and genuine, echoing softly through the ward.

But then the mood shifted.

On the projection, Kasumi and Lunaria sat down on Embryo Eve's surface. They reached out, placing their hands against the witch's body.

And froze.

Their eyes went wide — not with fear, but with recognition. Shock. Revelation.

They sat in silence, unmoving.

The laughter in the ward faded.

Mitama leaned forward, her brow furrowed. "What just happened?"

"They touched it," Mifuyu said. "And then..."

"They know something," Rena murmured. "They felt something."

"Is that another one of their abilities?" Momoko asked. "Some kind of... magical resonance?"

Mitama didn't answer right away. Her eyes were fixed on the projection, her mind racing.

"They learned something," she said at last. "I'm sure of it."

"We'll have to ask them," Mifuyu said. "When they come back."

"Assuming they do," Rena added.

"They will," Momoko said. "They promised."

Mitama nodded. "And when they do... we'll share this with the others. Iroha, Yachiyo, Kuroe, Sana, Felicia, Tsuruno. Maybe over a nice meal at Mikazuki Villa."

"With Kasumi and Lunaria too," Mifuyu added, smiling. "That sounds fun."

They all smiled at the thought — a warm evening, laughter over food, stories shared beneath the soft glow of lanterns.

A future worth hoping for.

But then—

A sound.

A low, distant rumble.

The projection flickered.

And then came the explosion.

A flash of light. A bloom of smoke. The chamber shuddered with the force of it.

Mitama's eyes widened. "What was that?"

"An explosion," Rena said, rising to her feet. "That was close."

"They noticed it too," Mifuyu said, pointing at the projection. "Look at them."

Kasumi and Lunaria had turned, their expressions sharp, alert. The easy warmth was gone from their faces.

“Change the projection,” Momoko ordered. “Show us where it happened.”

Mitama nodded, her fingers weaving through the air. The image shimmered, shifted—then reformed.

What they saw made their hearts stop.

The corridor was in ruins. Smoke curled from shattered walls. Magical girls lay unconscious across the floor. And at the center of it all was—

“No...” Momoko whispered, eyes wide as she raised a trembling hand to her mouth.

“Not you too...” Rena murmured, her fists clenching tight.

“Kuroe...” Mifuyu breathed, voice shaking as she clutched her Soul Gem close.

Mitama’s hands trembled.

And in that moment, the warmth of imagined futures gave way to the heavy stillness of grief.

The corridor was silent now.

Smoke drifted through the air in lazy spirals, curling around the shattered walls and scorched floor. The scent of ozone and burnt fabric lingered, mingling with the metallic tang of spent magic. Kuroe stood in the center of it all, her wings drooping, her breath ragged.

She was sweating, panting, her body trembling from exertion. Her soul gem pulsed faintly at her chest — dark, tainted, flickering with unstable light. She looked down at it, her breath catching. It was nearly black.

Around her, the bodies of the Wings of the Magius lay scattered — unconscious, unmoving. Their weapons had fallen from their hands, their cloaks torn, their expressions frozen in defeat.

Kuroe stared at them.

And saw someone else.

A girl with short black hair and a quiet smile. A girl who had once stood beside her in a witch’s labyrinth. A girl named Kuro.

The memory rose unbidden, sharp and vivid.

Kuroe remembered the labyrinth — the way the walls pulsed with chains and mirrors, the air thick with the scent of rust and sorrow. The Slave of Anima witch had twisted the space into a maze of reflections, each one showing fractured images of pain. She had entered alone, her soul gem already dim, her breath shallow with fatigue.

And then, from the shadows, another girl appeared.

Her posture was tense, her movements cautious. Her soul gem flickered weakly at her chest, barely holding its shape. She didn't speak at first. Neither of them did. They simply looked at each other — two strangers, both worn thin, both too tired to question why the other was there.

They fought together.

Not with elegance or coordination, but with desperation. Their attacks were clumsy, their defenses barely held. But somehow, they managed to damage the witch — enough to force it to retreat into the depths of its labyrinth.

It escaped.

And left behind no grief seed.

Kuroe stood panting, her hands trembling. The silence that followed was suffocating.

The other girl — Kuro — slumped against the wall, her shoulders sagging.

Kuroe blinked, still catching her breath. "Who are you? You are not from here right?"

"I'm not from here," Kuro replied. "I came to Takarazaki since there aren't many witches where I am from. I was hoping to get a grief seed since my soul gem is polluted."

Kuro forced a smile.

Kuroe stared, stunned. She always considered herself weak — but this girl was weaker still. And yet... she smiled. A soft, tired smile that didn't ask for pity.

"I'm sorry," Kuro said. "I didn't mean to hunt in someone else's territory."

"It's fine," Kuroe replied. "Things like this happen."

She turned to leave, her steps slow.

But Kuro called out. "Wait!"

Kuroe paused.

"Do you have any spare grief seeds?" Kuro asked, her voice barely above a whisper.

Kuroe hesitated.

She looked down at her own soul gem — tainted, but not nearly as dark as Kuro's. She wanted to help. She wanted to say yes.

But she didn't.

"I'm sorry," she said. "I don't have any to spare."

Kuro smiled again. "That's expected."

She looked down at her gem, then back at Kuroe.

“I’ll work hard,” she said. “I’ll try my best. And maybe one day... I’ll have enough grief seeds to share with everyone.”

Kuroe stepped forward, and they shook hands — a quiet promise exchanged between two girls who had nothing but hope.

Kuro waved as Kuroe turned to leave.

Kuroe looked back one last time.

Then she ran.

She never saw Kuro again.

And the memory haunted her.

Did she become a witch? Kuroe wondered. *Did she die?*

She looked down at the unconscious Wings of the Magius scattered around her — their bodies limp, their soul gems flickering faintly.

And saw Kuro in their faces.

She clenched her fists.

Things could have been different, she thought. *If we had stayed together. If I had helped her.*

Her wings trembled.

Her soul gem pulsed, dark and unstable.

She was so close now — to the life she wanted. To the people she loved. But the past clung to her like a shadow, whispering of choices not made, of hands not held, of promises broken before they could bloom.

The corridor was still, but the silence no longer felt like peace. It was the silence of something watching. Waiting. Kuroe stood in the center of the wreckage, her breath shallow, her soul gem pulsing with a sickly, unsteady glow. The black sheen of her wings had begun to fade, their edges fraying like burnt paper. Her legs trembled beneath her, and her vision blurred with exhaustion. But it wasn’t just fatigue that made her sway.

It was the voice.

Low. Familiar. Wrong.

“Poor Kuroe,” it said, curling around her like smoke. “Still pretending to be like Iroha.”

She turned, slowly, as if her body already knew what she would see.

There, rising from the shadows, was a figure cloaked in darkness. It wore Kuro's face — the girl from Takarazaki, the one she had left behind. But the features were warped, stretched by shadow and sorrow. Her eyes were too wide, too hollow. Her smile was a crack in porcelain. The darkness clung to her like a second skin, pulsing with malice.

Kuroe's breath caught in her throat.

"Iroha reaches out," the doppel said, its voice echoing with a cruel lilt. "She saves people. She gives them hope. And you? You run. You leave them behind."

Kuroe shook her head, her voice barely audible. "That's not true. I'm trying. I'm reaching out now. I want to help her. I want to be with her."

The doppel laughed — a sound like glass shattering in a frozen room.

"Then what about me?" it hissed, stepping closer. "What about me, Kuroe?"

The shadows thickened, and the figure shifted — no longer just Kuro, but something else. Something broken. Her limbs bent at unnatural angles, her soul gem cracked and leaking darkness. Her voice trembled with fury and grief.

"My soul gem was about to break," she said. "And you did nothing. You looked at me. You saw how close I was. And you turned your back."

Kuroe stumbled backward, her wings dragging against the floor. Her heart pounded in her chest, each beat louder than the last.

"You didn't offer to team up. You just ran."

"I—" Kuroe's voice cracked. "I didn't know. I didn't think—"

"Didn't think?" the doppel spat. "Or didn't care?"

Kuroe dropped to her knees, her hands trembling. The corridor spun around her, the walls warping, the air thickening with shadow. Her soul gem pulsed again — darker now, nearly black.

"Do you know what happened to me after that?" the doppel whispered, kneeling beside her. "Do you know what it feels like to die alone?"

Kuroe couldn't answer.

She clutched her head, her fingers digging into her scalp. Her breath came in short, broken gasps. Tears streamed down her cheeks, hot and bitter.

"No," she whispered. "Stop. Please..."

The doppel leaned in, its voice a blade against her skin.

"You don't deserve Iroha. You don't deserve to live in Mikazuki Villa. You don't deserve their kindness. Their warmth. Their trust."

Kuroe shook her head, sobbing now, her body wracked with tremors.

The corridor darkened.

Not from the flickering lights or the smoke that still lingered from the battle — but from something deeper. Something alive. The doppel's shadows began to spread, slow and deliberate, like ink bleeding across parchment. They slithered along the floor, curled around the walls, and reached for Kuroe with quiet hunger.

She felt it before she saw it — the cold touch of despair brushing against her skin, the weight of something ancient pressing down on her shoulders. Her wings twitched, her breath caught. The air grew thick, heavy with the scent of ash and regret.

“You deserve the same end I had,” the doppel whispered, its voice now everywhere — inside her ears, inside her thoughts. “Alone. Forgotten. Consumed.”

The shadows wrapped around her legs, her arms, her chest. They coiled like serpents, draining the last remnants of hope she had clung to. Her memories flickered — Iroha's smile, the warmth of Mikazuki Villa, the laughter she had begun to believe she could share. All of it dimmed, pulled into the dark.

Something inside her cracked.

“No,” Kuroe gasped, her voice trembling. “Stop... no... nooooo—!”

She screamed.

The sound tore from her throat, raw and jagged, a cry that echoed through the corridor like a soul being ripped apart. Her wings curled inward, her body folding in on itself. She collapsed fully, her forehead striking the floor with a dull thud. Her hands clawed at her temples, fingers digging into her scalp as if she could tear the voice out of her mind, as if she could silence the truth she didn't want to face.

The shadows surged.

Her soul gem flared — a burst of black light, violent and uncontained, that swallowed the corridor whole. The unconscious bodies around her were bathed in the glow, their forms flickering beneath the pulse of corrupted magic.

And then—

Silence.

Her body stilled.

Her breath ceased.

The last of her resistance slipped away, drowned beneath the weight of guilt and grief.

And the doppel took over.

Chapter 7: Fallen Doppel

The wind outside the Wings of the Magius HQ was sharp and cold, slicing through the air like a warning. Yachiyo, Iroha, Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno sprinted across the marble courtyard, their footsteps echoing against the stone. The exit was just ahead — freedom, safety, home.

But Iroha stopped.

She froze mid-step, her breath catching in her throat. Her soul gem pulsed faintly, and for a moment, black flickers shimmered across its surface — remnants of the connect she had shared with Kuroe earlier. A chill ran down her spine.

Yachiyo turned, concern etched across her face. “Iroha? Are you alright?”

Iroha clutched her soul gem, her voice trembling. “I... I don’t know. Something’s wrong. I feel it. Something terrible is happening to Kuroe.”

The others gathered around her, their expressions shifting from confusion to worry.

“Maybe it’s the bond,” Iroha whispered. “From our connect. I can feel her. And it’s... it’s not good.”

Yachiyo placed a hand on her shoulder, her voice calm and steady. “She promised you, didn’t she? That she’d catch up. You promised me something similar once. And even though I lost you for a time... we’re together now, aren’t we?”

Iroha looked up, her eyes shimmering. “Yes. Thank you.”

But the warmth of that reassurance shattered in an instant.

A thunderous explosion cracked through the air behind them.

They turned as one — and saw it.

Kuroe’s doppel.

It rose into the sky like a dark phoenix, wings unfurled, shadow trailing behind it like smoke. The air around it warped, pulsing with corrupted magic. Its form was monstrous, elegant, terrifying — and unmistakably Kuroe.

All five girls gasped, hands flying to their mouths.

“No...” Sana whispered.

“She’s... she’s doppelified,” Tsuruno said, her voice hollow.

“Just like Kaede,” Felicia murmured.

Iroha’s knees buckled. “Kuroe!”

She cried out, tears spilling down her cheeks. Her voice cracked with guilt, with grief. “I wasn’t there. I should’ve protected her. I should’ve—”

But then she saw it.

A sliver of humanity.

Kuroe's face — or part of it — still visible beneath the mask of shadow. Her eyes were closed, her expression pained. The doppel hadn't fully consumed her yet. The corruption was spreading slowly, like ink across skin.

"She's still fighting," Iroha whispered. "She's still in there."

She stepped forward, cupping her hands around her mouth. "Kuroe! You're not alone! We're here! Please — come back!"

The doppel faltered mid-air.

Its wings twitched — not from exhaustion, but from something else. A ripple. A voice. A memory.

Inside the swirling mass of shadow and grief, Kuroe heard it.

Faint. Fragile. But unmistakable.

"I'm here, Kuroe! You're not alone!"

Iroha's voice.

It pierced the fog like a thread of light, weaving through the darkness that had wrapped itself around Kuroe's mind. Her thoughts were scattered, her sense of self fraying at the edges, but that voice — that voice was real. It was warm. It was hers.

Kuroe stirred.

Somewhere deep inside the cocoon of despair, she reached for it. Her fingers trembled, her soul gem pulsed weakly. The shadows recoiled for a moment, flickering like flame caught in wind.

She remembered.

The way Iroha had smiled at her. The way she had reached out, even when Kuroe had tried to push her away. The way she had believed in her.

Kuroe... come back.

She tried to move. To speak. To scream.

But the doppel was waiting.

It surged forward, wrapping tighter around her consciousness. The shadows thickened, pressing against her chest, her throat, her thoughts. The warmth of Iroha's voice was drowned beneath a tide of cold whispers.

"She's not calling for you," the doppel hissed. "She's calling for someone she believes in. Someone who saves people. Someone who matters."

Kuroe gasped, her breath catching in her throat.

“Iroha doesn’t need you,” the voice continued, curling around her like smoke. “She has Yachiyo. She has Mikazuki Villa. She has everything.”

The shadows pressed harder.

“You’re just the girl who ran.”

Kuroe’s wings twitched. Her body convulsed. Her soul gem flickered — a pulse of pink, swallowed by black.

“No,” she whispered. “I’m trying. I want to—”

“You want to what?” the doppel spat. “Help? Save? You couldn’t even save me.”

The voice shifted — no longer just the doppel, but Kuro. Twisted. Broken.

“You left me,” it said. “You turned your back. You ran.”

Kuroe’s tears spilled, hot and silent.

“Iroha will leave you too,” the voice said. “She’ll see what you really are. And she’ll run.”

The shadows surged again.

Kuroe screamed — not aloud, but within. Her thoughts fractured, her memories splintering. The warmth she had clung to was slipping through her fingers.

But somewhere, buried beneath the weight of guilt and grief, a flicker remained.

A promise.

A voice.

Kuroe... come back.

The doppel rose higher, its wings beating with unnatural rhythm, its form growing more monstrous by the second. But inside — deep inside — Kuroe was still fighting.

And the battle was far from over.

Yachiyo’s eyes narrowed. “We’re not letting her go.”

She raised her soul gem, and beautiful swirls of water burst forth, spiraling into the air like ribbons of light. “Get on!”

The girls leapt onto the flowing currents, their feet finding balance on the liquid paths. Yachiyo guided the swirls upward, chasing the doppel through the sky.

But Kuroe’s doppel turned.

And attacked.

It spread its wings wide and unleashed a barrage of black, shadowy feather bullets — fast, heavy, and relentless. The air filled with shrieks of magic and the hiss of corrupted energy.

“Brace yourselves!” Yachiyo shouted.

She summoned dozens of spears, each one glowing with pale blue light. “Jump on them! Dodge!”

The girls leapt from the water swirls to the spears, hopping between them like dancers in a deadly ballet. The feather bullets struck the water, and the swirls darkened — consumed by shadow.

Yachiyo’s eyes widened. “I can’t control it anymore...”

The water twisted, then vanished — fading into mist.

The girls landed on the spears just in time, but the barrage continued. Too many. Too fast.

Sana raised her shield, her arms trembling. “I’ve got you!”

The bullets slammed into the shield, and the impact sent all five girls hurtling downward.

As they fell, Felicia gritted her teeth and manifested her hammer. “Yachiyo! Iroha! Get on!”

They didn’t hesitate.

Felicia spun mid-air, her muscles straining, and launched them upward with a roar.

Tsuruno followed, her fans glowing with fire. She unleashed a swirl of flames that met the shadowy feathers head-on. The two forces collided — and vanished together in a burst of blazing ash.

A path opened.

Yachiyo and Iroha soared through it.

“Thank you!” Yachiyo called.

“You’re amazing!” Iroha added.

Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno smiled as they fell, their voices rising together. “Keep going!”

Yachiyo summoned water again, graceful and swift, and she and Iroha ran across it like dancers on a stage. Yachiyo readied her spear, Iroha her crossbow — prepared for whatever came next.

But Kuroe’s doppel wasn’t done.

It let out a screech — high, sharp, birdlike — and flapped its wings with fury.

A gust of wind exploded outward, massive and wild.

Yachiyo and Iroha yelped, their bodies thrown backward, spiraling through the air.

“No!” Sana screamed.

“Iroha!” Felicia shouted.

“Yachiyo!” Tsuruno cried.

The wind slammed them toward the ground, fast and brutal.

Yachiyo thought quickly, her soul gem glowing. She summoned water beneath them — a soft, rippling cushion that slowed their descent.

They landed hard, but safe.

All five girls regrouped, panting, bruised, eyes wide with disbelief.

Above them, Kuroe's doppel flew farther and farther away.

And they watched — helpless, desperate — as their friend slipped beyond reach.

Iroha fell to her knees.

The cold stone beneath her offered no comfort, no grounding. Her hands trembled as she clutched her soul gem, her tears falling freely now, streaking down her cheeks in hot, silent trails. Her voice had gone hoarse from shouting, but Kuroe hadn't turned back. Hadn't answered. The flicker of her human face — that last fragile piece of her — was fading fast beneath the creeping mask of shadow.

"She's too far," Iroha whispered, her voice breaking. "She can't hear me anymore..."

Yachiyo stood beside her, fists clenched so tightly her knuckles had gone white. Her jaw was set, but her eyes betrayed the storm within. Iroha had been right — Kuroe's doppel was continuing to take over. The last sliver of her face was nearly gone, swallowed by the spreading corruption. Kuroe wouldn't last much longer.

Yachiyo's thoughts churned.

Why is Kuroe's doppel so strong? Kuroe is not a strong magical girl.

She had seen many doppels before — some wild, some barely restrained — but this one was different. It wasn't just powerful. It was purposeful. Focused. As if it had a will of its own.

A doppel is born from negative emotion, she thought. From grief. From despair. From everything we bury deep inside.

What had Kuroe been carrying?

What pain had she hidden behind her quiet voice and hesitant smiles?

Yachiyo's heart ached. She knew this pain too well — the pain of watching someone slip away. She had lost so many friends. So many teammates. And every time, it felt like a piece of her was carved out and left behind. She had wished to survive, and in doing so, she had watched others fall.

Now Iroha was feeling that same pain.

And Yachiyo could do nothing to stop it.

Behind them, Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno stood in stunned silence, their eyes fixed on the sky. Kuroe's doppel was still rising, its wings beating with unnatural rhythm, its form growing smaller against the clouds.

"Why is it still going up?" Sana asked, her voice barely audible.

Felicia frowned. "It's not just flying away..."

Tsuruno's eyes widened. "Wait. No. No, it can't be—"

They all gasped at once.

Kuroe's doppel had angled its body upward, its wings folding in slightly, its form narrowing like a spear.

It was aiming.

Straight for the sky.

Straight for the barrier.

"The APS," Tsuruno breathed. "It's going to hit the APS barrier."

Yachiyo's heart stopped.

Touka had told them about it — the APS containment field, a system designed to halt the final descent. Within its bounds, magical girls didn't become witches. Instead, they transformed into their doppel forms, manifestations of their despair. And when the doppel faded, the girls returned to normal. Soul gem cleansed. Pristine once again. A cycle of controlled catharsis, Touka had called it. A safeguard against ruin.

A safeguard that Touka wanted to spread throughout the world.

So if Kuroe's doppel broke through...

Yachiyo's breath caught. Her eyes went wide. "If there's a breach... then Kuroe would become a witch."

She turned to the others, her voice trembling. "And what happens to the others? The girls in the Isolation Ward — the ones already consumed by their doppels..."

Sana's face drained of color. "Would they... would they destabilize? Would they become witches too?"

Felicia took a step back, her voice cracking. "No. No way. That can't be true."

Tsuruno shook her head, but her voice was thin, barely holding. "If they all go berserk..."

"They'd destroy everything," Yachiyo said. "Kamihama. Maybe more."

Iroha looked up, her eyes red and swollen, her voice barely a whisper. "We can't stop that many. We can't..."

The weight of it settled over them like a shroud.

They had come so far. Fought so hard. And now, everything — everyone — was at risk.

All because one girl had fallen too far.

They looked up again, hearts pounding, as Kuroe's doppel neared the shimmering curve of the APS barrier. The sky above it rippled with magical energy, a dome of containment that had held for so long — glowing faintly like a second sky, fragile and sacred.

And now, it was about to be tested.

The girls braced themselves.

And waited for the impact.

The sky cracked.

Not with thunder, but with a sound sharper, more final — like glass shattering under pressure that had built for too long. The APS barrier rippled once, a shimmer of violet and blue magic trembling across its surface, and then fractured. The break was sudden, violent. Shards of containment magic rained down like falling stars, scattering across the courtyard in streaks of light that faded before they touched the ground.

Kuroe's doppel had broken through.

And in that instant, the girl was gone.

The transformation came like a storm — swift, merciless, absolute. Her shadowy wings twisted, contorted, expanded beyond recognition. Her body convulsed midair, shedding its human shape in jagged pulses of corrupted magic. The last remnants of Kuroe's face vanished beneath a veil of feathers and darkness. Her soul gem, once flickering with faint pink light, burst into black flame and disappeared into the void.

What rose in her place was not a magical girl.

It was a witch.

Ichizo.

A Nighthawk born of sorrow.

Her wings unfurled with a sound like tearing silk, stretching wide across the sky until they blotted out the stars. Each feather shimmered with a dark iridescence, etched with fragments of broken memory — glimpses of Kuroe's past, her regrets, her fears. The shape of the witch was elegant and monstrous, a silhouette of grace twisted into something predatory. Her body glowed faintly, not with light, but with the cold gleam of something that had stopped pretending to be human.

And then she screamed.

The sound tore through the air, piercing and echoing, a cry that reverberated through the bones of every magical girl in the HQ. It wasn't just loud — it was invasive. It crawled into the marrow, into the soul. It was the sound of birth, of hunger, of despair given form. It was the scream of a girl who had fallen too far, who had been consumed by everything she tried to carry alone.

The sky trembled.

The ground shuddered.

Inside the Magius command chamber, Touka and Alina turned toward the sound.

Touka's eyes widened, her mouth forming a small pout. "What was that?"

Alina stepped to the window, her gaze sharp. Her lips curled into a grin.

Outside, one section of the APS barrier lay in ruins. And beyond it, suspended in the sky, was a Nighthawk witch.

Alina scoffed. "So another miserable, hopeless girl bites the dust. How poetic."

Touka frowned. "That must be Kuroe. The Amane sisters told me she betrayed us. Led Iroha and Yachiyo into the HQ."

She turned to Alina, her voice tinged with curiosity. "Now that part of the barrier's broken... will there be any bad effects until you fix it?"

Alina's grin widened.

"I'm not completely sure," she said, her tone dripping with amusement. "But I expect... maybe, just maybe... the doppelified magical girls in the Isolation Ward might go berserk. Break out of their spheres. Maybe some of them will become witches."

Touka blinked. "That sounds... inconvenient."

Alina laughed — a cold, delighted sound that echoed through the chamber.

"Oh, it would be glorious," she said. "All that death and destruction. Perfect for a painting. The chaos, the agony — I'd capture it all. Frame it in blood and shadow."

Touka sighed, brushing a strand of hair behind her ear. "That sounds like a big pain. But oh well. It's not like the girls in the Isolation Ward were crucial to our plan. Just collateral damage."

She turned back to Alina, her tone light but firm. "Don't get too carried away in your art, please. Fix the barrier before the damage gets too big."

Alina rolled her eyes. "Fine. Yeah, sure."

But her smile lingered.

And outside, Ichizo spread her wings.

The storm had begun.

Iroha collapsed.

Her knees hit the ground with a dull thud, her hands trembling as they clutched the earth. The sky above still echoed with Ichizo's screech, but Iroha's world had narrowed to the space between her sobs — ragged, unfiltered, torn from the deepest part of her soul.

"Kuroe..." she cried, her voice cracking. "We were so close..."

Her tears fell freely, soaking into the stone beneath her. Her body shook with grief, her breath hitching between gasps. "We were almost out. We were almost home. Mikazuki Villa... we were going to live together. Fight together. Laugh together..."

She looked up, eyes red and swollen, staring at the distant silhouette of the Nighthawk witch.

"I saw it," she whispered. "A future. A bright one. For me... and for her. Why? Why did it have to go wrong at the very end?"

Behind her, Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno stood in silence. Their eyes shimmered with tears, their hearts heavy. Another magical girl. Another friend. Another soul lost to the fate they all feared.

Sana's hands shook violently as she wiped her cheeks. Felicia clenched her fists so hard her knuckles turned white, her jaw locking in a vice of helpless rage. Tsuruno simply bowed her head, her usually rigid shoulders trembling. None of them spoke. They didn't need to; Iroha's agony was a mirror of their own.

But then Yachiyo saw it.

Iroha's soul gem — once soft pink, now pulsing with black veins. The corruption was spreading fast, too fast. Her eyes went wide as she saw it: a shadow creeping across Iroha's face, curling from her temple down to her cheek.

Giovanna.

Iroha's doppel.

Yachiyo moved instantly, dropping to her knees beside Iroha and grabbing her hand.

"No," she said, voice firm but trembling. "Iroha, listen to me. You can't fall. Not now. Not after everything."

Iroha didn't respond. Her eyes were distant, unfocused.

Yachiyo squeezed her hand tighter. "You promised me. You promised you wouldn't leave my side. You promised you wouldn't die."

Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno stepped forward, surrounding Iroha in a quiet embrace. Their arms wrapped around her, their soul gems glowing faintly as they tried to connect — to share the burden, to pull her back.

But the darkness was strong.

Too strong.

It pressed in from all sides — thick, suffocating, alive. The air around them grew heavy, the sky dimmed, and the warmth of their soul gems flickered like dying embers. The girls stood close to Iroha, arms wrapped around her, trying to hold her together. But the shadows were already inside.

A voice echoed through their minds — low, inhuman, and intimate, like breath against the ear.

Giovanna.

“Iroha,” the voice hissed, each syllable dripping with venom. “You failed her.”

The words slithered into Iroha’s thoughts, coiling around her guilt.

“You let Kuroe become a witch. You weren’t strong enough. And now... you’ll join her.”

The girls flinched. Their soul gems pulsed erratically, dimming under the weight of the accusation. The warmth they had tried to share with Iroha was being devoured.

Then Giovanna looked at them.

Her face — half-formed, half-shadow — turned toward the group. Her lips curled into a demonic smile, jagged and cruel. Her eyes glowed with a sickly light, and for a moment, it felt like she was looking through them, into the deepest parts of their hearts.

“If you stay with Iroha,” she whispered, voice like silk soaked in poison, “you’ll become witches too.”

“No!” Yachiyo shouted, her voice cracking. “We won’t leave her! We won’t abandon her!”

Sana’s voice trembled. “We’re here. We’re still here.”

Felicia growled, stepping forward. “We’re not afraid of you.”

Tsuruno’s eyes blazed, her soul gem flaring. “We believe in her. In each other.”

But Giovanna laughed.

It wasn’t a sound meant for ears. It was meant for breaking things — for slicing through hope. It echoed through their minds like a blade dragged across glass.

“Friendship. Bonds. How cute.”

The shadows surged.

“Do you know what’s stronger than all of that?” Giovanna whispered, her voice rising like a crescendo of cruelty. “Complete and utter despair!”

And then she showed them.

Darkness exploded outward — a wave of pure negativity, magnified by Iroha’s grief, her guilt, her self-hatred. It slammed into the girls like a tidal force, knocking the breath from their lungs, severing the

fragile threads of connect they had tried to weave. Their soul gems dimmed, their magic faltered, their hearts recoiled.

The connection failed.

They staggered back, stunned, their bodies trembling, their minds reeling. The warmth they had tried to share was gone. Rejected. Drowned.

Iroha's face was nearly gone now — the mask of Giovanna spreading fast, curling around her eyes, her mouth, her thoughts. Her body was still, her soul gem pulsing with black veins. The girl they loved was slipping away.

Deja vu.

Just like Kuroe.

Yachiyo fell to her forearms, her physical strength entirely drained, her vision blurred by a hot rush of tears. She had watched this tragedy play out too many times. She had buried too many friends. But this time, the knife cut deeper. Because she knew exactly how the script ended. And she was entirely powerless to rewrite it.

"Please..." she whispered into the dirt, her voice cracking into nothingness. "Please don't let her fall..."

Her hands clawed at the stone, nails scraping.

"Please... someone... anyone..."

She collapsed entirely, her forehead pressed against the cold earth as her own soul gem began to pulse with a slow, heavy, suffocating darkness.

Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno turned to her, eyes wide with fear.

Yachiyo — their anchor, their guide, the one who always stood tall — was unraveling.

If this kept up...

She would fall too.

Chapter 8: Grace vs Despair

The air was still.

The sky above still rippled with the violent aftershocks of Ichizo's screech, the residue of her despair lingering in the atmosphere like toxic smoke. Below, Iroha knelt in a catatonic silence, her soul gem pulsing with angry, obsidian veins. Beside her, Yachiyo's hands remained pressed against the stone, her tears bleeding into the dirt, while Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno stood frozen—their hope sputtering out like a dying flame.

Then—

A voice.

Soft. Calm. Soothing.

Your cry is heard, Yachiyo.

The telepathic words drifted into their minds like a cool breeze through an open window, gentle and entirely unintrusive.

Kuroe. Iroha. You were so close.

The words wrapped around them like silk.

So close to starting a new life. A happy one. At Mikazuki Villa. With Yachiyo, Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno.

The girls' eyes widened. They looked around, startled, searching for the source. The voice was familiar — achingly so.

Iroha's breath caught. Yachiyo's gaze sharpened.

And then, in perfect unison, they whispered:

“Lunaria.”

A figure appeared in the sky.

Small at first, distant. But unmistakable.

A lone girl, ascending into the heavens with a serene, effortless posture. Her cloak billowed behind her like wings of moonlight. Her face was calm, composed — but her eyes held something deeper. A quiet sorrow. A knowing ache.

Lunaria.

The magical girls stared, stunned.

“She's flying,” Felicia murmured.

“But... where's her soul gem?” Sana asked.

Tsuruno shook her head. “I still don't understand what she is...”

Yachiyo's voice was quiet. “She's going toward Ichizo.”

The Nighthawk witch hovered above, wings unfurled like blades of shadow, her body pulsing with corrupted magic. Her form was vast now, more monstrous than anything they had seen in Kuroe's doppel — a predator fully awakened. Her feathers shimmered with oily iridescence, each one a shard of memory twisted by despair. Her eyes glowed with a cold, hunting light, unblinking and cruel.

She saw Lunaria.

And reacted.

Shadow feather bullets erupted from her wings in jagged spirals, slicing through the air with shrieks of velocity. They spun like razors, trailing black mist. Talon-shaped projectiles followed, curved and serrated, spinning like sickles hurled by a storm. Beak-shaped bursts of magic tore forward, each one honed to pierce, to rip, to consume — the weapons of a hunter, conjured from the deepest instincts of a bird of prey.

The girls gasped.

The barrage was relentless. Terrifying. More vicious than anything they had seen from Kuroe's doppel. Ichizo was a witch in full form — a predator unleashed. The sky itself seemed to recoil from the violence, the air thick with the scent of scorched magic and the pressure of raw despair.

And Lunaria?

She didn't flinch.

She flew forward, her body weaving through the onslaught with impossible grace. Her cloak billowed behind her like a trail of moonlight, catching the wind and folding around her limbs in fluid arcs. Her arms moved like water, her legs like wind. She didn't dodge — she danced.

A feather bullet spun toward her chest. She twisted her torso just enough to let it pass, her breath steady, her gaze serene. A talon-shaped projectile came from below — she dipped, her knee folding inward, her foot flicking the attack away with a precise, feather-light touch. She didn't stop the attack. She let it continue its descent, using the contact to guide herself upward.

Then came the beaks — jagged bursts of magic, sharp and fast. Lunaria turned mid-air, her spine arching in a perfect crescent. Her forearm intercepted one, her shoulder rolled through another, and her hip deflected the third. Each point of contact was chosen with eerie precision, not to resist, but to redirect herself — a conversation of motion, not force.

Her limbs flowed like silk threads in the wind, never stiff, never panicked. Every motion was a response, a continuation of Ichizo's aggression turned into exquisite choreography. Her body became a canvas of motion, each limb a brushstroke painting serenity into violence.

To the girls below, it was mesmerizing.

Lunaria's body was a symphony of motion — each twist a note, each dodge a pause, each tap a gentle crescendo. She didn't just respond to Ichizo. She understood her. She read the witch's movements like poetry and replied with grace.

And through it all, she remained untouched.

Ichizo shrieked again, her cry splitting the sky like a blade. Her wings beat once — and the air ignited.

A second barrage erupted from her body, more vicious than the first. Shadow feather bullets spiraled outward in dense, chaotic patterns, their edges serrated with magical venom. Talon-shaped projectiles followed, sharp and curved, spinning like sickles. Beak-shaped bursts of energy tore through the sky, each one honed to pierce, to shred, to devour.

The sky became a storm of predation.

And Lunaria continued straight into it.

She didn't hesitate. Didn't summon a shield. Didn't raise a weapon.

She danced — with more intensity than before.

Her body moved with impossible grace, weaving through the chaos like silk in a hurricane. Her arms swept in wide arcs, her legs folding and extending with the rhythm of breath. She didn't resist the attacks — she flowed with them. A feather bullet sliced toward her chest, and she turned her shoulder just enough to let it pass, her body spinning with the momentum. A talon-shaped projectile came from above — she raised her forearm, not to block, but to tap it lightly, using the contact to push herself away, letting the attack continue its descent behind her.

She was using the attacks to redirect herself closer to Ichizo.

A beak-shaped burst of magic screamed toward her from the side. Lunaria twisted mid-air, her cloak catching the edge of the blast and folding around it like a ribbon. Her knee bent, her foot brushed the air, and she spun away, the projectile missing her by inches and continuing its path toward the ground.

Each movement was precise. Minimal. Beautiful.

Her fingertips brushed a feather bullet, and she used the contact to pivot, her body arcing in a slow, deliberate spiral. Her heel caught the edge of a talon, and she let it carry her upward, her body folding into a backflip that brought her closer to Ichizo.

She moved with the attacks, not against them. She let them pass, let them fall, let them scream past her like wind through trees. Her body was a study in control — not rigid, not reactive, but responsive. Every motion was a conversation with gravity, with momentum, with the violence around her.

There was no flash of power. No surge of magical energy.

Just movement.

The girls watched, mouths open, hearts stilled.

"She's not even trying to fight it..." Felicia whispered, her hammer lowering.

"It's like... a ritual," Sana's eyes shimmered with tears. "She's dancing for her."

Tsuruno's breath caught. "I never knew you could face a Witch like that..."

"So this is what Lunaria is," Yachiyo's voice trembled, a spark of reverence returning to her eyes.
"Beautiful..."

Beside them, the frantic pulsing of Iroha's soul gem suddenly slowed.

The suffocating black veins began to recede, melting back into the pink glass. She stared upward, tears still clinging to her lashes, her frantic breathing finally dropping into a steady rhythm. Lunaria's movements weren't just a distraction; they were an anchor. The despair that had been on the verge of

consuming Iroha was being held at bay—not by a clash of weapons, but by the sheer, undeniable weight of beauty.

"If Lunaria can do this..." Iroha whispered, her voice filled with a fragile, reborn hope. "Maybe... just maybe, she can save Kuroe."

Sana's voice broke the silence first, soft but steady.

"It's good that you still have hope, Iroha," she said gently. "But... I'm sorry. Kuroe's a witch now."

Felicia nodded, her eyes shadowed. "Her self is gone. That's what happens when a magical girl falls too far. The witch takes over. There's no coming back."

Tsuruno's voice was quiet, unusually subdued. "Even the Wings of the Magius... they built the APS system to stop this. To keep us from becoming witches. If they thought there was a way to bring someone back, they would've used it. But they didn't. They must've concluded it's impossible."

Iroha clenched her fists.

She didn't argue. She knew her friends were trying to keep her grounded, trying to protect her from false hope. And they were right — everything they said was true. She had seen it herself. Once a soul gem shattered, once the witch emerged, there was no magical girl left to save.

But still...

Her eyes lifted to the sky.

Lunaria.

A girl with no soul gem. A girl who could fly, who could deflect a witch's barrage with nothing but movement and grace. A girl who was confronting with Ichizo without a single spell, without a single weapon.

Maybe...

Just maybe...

She could do something.

Ichizo shrieked again, her body twisting in fury. Her wings beat once — and then she struck.

One of her massive black wings swept toward Lunaria in a brutal arc, fast and heavy. The air split around it, gales roaring outward in concentric waves. The force was immense, enough to blow away anyone in its path, to send even the strongest magical girl tumbling through the sky.

Iroha, Yachiyo, Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno braced themselves, eyes wide, hearts pounding.

But Lunaria's face remained unchanged.

Calm.

Her eyes still held that same sorrow — quiet, ancient, knowing.

She reached out with one hand.

And pressed it gently against Ichizo's wing.

There was no resistance. No clash. Just a touch — graceful, deliberate, soft.

Then, with a subtle shift of her body, Lunaria pushed against the wing and let the momentum carry her upward. She moved with the gale, not against it, her cloak fluttering wildly in the wind, her hair streaming like ribbons of moonlight.

The strike passed beneath her.

And Lunaria rose.

She landed on Ichizo's head with the lightness of a falling petal.

She smiled.

Then sat down.

Lunaria's posture was relaxed. Composed.

She sat atop Ichizo's head as if the witch were not a creature of despair, but a wounded bird in need of comfort. Her cloak fluttered gently in the lingering wind, her hair trailing like strands of moonlight. One hand extended, slow and deliberate, and came to rest atop Ichizo's feathers — not with force, but with grace. Her fingers barely pressed, as if afraid to disturb something fragile. The gesture was intimate. Reverent. Like a lullaby in motion.

The girls below stared in stunned silence.

"She... she did it," Felicia whispered, her voice barely audible.

"She's on Ichizo now," Sana said, eyes wide. "Is she going to attack? Is this the end for Ichizo... and Kuroe?"

Tsuruno's brow furrowed, her gaze locked on Lunaria's stillness. "But look at her... her body language. It's too calm. Too gentle."

Yachiyo's voice was hushed, almost reverent. "Yes... too calm and gentle to be an attack..."

Iroha's breath caught in her throat. "Then... what is Lunaria doing?"

They watched, hearts suspended, breath held, unsure of what would happen next. The air around them felt frozen — not with cold, but with anticipation. The witch beneath Lunaria twitched, her wings pulsing with residual fury, but Lunaria didn't move. She simply sat, hand resting, eyes soft.

Then Lunaria spoke.

Her voice echoed through their minds — telepathic, soft, and warm. It didn't pierce like Giovanna's had. It wrapped around them like a blanket, gentle and steady.

Kuroe. Iroha. You were so close.

So close to living a happy life together at Mikazuki Villa. With Yachiyo. With Sana. With Felicia. With Tsuruno.

Wouldn't it be sad... if everything broke apart now?

Her hand remained on Ichizo's head, unmoving. The witch's body trembled beneath her, feathers rustling, but Lunaria didn't flinch.

Please, she whispered. Try to remember your promise. The one you made to Iroha. That you'd catch up. That you'd come back to her.

Iroha gasped.

Her eyes widened, shimmering with tears.

"That promise..." she whispered. "How does she know?"

She remembered it vividly — Kuroe's voice, trembling but determined, as she pushed Iroha through the portal before it closed. *I'll catch up. I promise.*

Had Lunaria been watching?

Had she seen everything?

Yachiyo turned to the others, her voice low and filled with awe. "She's not fighting the witch..."

"She's... communicating," Sana finished, her voice barely above a breath.

Tsuruno's eyes narrowed, trying to make sense of it. "Is that even possible? Can you talk to a witch? To the magical girl inside?"

"I've never heard of anything like it," Sana murmured.

Felicia's voice was quiet. "But if anyone could do it... maybe it's her."

They looked up again, eyes wide, hearts trembling.

Lunaria sat calmly atop the witch's head, her hand resting like a benediction, her voice echoing through the air like a prayer.

And for the first time ever, they dared to believe — truly believe — that there might be another way to break the magical girl cycle.

Not through becoming a witch.

Not through the fragile containment of the APS.

Not through the volatile release of a doppel.

But through something else.

The silence that followed Lunaria's words was fragile.

The wind stirred gently around her, rustling the feathers beneath her hand. Ichizo's body trembled, her wings twitching with residual tension. For a moment, it felt as though something might shift — as though Lunaria's voice had reached a place no one else could.

Then—

A voice replied.

Dark.

Heavy.

Saturated with despair.

It echoed not through the air, but through their minds — low and jagged, like rust scraping against bone.

Kuroe no longer exists.

She is gone. Dead.

Only I remain.

Ichizo's voice.

The girls froze.

She abandoned a magical girl, the voice continued, each word dripping with malice. Kuro. She left her behind. Left her to suffer. Kuroe is not worthy of friendship. Not worthy of Mikazuki Villa. Not worthy of Iroha. Or Yachiyo. Or Sana. Or Felicia. Or Tsuruno.

She is where she belongs.

A witch.

A creature hated by magical girls. Feared by humans. Born to cause harm.

The words hit like a wave.

Iroha staggered back, her breath catching. Her soul gem pulsed faintly, a flicker of black returning. She had heard these words before — not from Ichizo, but from Giovanna. The same contempt. The same despair. The same cruel logic.

Giovanna had preyed on her guilt. Had whispered that she wasn't strong enough. That she had failed Kuroe. That she deserved to fall.

And Iroha had almost believed it.

Yachiyo stepped forward, her voice quiet. "That's what Giovanna used against you."

Iroha nodded, trembling. "She drowned me in it. All that guilt. All that fear. I couldn't fight it."

Sana's eyes were wide. "We tried to connect with you... but it was like our magic couldn't reach you."

Felicia clenched her fists. "It was like being swallowed. Like our hope didn't matter."

Tsuruno's voice was soft. "And now we're hearing it again. From Kuroe's witch."

Yachiyo's gaze darkened. "So this is why Kuroe's doppel was so strong."

She looked up at Ichizo, her eyes filled with sorrow.

"Kuroe's guilt... it wasn't just a moment. It was something she carried for a long time. Something she bottled up. Suppressed. Hid from everyone."

She paused.

"And when all of it finally broke free... it became her doppel. And then her witch."

She turned to the others. "That's the terrifying thing about doppels. They're not just bursts of emotion. They're reservoirs. And when they rupture..."

The girls said nothing.

They didn't need to.

They felt it.

The weight of Kuroe's despair. The truth of her fall.

But then Sana spoke, her voice trembling. "Even so, here we are. We're hearing her. We're hearing Ichizo."

Felicia blinked. "Lunaria is really doing it... she is talking to a witch."

Tsuruno's voice was hushed. "I thought witches couldn't speak. That they were just... monsters."

Yachiyo shook her head slowly. "That's what we were taught. That witches are pure despair. That they can't be reached."

Iroha looked up at Lunaria, still seated calmly atop Ichizo's head, her hand resting like a prayer.

"But Lunaria is talking to her," she whispered. "And Ichizo is answering."

The thought settled over them like mist.

If witches could speak...

Could they listen?

If despair could be heard...

Could it be healed?

None of them said it aloud.

But the question hung in the air.

If talking with a witch is possible...

Then is bringing the magical girl back possible?

But Lunaria was not deterred.

She remained seated atop Ichizo's head, her hand resting gently against the witch's feathers, her eyes half-lidded with sorrow — not fear, not judgment. The wind stirred around her, catching the folds of her cloak, but she did not move. Her voice, when it came again, was soft. Steady. Like a lullaby remembered from childhood, or a prayer whispered in the dark.

Kuroe, she said, how long will you dwell on past regrets?

Yes, you made mistakes. All of you have. Every magical girl carries regrets. Some small. Some unbearable. And one regret binds you all — the contract. The moment you said yes to Kyubey. The moment you traded your soul for a wish you barely understood.

But that doesn't mean you don't deserve peace.

That doesn't mean you don't deserve joy.

Her voice didn't rise. It didn't plead. It simply... was. Like moonlight on water. Like breath in winter.

You don't have to earn joy, Kuroe. You are allowed to feel it. Even now. Especially now. Joy is not a luxury. It is nourishment. It is what keeps the soul from starving.

Life — your life — is beautiful. Not because it's perfect. Not because it's painless. But because it's alive. Because it moves. Because it breathes.

Its value doesn't lie in power. Or in how many people you save. Or how many mistakes you avoid. Its value lies in the quiet moments. The living, breathing ones. Every breath. Every thought. Every bond you form... it's all a small miracle.

It's a form of magic.

Below, the girls listened in silence.

Iroha's hands trembled at her sides, her soul gem still faintly glowing. Her eyes shimmered, wide and wet, as Lunaria's words wrapped around her like a second heartbeat. She felt them settle into the hollow places inside her — the ones that had been carved out by grief, by guilt, by the endless ache of trying to save everyone and always falling short.

Yachiyo stood still, her breath caught in her throat. She had spent so long surviving. So long believing that survival was the only thing she was allowed. That joy was something for other people. That her role was to endure, to lead, to carry the weight. But now, hearing Lunaria speak, something inside her cracked. Not in pain — but in recognition.

Sana's lips parted, her eyes wide. Felicia's fists slowly unclenched. Tsuruno's shoulders, always held high with forced cheer, softened.

They all felt it.

The truth of it.

The bonds you started to form here, Lunaria continued, *with Iroha. With Yachiyo. With Sana. With Felicia. With Tsuruno. With Mitama. With Mifuyu. With Momoko. With Rena...*

They are beautiful.

They are small miracles.

They are magic.

Please... don't throw them away. Not now. Not when they're just beginning to bloom.

The wind quieted.

The sky held its breath.

And in that stillness, something shifted.

Not in the air.

But in them.

In the girls who had fought so long. Who had bled and broken and kept going because they didn't know what else to do. Who had learned to brace for loss, to expect betrayal, to carry grief like armor. Who had forgotten what it meant to feel joy without guilt. Who had forgotten that they were allowed to want more than survival.

Lunaria's words didn't erase their pain.

But they made space for something else.

Something warmer.

Something alive.

The silence that followed was not empty. It was full — full of breath, of memory, of the quiet stirrings of something long buried. The girls stood together, not just as comrades in battle, but as people. As souls. As girls who had once dreamed of happiness and had been told, again and again, that it was naïve.

But now, they felt it.

Not as a distant hope.

But as a presence.

Iroha looked at Yachiyo, and for the first time in days, she didn't see the weight Yachiyo carried — she saw the way Yachiyo had always stood beside her. Protected her. Believed in her. Even when she couldn't believe in herself.

Yachiyo looked back, and saw not a burden, but a bond. A thread that had been woven through every moment they had shared. Not perfect. Not painless. But real.

Sana felt Felicia's hand brush against hers, and instead of flinching, she held it. Felicia didn't speak, but her grip tightened — not in fear, but in presence. In solidarity.

Tsuruno stepped closer, her usual bravado quieted. She didn't need to perform, didn't need to pretend to be strong. Not here. Not now. She just needed to be.

And in that moment, they all felt it.

The warmth of each other's company.

Not as background noise.

Not as a tactical advantage.

But as something sacred.

Something worth cherishing.

Their soul gems pulsed — faintly at first, then brighter. The black veins that had crept across Iroha's gem began to recede, curling inward like shadows chased by dawn. Yachiyo's gem shimmered, the darkness lifting, replaced by a soft, steady glow.

Lunaria's words had reached them.

The bonds you started to form here... they are beautiful. Small miracles. Magic.

They had always known it, somewhere deep inside. But now, they felt it. Intentionally. Fully. They let themselves feel it.

The air trembled.

Ichizo's voice returned, darker than before — not just despairing, but laced with contempt. It echoed through the sky like a sneer, a jagged whisper that scraped against the edges of thought.

What do you know?

You don't even have a soul gem.

You're not a magical girl.

You don't understand us. You don't understand what it means to suffer. To fight. To fall.

Stop pretending to be the wise one on a high horse. Stop speaking like you know more than me. More than other witches. More than magical girls.

The words struck like knives.

Iroha's breath caught. Yachiyo's shoulders tensed. Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno stood frozen, their hearts in their throats.

They had seen Lunaria deflect Ichizo's attacks with grace. They had heard her speak with warmth and wisdom. But now, faced with the witch's scorn, they felt the weight of uncertainty press down on them.

Was Lunaria truly something else?

Was she pretending?

Would she finally reveal who — or what — she really was?

Then Lunaria chuckled.

Soft.

Gentle.

Not mocking. Not amused.

Just... sad.

"The thing is," she said, her voice like wind through leaves, "I do understand."

"I do know how magical girls feel."

Her words hung in the air, tinged with emotions too complex to name. Iroha felt a pang of nostalgia. Yachiyo sensed sorrow. Sana heard reflection. Felicia caught longing. Tsuruno felt something like recognition.

None of them could fully grasp it.

But all of them felt it.

Lunaria's voice carried the weight of someone who had seen too much, felt too deeply, and still chose to speak with kindness.

She closed her eyes.

And then, calmly but firmly, she spoke a single word.

"Dis-connect."

The sound reverberated not just through their minds, but through the entire night sky. Through the HQ. Through the broken barrier. Through the witch's body.

Iroha, Yachiyo, Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno felt it ripple through them — a pulse of something ancient and unfamiliar. Their lips moved before they could think, voices joining in unison.

“Dis-connect.”

They didn’t know what it meant.

But they felt it.

Like a key turning in a lock.

Like a door opening in the dark.

And somewhere deep inside Ichizo...

Something stirred.

A bright light began to emanate from Ichizo.

It wasn’t harsh or blinding — it was warm. Gentle. Like sunlight filtered through morning mist. Iroha, Yachiyo, Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno instinctively closed their eyes, shielding themselves from the sudden radiance. The air around them shifted, no longer heavy with despair, but light with something else. Something sacred.

Then they heard Lunaria’s voice again.

This time, it was directed to them.

“Iroha,” she said softly, “Kasumi and I found out more about Ui today.”

Their eyes snapped open.

Each girl brought a hand to her mouth, breath caught, hearts stilled.

They were no longer in the HQ.

They stood in a strange spiritual plane — a realm of golden light and drifting mist. The ground beneath them was soft, undefined, like clouds woven into silk. The air shimmered with warmth, and the sky above was a canvas of soft hues, gold and rose and pale blue. It felt timeless. Weightless. Like a memory made real.

And there, before them, stood Lunaria.

Her smile was gentle, radiant. The golden light kissed her features, making her seem even more ethereal — not distant, but deeply present. Her cloak fluttered in a breeze that didn’t stir the mist. Her eyes held the same sorrow, the same knowing, but now there was something else too.

Warmth and openness.

The girls looked around, searching for Kuroe, for Ichizo — but they were nowhere in sight.

Only Lunaria.

Only light.

When they had gathered themselves, when the awe had settled into breath, Iroha stepped forward. Her voice trembled with emotion.

“You found out more about Ui?” she asked, eyes wide. “Please... please tell me.”

Lunaria nodded.

“This morning,” she said, “before we left Mikazuki Villa, Kasumi and I pet the little Kyubey. And in that moment... we realized something.”

She paused.

“We were able to communicate with her, but very briefly. Just enough to get a lead on who Ui is.”

She looked at Iroha, her gaze tender.

“And the most important part... is that the little Kyubey is Ui, your little sister.”

Iroha’s breath caught.

Her knees nearly buckled.

Yachiyo reached out instinctively, steadying her.

Sana gasped. Felicia’s eyes went wide. Tsuruno’s hand flew to her chest.

“She’s... my sister?” Iroha whispered.

Lunaria nodded. “Yes. Ui is your younger sister.”

The silence that followed was thick with emotion.

Yachiyo’s mind raced. She thought back — to all the times the little Kyubey had appeared. Always at the right moment. Always leading them to safety, to answers. She remembered the strange behavior of Lunaria and Kasumi when they touched the creature — the way they had gone quiet, distant, as if hearing something no one else could.

“It makes sense,” Yachiyo said slowly. “She’s always helped us. Guided us. And you two... you were hiding something. I knew it.”

Iroha’s eyes filled with tears.

So all those visions — the fleeting glimpses of a pink-haired girl, the ache in her chest, the sense that something was missing — they weren’t illusions. They weren’t dreams.

They were memories.

Real.

True.

“I always knew,” Iroha whispered. “I always felt it. That Ui was connected to me. That she was... mine.”

She pressed a hand to her heart, and for the first time in what felt like forever, she felt whole.

Yachiyo turned to Lunaria again, her voice steadier now. “So you were able to communicate with Ui. Just like you did with Ichizo. How? No one’s ever been able to speak to her. And we didn’t think witches could be spoken to at all.”

Iroha stepped forward, her voice trembling. “What happened to her? What happened to Ui? Why is she in the small Kyubey? And why do I remember her... but Touka doesn’t?”

Lunaria’s expression softened.

She didn’t answer right away.

She let the questions hang in the air, let the mist swirl around them, let the golden light settle into their skin.

And then she chuckled slowly, and began to speak.

“Yachiyo, you are very sharp,” she said, her gaze warm. “During our brief conversation with Ui at Mikazuki Villa... she dropped a few bombshells.”

The girls leaned in, breath held.

“She told us,” Lunaria continued, “that it was the first time she had spoken to anyone since she became a witch.”

Silence.

Then shock.

Iroha’s body trembled. Her hands flew to her mouth, her eyes wide with disbelief. “No...” she whispered. “That... that can’t be possible.”

Her voice cracked.

“My sister... my Ui... a witch?”

The words tasted bitter. Unthinkable. The sorrow that bloomed in her chest was sharp and immediate, like a blade drawn across memory. She had spent so long searching. So long hoping. And now, to hear that Ui had fallen — that she had become the very thing they all feared — it made her heart feel heavy, hollow.

Yachiyo placed a hand on Iroha’s shoulder, steadying her. Her own expression was taut with grief, but her eyes remained focused. “And I assume she said it’s related to the Wings of the Magius?”

Lunaria nodded. “Ui said it’s a long story. One we’ll need time to understand.”

The girls exchanged glances, their minds racing.

If the small Kyubey was a witch — then why had it always helped them? Why had it appeared at moments of need, guided them, protected them? It didn't look hostile. It didn't act like a witch. It didn't even feel like one.

"What is going on?" Felicia muttered. "How does this make sense?"

Sana's voice was quiet. "Did the Wings of the Magius... find a way to turn witches into small Kyubeys? Harmless ones? Ones that still carry the personality of the magical girl they used to be?"

Tsuruno frowned. "If they did... why haven't they made more? Why are they farming witches to feed Embryo Eve? Why are doppelified magical girls locked in a ward?"

The questions came fast, overlapping, urgent.

Lunaria listened.

She didn't interrupt.

When the silence returned, she spoke again.

"Kasumi and I didn't press Ui further," she said. "We didn't want to arouse suspicion. We were already sitting too long with our hands on the small Kyubey. We didn't want Iroha, Yachiyo, or Kuroe to notice."

She paused.

"But we promised her. Ui, Kasumi, and I — we promised to talk again. Soon."

The girls nodded, their expressions solemn.

"And as for how Ui's story connects to the Wings of the Magius," Lunaria continued, "Kasumi and I found out more while exploring the HQ. Before Kuroe became doppelified."

Iroha, Yachiyo, Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno leaned in instinctively, eyes locked on Lunaria, hearts pounding. They were fully present now — no longer grieving, no longer doubting. Just listening.

Lunaria's voice softened.

"After you all left the Doppel Isolation Ward," she said, "Kasumi and I went our own way. We wanted to understand the Wings of the Magius. Their true intentions. Their secrets."

"Our first stop," she continued, "was Embryo Eve."

The girls stiffened.

"That artificial witch," Yachiyo said. "It's the cornerstone of their plan. The heart of spreading the APS system to the entire world."

Lunaria nodded. "We touched it. Kasumi and I both placed our hands on its surface."

She paused.

“And in that moment... we understood.”

“Embryo Eve,” she said, “is the body of the witch Ui became.”

The silence that followed was absolute.

Not even the mist stirred.

Lunaria’s eyes shimmered in the golden light. “Her soul... is in the small Kyubey. But her witch’s body... is Embryo Eve.”

Iroha’s breath hitched.

Her knees buckled.

Yachiyo caught her again, holding her close.

Sana’s eyes filled with tears. Felicia stared, stunned. Tsuruno pressed a hand to her chest, trying to steady her heartbeat.

“She’s been with us,” Iroha whispered. “All this time. Watching. Guiding. And... she’s Embryo Eve?”

Lunaria nodded. “That’s all Kasumi and I know for now. We’ll need to speak with Ui again. A proper conversation. A long one.”

The golden light around them pulsed gently, like a heartbeat in the mist.

Iroha, Yachiyo, Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno stood in silence, their expressions caught between awe and disorientation. The revelations had come fast — too fast — and each one had chipped away at the foundation of what they thought they knew. Lunaria’s mysterious powers. Her ability to speak to witches. The invocation of “dis-connect,” a word none of them had ever heard before. And now, the idea that a magical girl’s soul could be separated from her witch body and placed into another vessel — something that defied everything they had been taught.

It was overwhelming.

It was transformative.

It was terrifying.

Yachiyo stepped forward, her posture steady, her eyes sharp. She looked at Lunaria with quiet intensity — not accusatory, but searching.

“Thank you,” she said, voice firm. “For sharing all of this with us.”

She paused.

“But why now?”

Her gaze didn’t waver.

“Why did you and Kasumi hide the fact that you could communicate with the small Kyubey? That the small Kyubey was Ui? That would’ve been good to know earlier.”

Iroha nodded, her voice soft but trembling. “She’s my sister. My little sister. Why keep that from me?”

Lunaria chuckled — not dismissively, but with a kind of gentle regret. Her smile was tinged with sorrow, her eyes reflecting the weight of the choice she had made.

“I understand,” she said. “Truly.”

She looked at Iroha, then Yachiyo, then the others.

“The reason we didn’t tell you earlier,” she continued, “was because we were afraid. Not for ourselves — but for you.”

She folded her hands in front of her, the golden mist curling around her wrists like ribbons.

“If we had told you that Ui was in the small Kyubey... that she was a witch... we feared you might act rashly. That you, Yachiyo, or Kuroe might confront the Wings of the Magius leaders — Touka, Alina, especially Nemu — without a plan. Without protection. Just to hear their side of the story.”

Her voice softened.

“That could have put you in grave danger.”

The girls listened, their expressions shifting from confusion to understanding.

“The HQ is not safe,” Lunaria said. “You’ve seen it yourselves. What happened to Kaede. To Kuroe. To all those doppelified magical girls. To Embryo Eve, consuming witches to awaken.”

She paused.

“We didn’t want that to happen to you.”

Iroha’s eyes shimmered. She thought of Kuroe — of her fall, her scream, her transformation. She thought of the Isolation Ward, of the girls trapped inside, their souls flickering like dying stars. She thought of Embryo Eve, vast and silent, feeding on despair.

And she understood.

Yachiyo nodded slowly. “You waited for the right moment.”

Lunaria smiled. “We did.”

“Iroha seemed desperate to meet Nemu,” she continued. “To ask about Ui. But Nemu wasn’t in the HQ. And I feared you might go back in. Alone. Unprepared.”

She looked at them all.

“I didn’t want this to happen again.”

Iroha stepped forward, her voice quiet. “I understand now.”

Yachiyo placed a hand on Lunaria's shoulder. "We appreciate your caution. Your care."

Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno nodded in agreement, their expressions softening.

The mist around them swirled gently, the golden light deepening.

And for a moment, there was peace.

Not because the world was fixed.

But because they were no longer alone in trying to understand it.

The golden mist around them began to soften, the light dimming into a gentle glow. The tension that had gripped their hearts slowly unraveled, replaced by a lighter, more curious energy. The revelations had been staggering — the truth about Ui, the nature of Embryo Eve — but now that the storm had passed, the girls found themselves filled not with fear, but with questions.

A flurry of voices rose at once.

"What will happen to Kuroe?" Iroha asked, her voice trembling with hope and worry.

"What was that technique you used?" Yachiyo added. "'Dis-connect'... what does it mean? What does it do?"

Sana leaned forward. "How can you talk to witches? And to Ui?"

Felicia crossed her arms, eyes narrowed. "What are you and Kasumi planning to do now? Are you going to keep investigating the Wings of the Magius?"

Tsuruno tilted her head. "And most importantly... who are you? Why did you show up here? Why help us? Where's Kasumi?"

Their voices overlapped, not frantic, but full of urgency — the kind that comes when something impossible has just brushed against reality and left behind a trail of wonder.

Lunaria laughed softly.

It was a gentle sound, like wind chimes stirred by a breeze. Her smile remained warm, her posture relaxed, as if she had expected this moment all along.

"We'll meet again," she said, her voice like sunlight through leaves. "Very soon."

She looked at each of them in turn, her gaze lingering with quiet affection.

"Hopefully Kasumi and I will know more about Ui by then. And we'll share everything we can."

She paused.

"Until then... farewell."

Her final words were soft.

“Please stay safe.”

“No—wait!” Iroha blurted out, stepping forward. “Please don’t go!”

“At least answer some of our questions!” Yachiyo added, her voice rising.

“Just a few more!” Sana pleaded.

Felicia reached out. “You can’t just vanish!”

Tsuruno’s eyes shimmered. “Please...”

But it was no use.

The light around Lunaria began to dissolve, folding inward like petals closing at dusk. The mist swirled once, then faded. The warmth receded. And then—

They opened their eyes.

They were back.

Outside the HQ.

The courtyard was quiet, the air still. The APS barrier above still bore a jagged hole, its edges flickering with unstable magic. But there was no sign of Kuroe’s witch. No sign of Lunaria. No feathers. No light.

It was as if they had never been there.

The girls looked around, blinking in confusion.

Was it a dream?

A vision?

Had they imagined it?

Iroha turned to Yachiyo, her voice barely a whisper. “Did... did Lunaria save Kuroe?”

“Or did she defeat her?” Felicia asked. “Take the grief seed?”

“Where are they?” Sana murmured.

Tsuruno looked up at the sky, her brow furrowed. “Did any of that really happen?”

They had answers — fragments of truth, glimpses of something deeper. But they had even more questions now. About Ui. About witches. About Lunaria and Kasumi. About the nature of magic itself.

They stood together, quiet, thoughtful.

And somewhere deep inside each of them...

A seed of hope remained.

Chapter 9: Doppel rampage

Touka stared at the sky, her eyes narrowed, her mind racing.

The hole in the APS barrier still shimmered faintly, a jagged wound in the sky. But the witch was gone. Lunaria was gone. No feathers. No light. No trace.

She rubbed her temples, trying to piece together what she had just witnessed.

Kuroe's doppel had taken over — that much was clear. It had flown toward the barrier, shattered it, and triggered her transformation into a full-fledged witch. That part made sense. It was textbook. Predictable.

But then came the girl.

The one who had appeared midair, serene and unarmed. The one who had deflected Ichizo's attacks without magic. The one who had sat atop the witch's head like she was comforting a wounded animal.

Lunaria.

Touka had never met her, but she recognized her from the Kamihama school talent show — the special guest flutist whose performance had rippled through the hearts of magical girls across the city. Touka had watched it through the venue's broadcast, along with the rest of the Wings of the Magius. She remembered the way the music had made her chest ache, the way it had stirred something she couldn't name.

Just like Kasumi's performance.

Touka frowned.

Maybe they were friends. Travelers. Wanderers who moved from place to place, leaving behind echoes of something deeper. Neither of them had soul gems. Neither of them fit into any known category.

So how had Lunaria gotten into the HQ?

And what had she done to Kuroe's witch?

It hadn't looked like a battle. There were no spells. No explosions. No grief seed harvested. Just a girl sitting calmly on a witch's head, placing her hand gently, like a benediction.

Was she... communicating?

That should be impossible.

Witches didn't speak. Witches didn't listen.

And yet, the only word Touka had heard — the only word that had echoed through the HQ like a bell tolling in the dark — was Lunaria's final invocation:

“Dis-connect.”

Then the light.

Then nothing.

Touka clenched her jaw.

What was “dis-connect”? Was Kasumi here too? Who were these girls? Where had they gone?

She hated not knowing.

She hated gaps in her understanding.

The next time she saw Kasumi — or Lunaria — she would ask very specific questions. No more riddles. No more performances. She wanted answers. She need them.

Alina, meanwhile, was transfixed.

Her gaze lingered on the sky, her lips curled into a quiet smile.

She had always been fascinated by the line between life and death. By the transformation of magical girls into witches. By the beauty of despair. And what she had just witnessed — it touched all of those themes.

Kuroe had become a witch.

And then, a mysterious girl — Lunaria, Touka had called her — had arrived. Had done something. Had saved her? Defeated her? Sent her away?

Alina didn’t know.

She didn’t understand what she had just witnessed — not fully. But she wanted to. Desperately.

She wanted to meet Lunaria. To talk to her. To dissect her. Not with cruelty, but with curiosity. To understand what kind of girl could sit atop a witch’s head and speak to it like a sister. What kind of girl could invoke a word like “dis-connect” and make the entire HQ tremble. What kind of girl could disappear in a burst of light, leaving behind no wreckage, no grief seed, no trace.

If she was still alive, that is.

Alina’s fingers twitched with anticipation.

But she didn’t dwell on it.

Her attention shifted.

The Isolation Ward.

The doppelified magical girls.

The ones who had been locked away, contained, silenced. Their emotions bottled up, their magic restrained, their despair simmering just beneath the surface.

And now?

Now the barrier was broken.

Now the containment was failing.

Now the chaos was about to unfold.

That was the real art.

Not the sterile elegance of Lunaria's dance. Not the quiet miracle of soul and witch parting ways.

No — this was raw.

Unfiltered.

The eruption of emotion. The collapse of control. The beauty of destruction.

Alina could already imagine it — the flickering soul gems, the distorted transformations, the cries of rage and sorrow echoing through the halls. The color. The movement. The madness.

It was sublime.

It was honest.

It was everything she had ever wanted to see.

Her eyes gleamed, catching the fractured light of the broken barrier.

Let the chaos begin.

And then came the explosion.

A flash of light. A bloom of smoke. The chamber shuddered with the force of it.

Mitama's eyes widened. "What was that?"

"An explosion," Rena said, rising to her feet. "That was close."

"They noticed it too," Mifuyu said, pointing at the projection. "Look at them."

Kasumi and Lunaria had turned, their expressions sharp, alert. The easy warmth was gone from their faces.

"Change the projection," Momoko ordered. "Show us where it happened."

Mitama nodded, her fingers weaving through the air. The image shimmered, shifted—then reformed.

What they saw made their hearts stop.

The corridor was in ruins. Smoke curled from shattered walls. Magical girls lay unconscious across the floor. And at the center of it all was—

“No...” Momoko whispered, eyes wide as she raised a trembling hand to her mouth.

“Not you too...” Rena murmured, her fists clenching tight.

“Kuroe...” Mifuyu breathed, voice shaking as she clutched her Soul Gem close.

Mitama’s hands trembled.

What they saw was Kuroe overtaken by her doppel.

Her doppel had fully emerged, twisting around her like a storm of shadow and grief. The transformation was violent, raw — a soul unraveling in real time. The projection flickered with unstable magic, and the girls watching felt their hearts sink.

Another one.

Another magical girl lost.

Mitama’s breath caught. She had seen this too many times. The Isolation Ward was full of girls who had reached this brink — some still clinging to themselves, others already gone. And now Kuroe, who had fought so hard, who had tried to stay close to Iroha, had joined them.

Mifuyu’s eyes shimmered. Momoko lowered her gaze. Rena clenched her fists, her jaw tight.

Then Kuroe’s doppel did something strange.

She began to rise.

Higher and higher, her body twisting upward like a dark flame, her form shedding the last remnants of restraint. The projection shimmered with unstable magic, and the air around Mitama, Mifuyu, Momoko, and Rena grew heavy with dread. They watched in silence as the doppel ascended, her movements erratic, desperate, as if pulled by something beyond her control.

Mitama’s eyes widened, her voice barely a whisper. “She’s trying to break through the APS barrier...”

The others turned to her, stunned.

“If she succeeds,” Mitama said, her tone grim, “she’ll become a full-fledged witch. And once that happens...”

“She will be gone,” Mifuyu whispered, her voice hollow.

Mitama’s hands hovered near her spell matrix, fingers trembling with urgency. But it was no use. Kuroe was too far. Too high. Out of reach. She couldn’t trap her in an isolation sphere. She couldn’t contain her. The moment was slipping through her fingers like sand, and all she could do was watch.

And so they did.

With heavy hearts.

With silent tears.

Then, just as Mitama had feared, Kuroe's doppel shattered the barrier.

The sky tore open.

A jagged wound split the heavens, and from it bloomed Kuroe's witch form — vast, terrible, and aching familiar. A creature born of sorrow and guilt, shaped by everything Kuroe had tried to suppress. The projection trembled with the force of it, and the girls watching felt the finality settle in their bones like frost.

Kuroe was gone.

Then Momoko's breath hitched.

Her eyes went wide.

“Look!” Momoko cried, her voice sharp with urgency as she pointed at the screen.

Mitama, Mifuyu, and Rena turned — and their eyes widened in unison.

From the lower corner of the projection, a lone figure was rising, flying toward the witch with deliberate, unhurried grace. She was unarmed. No weapons. No soul gem. Just a cloak fluttering in the wind and a presence that felt impossibly calm amid the chaos. The moonlight caught her long indigo hair, making it shimmer like strands of night woven with silver. Her clothes rippled around her like water, soft and fluid, untouched by the violence that surrounded her.

Her face was serene — but her eyes told another story.

Deep indigo, luminous and heavy, they held something ancient. Something aching. It wasn't fear. It wasn't anger. It was sorrow. A quiet, profound sorrow at what Kuroe had become. As if she had seen this kind of fall before. As if she had mourned it long ago and was mourning it again now, not with panic, but with understanding.

The lone figure was Lunaria

“Lunaria? What is she doing there?!” Rena said, her voice sharp with disbelief. “She and Kasumi were just on Embryo Eve. How did she get there so fast?”

“This must be related to how Lunaria and Kasumi entered the portal earlier,” Mifuyu murmured. “None of the others — Iroha, Kuroe, Yachiyo, even the Amane sisters — noticed them. It seems like they truly can move at high speeds.”

And now she was here.

Confronting Kuroe's witch.

They watched, transfixed, as Lunaria danced through the witch's attacks. She didn't fight. She didn't cast spells. She moved with the storm, her body weaving through the chaos like silk in wind. Her limbs flowed with impossible grace, her cloak trailing behind her like a second set of wings. She was not

resisting the witch — she was moving with her, through her, as if the violence itself were a current she could ride.

It was mesmerizing.

It was beautiful.

It was unlike anything they had ever seen.

“She’s not attacking,” Mifuyu whispered, her voice tinged with awe.

“She’s... dancing,” Rena said, eyes wide.

“I still do not see a soul gem on her,” Momoko murmured. “Who is she?”

Mitama’s eyes narrowed, her voice low. “What are you doing, Lunaria? Are you trying to defeat Kuroe’s witch... or save her?”

None of them had ever heard of such a thing — witches being saved. It was a contradiction. A fantasy. But Lunaria looked so calm, so serene, as she flew toward Kuroe’s witch. There was no aggression in her posture. No fear. No urgency. Only grace.

Lunaria landed on the witch’s head.

Placed her hand gently.

And then, they heard it.

One word.

Echoing through the HQ like a bell in the dark.

“Dis-connect.”

The projection flared with light.

And then—

Nothing.

Lunaria and the witch vanished.

Gone.

As if they had never been there.

The girls sat in stunned silence.

The projection faded.

The room was quiet.

Then, slowly, they began to speak.

“Dis-connect?” Momoko asked, her voice trembling. “What was that? What did Lunaria do?”

“Did she... save Kuroe with it?” Rena added. “Or send her somewhere?”

“Where is Kasumi?” Mifuyu wondered aloud. “Was she watching too?”

Mitama’s voice was soft, almost reverent. “Did you do it, Lunaria? Did you just save Kuroe from her fate as a witch?”

They didn’t have answers.

But they had something else.

Hope.

A fragile, flickering hope that maybe — just maybe — there was another way. Another path. Another solution to the cycle that had defined their lives. A way that didn’t rely on containment, or suppression, or sacrifice. A way that felt... gentle. Human.

They hoped they would meet Lunaria and Kasumi again.

They hoped they could ask.

They hoped they could understand one day.

The golden haze of the spiritual plane had barely faded when the ground beneath them began to tremble.

Iroha, Yachiyo, Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno stood outside the HQ, still reeling from Lunaria’s revelations about Ui and Embryo Eve. Their minds were full — full of questions, full of wonder, full of the fragile hope that maybe something had changed. But reality had other plans.

The tremor was subtle at first — a low rumble beneath their feet, like the breath of something ancient stirring in its sleep. Then it grew. The ground shook violently, sending dust and loose debris skittering across the courtyard. The girls staggered, bracing themselves against the sudden quake.

Felicia’s voice cut through the tension, sharp and anxious. “Now what?! Is Embryo Eve waking up ahead of schedule?”

No one answered.

Because before they could speak, they heard it.

An explosion.

Sharp. Deafening. It echoed through the HQ like a scream, followed by a wave of magical pressure so intense it made their soul gems flicker. They turned toward the source — and what they saw made their blood run cold.

Doppels.

Dozens of them.

Bursting from the HQ like a swarm of shadows, their forms twisted and unstable, their cries echoing with raw emotion. The hole in the APS barrier — the one Kuroe's witch had torn open — was now a gateway. A rupture. And through it poured chaos.

Yachiyo's worst fear had come true.

The containment had failed.

The Isolation Ward was breaking.

The doppels were going berserk.

Iroha's breath caught. Sana clutched Felicia's arm. Tsuruno's eyes widened in horror. They had seen doppel outbreaks before — but never like this. Never this many. Never this fast.

Then, from the sky, two figures were launched toward them — flung by the sheer force of the magical eruption.

Mifuyu and Momoko.

They hit the ground hard, tumbling across the courtyard in a blur of limbs and dust.

"Mifuyu! Momoko!" Yachiyo shouted, already running toward them.

The others followed, hearts pounding.

They reached the fallen girls, helping them up, brushing debris from their clothes. Mifuyu took Yachiyo's hand, steadying herself. Momoko groaned, but managed a weak smile.

"We're fine," she said, breathless. "Just... shaken."

They turned together, looking back at the sky.

The doppels were everywhere now — streaking across the horizon, their forms trailing smoke and magic. Some were already heading toward Kamihama. Others hovered, pulsing with unstable energy. The city was vulnerable. The world was vulnerable.

Iroha's voice trembled. "Where are Mitama and Rena?"

Momoko shook her head. "We don't know. We were blown this way when the doppels broke free. Mitama and Rena must've been thrown in another direction."

Mifuyu's gaze darkened. "Knowing Mitama... she'll try to help. She'll try to save as many girls as she can."

She paused, her voice heavy.

"But this? This is too much. No one can handle this alone."

The girls grimaced, the weight of the situation settling over them like ash.

Sana's voice was quiet. "What can we do now?"

There was no easy answer.

But Mifuyu looked at them — at Iroha, Yachiyo, Felicia, Sana, and Tsuruno — and asked, “You saw it, didn’t you? Lunaria’s interaction with Kuroe’s witch?”

They gasped in unison, eyes wide with recognition.

Yachiyo nodded, a soft chuckle escaping her lips. “So it was real. It wasn’t a dream.”

“Yes,” Iroha said, her voice shaking with disbelief and joy. “We saw everything. We heard everything.”

Felicia smirked, her tone shifting. “Lunaria spoke to Kuroe’s witch — Ichizo. We even heard Ichizo’s voice. I always thought witches were monsters, beyond reason. But after hearing Ichizo speak... I realized we’re not so different.”

Sana’s eyes shimmered. “Lunaria told Ichizo, and us, that we deserve joy. That our lives and our bonds are precious. Magical. Small miracles. She said they should be cherished, not thrown away.”

Tsuruno’s voice was barely a whisper. “She was trying to bring us back. All of us. Her words wrapped around my soul like a warm embrace. It reminded me of who I was before all this — before the suffering.”

Mifuyu and Momoko looked at them, stunned.

Lunaria speaking to a witch. Trying to save a magical girl who had already fallen. It defied everything they had ever known.

“Thank you for sharing that,” Momoko said, her voice contemplative. “That must’ve been... incredible. I wish we could’ve been there.”

“We only saw it through Mitama’s projection,” Mifuyu added. “We couldn’t hear anything except that final word — ‘dis-connect.’ Do you know what it means?”

Yachiyo smiled gently. “We don’t know exactly. But something happened to all of us after she said it. It felt like... a transformation.”

Mifuyu and Momoko leaned in, eyes sparkling with curiosity.

Iroha continued, “After Lunaria said ‘dis-connect,’ everything was enveloped in light. And then... we were somewhere else. A peaceful, beautiful place. A spiritual plane. Lunaria was there. Kuroe wasn’t.”

She paused, her voice softening.

“That’s where Lunaria told us what she and Kasumi learned. About Ui. About the small Kyubey. About Embryo Eve. It turns out... they’re all Ui. My little sister.”

Mifuyu and Momoko gasped.

Ui was Iroha’s sister?

How could she be both the small Kyubey and Embryo Eve?

Why were Iroha's memories so fragmented?

Momoko smiled, placing a hand on Iroha's shoulder. "I'm glad you found her. I hope it brought you some peace. Mifuyu and I... we have something to share too."

Iroha tilted her head. "Oh?"

Mifuyu nodded. "After you all left, Lunaria and Kasumi went to investigate the Wings of the Magius. Their first stop was Embryo Eve — the cornerstone of the Wings' plan to spread the APS to the entire world."

Momoko continued, "Mitama projected the room so we could watch. When they reached Embryo Eve, they both leapt onto it and touched it. And then... their expressions changed. Like they realized something."

Iroha, Yachiyo, Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno chuckled.

Iroha smiled. "Yes. That's when they realized Embryo Eve is Ui's body. After she became a witch."

Mifuyu and Momoko's eyes widened in horror.

Momoko's voice rose. "Wait — how your sister became a witch? Why is she dormant? What do the Wings have to do with this? Did they... turn her?"

Mifuyu frowned, thinking hard. "But you said the small Kyubey is also Ui. How can that be?"

Iroha nodded. "Earlier today, at Mikazuki Villa, Lunaria and Kasumi petted the small Kyubey. That's when they realized it was Ui. They even spoke to her."

Momoko and Mifuyu could only laugh — not out of disbelief, but out of awe.

"Haha... it's one surprise after another with those two," Momoko said, reverent. "She can talk to witches. And the small Kyubey. How does she do it?"

"What did Ui say?" Mifuyu asked. "Did she tell them her story? What happened to her?"

Iroha shook her head. "They didn't speak long. But Ui said this was the first time she'd spoken to anyone since becoming a witch. And that what happened to her... is connected to the Wings. Lunaria said she, Ui, and Kasumi will talk again."

Yachiyo added, "After that, we asked Lunaria everything — about Kuroe, about 'dis-connect,' about what she and Kasumi plan to do. But she left without answering anything, as always. She said we'll meet again soon. And that she'll share more when she knows more."

Mifuyu and Momoko exhaled gently and looked up at the night sky — serene, moonlit, twinkled with stars, and impossibly clear. A stark contrast to the chaos unfolding below, as doppelified magical girls spread across Kamihama like wildfire.

But despite the looming disaster...

Despite the fear...

Their hearts felt strangely calm.

Strangely warm.

Strangely hopeful.

As if, somehow, there was a way through this.

As if Lunaria had shown them a door they never knew existed.

Mifuyu rose to her feet, her gaze steady, her soul gem pulsing faintly in the moonlight. She looked out at the sky, where the APS barrier had been torn open, and at the swarm of doppels now spilling across Kamihama like a tide of sorrow. Her eyes didn't flinch. They burned with quiet resolve.

"I've made up my mind," she said, her voice clear and unwavering. "I'm going to help them. All of them."

The others turned to her in shock.

Iroha's breath caught. Sana's eyes widened. Felicia blinked, stunned. Tsuruno took a step forward, uncertain. Even Yachiyo, who had known Mifuyu longer than any of them, looked at her with alarm.

"Mifuyu," Yachiyo said gently, her voice laced with concern, "you can't be serious. There are too many. You'll die if you try to fight them all. Even if we all joined you... I don't think we could stop this."

Mifuyu turned to her, her expression soft, touched with sadness and something deeper — a quiet ache that had long lived behind her eyes.

"I'm not planning to fight them," she said gently. "That's not what this is."

She looked back at the sky, at the chaos now spilling through the broken barrier — the doppels, wild and unmoored, trailing grief like smoke. Her gaze didn't flinch. It lingered, searching for something beyond the destruction.

"When I saw Lunaria with Kuroe... something changed in me. Mitama saw it too. Lunaria didn't attack Ichizo. She didn't try to destroy her. She didn't even raise her voice. She tried to understand her. To connect."

She paused, her voice trembling with conviction.

"I don't know what Lunaria did exactly. I don't know what 'dis-connect' means. I don't even know if she truly saved Kuroe. But I believe she did. And that belief... it's giving me hope. Hope that there's another way. That maybe we don't have to fight these girls. That maybe we can reach them before they fall."

She turned back to the others, her voice growing steadier.

“The doppelified magical girls... they’re not witches. Not yet. Maybe there’s still time. Maybe I can reach them. Maybe I can do what Lunaria did.”

Momoko stepped forward, her eyes shimmering with emotion.

“When Mitama opened up to us in the Isolation Ward,” she said, “she told us something important. That when she adjusts a soul gem, she attunes herself to the girl. She feels everything. All the pain. All the despair. And she had to close off her heart just to survive it.”

She looked at Mifuyu with warmth and quiet admiration.

“Her apathy was a mask. A way to keep going. But maybe now... maybe it’s time we help her carry that weight.”

She smiled, gently.

“Maybe it’s time we share Mitama’s burden. As friends should.”

Mifuyu returned the smile, her eyes softening. “Yes,” she said. “She is our friend. Let’s help her.”

She looked up again, at the broken sky, and chuckled gently — not with amusement, but with a kind of wistful longing.

“Maybe Lunaria or Kasumi will come to help us. Just like Lunaria did for Kuroe.”

Yachiyo stepped forward, her expression thoughtful, her gaze distant.

“It’s interesting,” she said slowly, “that Lunaria chose to act when she did. After Kuroe became a witch. If she’s as powerful as I think she is... she could’ve intervened at any time. She could’ve taken us into the HQ undetected. Investigated the Wings. Taken us home safely. But she didn’t.”

Iroha nodded, her voice quiet. “She and Kasumi mostly watched. Even when Kuroe and I had to fight that security Uwasu. Even when Kaede turned and attacked Rena. They didn’t step in.”

Momoko chuckled softly, standing beside Mifuyu and gazing at the same place in the sky.

“They didn’t interfere when Mitama, Rena, and I clashed in the Isolation Ward either. They just watched. Smiled. Waited for us to find our own way.”

She paused, her voice growing more reflective.

“I think they’re watching us now. Waiting to see what we’ll do.”

She turned to Mifuyu, her voice quiet and steady.

“But if they don’t come... if they don’t help... are you ready to risk everything? To sacrifice yourself for these girls?”

Mifuyu looked at her, eyes full of resolve.

“Yes.”

They held hands.

A quiet gesture.

A bond renewed.

Connect.

Then Yachiyo stepped forward, her eyes misted with memory. She placed her hand over theirs.

“I want to help too,” she said. “You’re my teammates. My friends. This... this brings back everything.”

And then—

Something shifted.

As Mifuyu, Momoko, and Yachiyo connected, a pulse of warmth spread through them. Not magic. Not power. Something deeper. Something older. A resonance. A memory. A light.

And what they experienced...

Surprised them all.

Chapter 10: Your True Ability

Yachiyo, Mifuyu, and Momoko opened their eyes.

They were no longer standing in the chaos outside the HQ. No longer surrounded by the cries of doppels or the flickering remnants of the APS barrier.

They were back at Mikazuki Villa.

But it wasn’t the real one.

The air shimmered with golden light, soft and warm. The garden was in full bloom, untouched by time. The wind stirred the trees gently, and the sky above was a tranquil dusk, painted in lavender and rose. It felt like a memory — not one they were recalling, but one they were inside.

A spiritual realm of connect.

And then they saw them.

Mel and Kanae.

Standing beneath the plum tree, smiling.

Mel chuckled, her voice light. “It’s been a long time, hasn’t it?”

Kanae nodded, eyes twinkling. “Just like the old days. All of us together.”

Mifuyu, Momoko, and Yachiyo froze.

Their breath caught.

Their hearts stilled.

“Mel? Kanae?” Yachiyo whispered. “What... what are you doing here?”

Mel and Kanae stepped forward, their smiles warm, their presence radiant.

Kanae spoke first, her voice gentle. “We’ve been watching you, Yachiyo. We know how much you’ve carried. How distant you became. You thought your wish to survive was twisted — that it caused others to die in your place.”

Yachiyo’s eyes widened. Her mouth opened, but no words came.

Mel continued, her tone soft but clear. “But that’s not what your wish did. Your true ability... is to inherit the hope of magical girls who placed their trust in you. Their dreams. Their strength. That’s why you’re so powerful. That’s why we’re here now.”

Yachiyo’s knees buckled.

Tears spilled down her cheeks.

She rushed forward and embraced them both, arms trembling, heart breaking open.

It felt like liberation.

The chains she had wrapped around herself — the guilt, the fear, the isolation — began to fall away. She sobbed into their shoulders, and they held her, steady and kind.

Behind her, Mifuyu and Momoko chuckled softly.

“Hey,” Momoko teased, “why does Yachiyo get all the benefits? Not fair.”

Mifuyu smiled. “This is what I kept trying to tell you, Yachiyo. Not all magical girls are as strong as you. That’s why so many joined the Wings of the Magius. We were desperate. Weak. Clinging to any hope that might free us from this endless cycle.”

Yachiyo turned to them, wiping her tears.

She looked at Mifuyu with new eyes — eyes that saw, not judged.

“I understand now,” she said. “I understand you. And all the girls who joined the Wings. If only I had listened earlier... instead of shutting you out. Instead of always being confrontational.”

She bowed her head. “I’m sorry.”

Mifuyu stepped forward and took her hand. “I accept. And I’m sorry too. Recruiting girls into the Wings... it hurt many of them. Some became doppelified. I carry that weight.”

They stood together in silence, the air around them pulsing with quiet understanding.

Then Yachiyo spoke again. “What should we do now? Should we find Mitama? Help her adjust the soul gems of the doppelified girls?”

Momoko and Mifuyu exchanged a glance.

“That’s what we’re planning,” Momoko said. “But... we don’t want you to come.”

Yachiyo blinked. “What? Why?”

“We’re old teammates,” she said. “You can’t expect me to stand back while you do something dangerous.”

Mifuyu stepped forward, her expression tender and sad — the look of someone saying a final goodbye.

“Mitama told us,” she said. “If she tries to adjust a doppel’s soul gem... she risks being consumed by it. It’s dangerous. That’s why she hasn’t done it yet.”

She placed a hand on Yachiyo’s shoulder.

“You have to live on.”

She smiled, eyes glistening.

“You have new friends who need you. Iroha. Sana. Felicia. Tsuruno.”

She paused.

“And maybe even Kuroe. I believe Lunaria saved her.”

Momoko nodded. “Even if we die... we’ve placed our hopes in you. Our dreams. Our trust. You’ll carry us. You’ll be stronger than ever.”

She winked. “And maybe we’ll chat again like this. Since this is part of your true ability, after all.”

Yachiyo looked at them — at Mifuyu, at Momoko, at Mel and Kanae.

Her heart ached.

She didn’t know how this realm had formed. Didn’t know if she could ever return to it. But she saw the resolve in their eyes. The peace. The love.

She sighed.

Then she stepped forward and embraced them both.

Light tears flowed down her cheeks.

“Okay,” she whispered. “I understand. I’ll stay. I’ll live. And I’ll find a way to speak with you again. I’ll master this ability. I promise.”

Momoko and Mifuyu closed their eyes, smiling through their tears.

“Thank you,” Mifuyu said softly. “We’re both so glad to have met you, Yachiyo. To be your friend. Your teammate. To have fought beside you, laughed with you, and suffered through the worst of it together.”

Momoko nodded, her voice trembling. “You were always the one who held us together. Even when you didn’t know it. Even when you were hurting. You gave us strength just by being there.”

Yachiyo’s breath hitched.

Mel stepped forward, her grin playful but her eyes shimmering. “Hey, maybe once you master this true ability of yours, we can do more things together. Shopping and eating out sounds nice! I’ve been craving those plum rice balls you used to make.”

Kanae chuckled, brushing a strand of hair behind her ear. “I will hold you to that promise, Yachiyo. You better figure it out soon. I want to see how strong you’ve become. And I want to hear you laugh again — really laugh.”

Yachiyo let out a weak, tearful laugh. “You guys...”

She wiped her eyes, her heart full and breaking all at once.

Mifuyu leaned in, her voice barely above a breath. “Even if we’re gone... Even if we never talk or see each other again... we’ll be with you. In every step. In every fight. In every moment you choose to live.”

Momoko added, “And when you feel alone, just remember — we trusted you. We believed in you. That bond doesn’t fade.”

Yachiyo nodded, her arms wrapped around them tightly.

“I’ll carry you,” she said. “I’ll carry all of you.”

Mel and Kanae placed their hands on her shoulders, warm and steady.

“You’re not alone,” Kanae said. “You never were.”

And then—

The scene began to fade.

The plum blossoms shimmered once, then dissolved into light.

The garden, the sky, the warmth — all slipping away like a dream remembered at dawn.

But the feeling remained.

The connection.

The promise.

The love.

Yachiyo's consciousness returned to the real world.

The golden warmth of the spiritual realm faded, replaced by the cool night air outside the HQ. The sky above was still torn, the APS barrier fractured, and the cries of distant doppels echoed faintly across Kamihama. But something inside her had changed.

She looked around.

Momoko and Mifuyu were gone.

They must have already gone to find Mitama — to help her, to begin the impossible task of saving the doppelified magical girls. Yachiyo stared at the HQ, her eyes misting. A sad smile tugged at her lips, and tears began to fall.

She might never see them again.

Not in this world.

Not in this life.

But they would always be with her.

In her heart.

In her soul gem.

In the quiet strength she now carried.

"Iroha! Yachiyo!" Felicia's voice broke through the silence. "Are you okay? Where did Momoko and Mifuyu go?"

Sana and Tsuruno rushed to her side, concern etched across their faces.

Yachiyo turned to them, her expression soft and full of love. She embraced them all, arms wrapped around their shoulders, pulling them close.

"They've made up their minds," she said gently. "They're going to help Mitama. Try to save the girls who've turned into doppels. It's dangerous. They may not come back."

The others fell silent.

Iroha's eyes shimmered. "Are you... okay with that?"

Sana looked down. "With your old teammates sacrificing themselves?"

Felicia clenched her fists. "That's not fair."

Tsuruno's voice was quiet. "You shouldn't have to lose them."

Yachiyo looked at each of them, her gaze steady and warm.

"I wasn't okay with it," Yachiyo said, her voice low but steady. "Not at first. I didn't want to let them go. I didn't want to believe they'd chosen something so dangerous."

She paused, her gaze drifting upward to the fractured sky, then back to her friends. The moonlight caught the tears already gathering in her eyes.

“But then... something happened.”

She took a breath, and her voice softened into something more intimate — not just explanation, but confession.

“When I connected with Momoko and Mifuyu... we weren’t here anymore. We were back at Mikazuki Villa. But it wasn’t the real one. It was... warm. Quiet. The garden was blooming. The air shimmered like memory. It felt like a place made from our hearts.”

Her voice trembled.

“And then Mel and Kanae were there.”

Iroha gasped softly. Sana’s hand went to her mouth. Felicia and Tsuruno leaned in, eyes wide.

“They smiled at me,” Yachiyo continued, her tears beginning to fall. “Like nothing had changed. Like they’d just stepped out for a moment and come back. And they told me the truth.”

She looked down at her hands, then back up, her voice breaking open.

“That my real ability... is to inherit the hope of magical girls who place their trust in me. Their dreams. Their strength. That’s why I’ve survived. That’s why I’m strong. Not because others died in my place... but because they believed in me.”

She wiped her eyes, but the tears kept coming.

“I lived my life thinking my wish was twisted. That Kyubey had cursed me. That if I couldn’t escape, someone else would die instead. I thought I had to stay distant. Cold. Alone. Just to protect people from me.”

Her voice cracked.

“But now... I know better.”

She looked at each of them — Iroha, Sana, Felicia, Tsuruno — and her gaze was full of light.

“I can open my heart again. I can make bonds. I can love without fear.”

She stepped forward and embraced them all, arms wrapped tightly, tears falling freely.

“I don’t have to be alone anymore.”

Iroha hugged her back, eyes shimmering. “You never were.”

Sana smiled through her tears. “We’re here. We’ve always been here.”

Felicia sniffled. “You’re really crying in front of us, huh? I guess miracles do happen.”

Tsuruno laughed, wiping her eyes. “You’re finally acting like a real friend. Took you long enough.”

Yachiyo laughed with them, her voice full of joy and release.

“I’m sorry it took so long,” she said. “But I’m here now. And I’m not going anywhere.”

Iroha closed her eyes, “I’m so happy for you, Yachiyo!”

Sana smiled through her tears. “You deserve this peace.”

Felicia grinned. “You’re finally acting like a real person!”

Tsuruno laughed. “We’ll have to get used to this new Yachiyo. She’s kind of... warm.”

Yachiyo laughed with them, her heart full.

She looked up at the night sky, at the place where Lunaria and Kuroe had vanished.

“I believe,” she said softly, “that I’ll see Momoko and Mifuyu again. That I’ll speak with Mel and Kanae again. Just like I did tonight. I’ll master this ability. I’ll find a way.”

She turned to her friends, her smile radiant.

“And maybe... I can bring all of you with me next time. We can go shopping. Eat out. Spar a little. Just... be together.”

The girls burst into laughter.

Felicia pointed at her. “Who are you and what have you done with Yachiyo?”

Tsuruno wiped her eyes. “You’re talking about parties and food. This is surreal.”

Yachiyo chuckled, then paused.

She looked down at her soul gem.

Silver and gold flickered within it — soft, luminous threads dancing in the core.

The colors of Mifuyu and Momoko, silver and gold.

The last connect they would share.

Iroha gasped. “Yachiyo... your soul gem...”

Sana leaned in. “It’s beautiful.”

Felicia nodded. “It’s like they’re still with you.”

Yachiyo closed her eyes, her expression serene.

“Yes,” she whispered.

And in her heart, she added silently:

Please, Lunaria... Kasumi... if you're out there... help them. Save them. Let us meet again. Just like you heard my plea for Iroha... please hear this one too.

She opened her eyes.

“Enough sentimental talk,” she said, smiling. “Let’s go home. It’s getting late. And I’m hungry.”

The girls cheered.

Tsuruno clapped her hands. “Let’s eat at Banbanzai! My parents are working tonight — they’ll cook something amazing!”

Laughter and light conversation echoed through the night as they walked away from the HQ. Behind them, the doppels still spread across the city, a storm of sorrow and magic.

But they walked forward with trust.

With hope.

With love.

And the night, for all its darkness, felt just a little brighter.

The realm shimmered like memory.

Soft light filtered through the canvas of countless tents, each one pulsing faintly with the soul of a magical girl. The air was quiet, heavy with emotion, like a dream suspended between despair and hope. Mitama walked slowly, her footsteps echoing across the groundless floor, her heart pounding.

She reached Kaede’s tent.

The curtain fluttered gently, as if stirred by breath. Rena stood beside her, tense and silent, her eyes locked on the entrance.

Mitama pulled the curtain aside and stepped in.

Inside, the air was thick with grief.

Kaede’s soul gem pulsed erratically, flickering between light and shadow. Her doppel loomed behind her — a twisted, sorrowful shape, coiled and trembling, its cries echoing like wind through broken glass.

Mitama knelt beside Kaede, her hands glowing faintly as she began the adjustment.

This was the first time she had ever tried to save a doppelified magical girl.

Not contain.

Not stabilize.

Save.

She remembered what Momoko and Rena had told her — that they wanted to be her friends. That they saw her. That they believed in her.

And because of that...

She was trying.

Trying to be the magical girl she had always dreamed of being — one who could support others, who could spread happiness, who could carry the weight of despair without being consumed by it.

Rena knelt beside her, placing a hand on Mitama's shoulder.

"I'm here," she whispered. "We'll do this together."

Mitama nodded, but her hands were trembling.

Kaede's despair was deep. Her doppel surged and twisted, resisting the adjustment. Mitama grimaced, sweat beading on her forehead. Her magic flickered. Her heart ached.

If I can't save Kaede... how can I save the others?

Then—

A voice.

Soft. Familiar.

"Mitama."

She looked up.

Two glowing figures floated toward them — blue spirits, luminous and gentle.

Momoko and Mifuyu.

Mitama's breath caught.

Rena gasped.

They hovered in front of them, radiant and calm.

"What are you doing here?" Mitama asked, her voice trembling. She already knew the answer, but her heart wasn't ready for it.

Mifuyu floated closer, her form glowing faintly, serene and sad. "We came to help."

She reached out to Kaede, her hand shimmering with soft light.

"I've always been weak," she said, her voice gentle but steady. "But maybe that weakness can help others. Maybe I can show the girls who've fallen that they're not alone. That it's okay to be sad. That they're still loved."

She paused, her eyes full of quiet conviction.

“Lunaria showed me that. When she reached out to Kuroe’s witch... she didn’t fight. She connected. She understood. I want to do a small part of that. I want to try.”

Mitama’s breath caught.

Momoko stepped forward, her gaze warm and unwavering.

“I’m here to support Mifuyu. To save Kaede. And to support you, Mitama.”

She placed a hand over Mitama’s.

“You’re our friend. You don’t have to carry this alone.”

Mitama’s eyes widened.

The words echoed through her — not just in her ears, but in her soul. She brought a trembling hand to her chest, where her soul gem pulsed faintly.

“I am your friend...” she whispered. “I don’t have to do this alone...”

And suddenly, the weight she’d been carrying — the despair, the isolation, the fear of failing every girl she tried to help — began to lift. Her soul felt lighter. Less suffocated. Less afraid.

They reached out — Mifuyu to Rena, Momoko to Mitama.

Their hands met.

A pulse of light spread through the tent, soft and radiant, like the first warmth of spring after a long winter.

Mitama closed her eyes.

And for the first time in a long while...

She felt held.

Rena and Momoko leaned close to Kaede, their voices soft and pleading.

“Come back to us,” Rena whispered. “Please. We’re here. We love you.”

“Kaede,” Momoko said, “you’re not alone. You never were.”

The doppel shuddered.

Then slowly—

It began to recede.

The twisted form unraveled, dissolving into light. Kaede’s soul gem steadied. Her body slumped gently to the ground, unconscious but whole.

Rena stared.

Then she cried.

She pulled Kaede into her arms, sobbing, her tears falling onto Kaede's shoulder.

"Thank you," she whispered. "Thank you, Mitama. Thank you, Mifuyu. Thank you, Momoko."

Mitama knelt beside them, her hands still glowing, her heart full.

She didn't speak.

She didn't need to.

Because in that moment, she knew—

She had saved someone.

And she hadn't done it alone.

But the happiness would not last.

Mitama and Rena heard it — a faint, brittle crack.

They turned toward the sound, and their hearts sank.

Mifuyu and Momoko's blue spirit forms shimmered in the air, but now... they bore fractures. Thin, glowing lines running through their bodies like cracks in porcelain. The light around them flickered, unstable.

Mitama's eyes widened in horror.

"No," she whispered. "Do you realize what you're doing? If you keep this up... you'll die. This is just like when a magical girl uses too much energy and her soul gem shatters."

Her voice trembled.

"You're burning yourselves out."

Mifuyu and Momoko looked at her calmly, their expressions serene.

"We know," Mifuyu said softly. "We're ready."

Mitama stepped forward, desperate. "But why? Why are you so calm in the face of death? Don't you have friends who would miss you? Dreams you haven't lived yet?"

Momoko's gaze was gentle. "Of course we do. But we've made peace with it."

Mifuyu nodded. "When we connected with Yachiyo earlier... we saw something. Something that changed everything."

She paused, her voice growing more tender.

"We were back at Mikazuki Villa. And Mel and Kanae were there — our old teammates. Yachiyo's too."

Mitama's breath caught.

"They told us the truth about Yachiyo's wish," Mifuyu continued. "Her true ability. It's not just survival. It's to inherit the hope of magical girls who place their trust, dreams, and love in her. That's why she's so strong. That's why Mel and Kanae were able to appear when we connected."

Mitama's eyes went wide.

A wish that allowed one to communicate with the dead. To grow stronger through the love and trust of those who had passed. It was beautiful. Terrible. Sacred.

She brought a hand to her chest, her soul gem pulsing faintly.

"That's... incredible," she whispered. "What a powerful, beautiful gift."

Mifuyu nodded. "Yachiyo thought her wish was corrupted. That every time she survived, someone else died in her place. That's why she became cold. Distant. She didn't want to hurt anyone."

Momoko looked at Mitama, her voice soft. "Not so different from you, right? You had to become neutral. Apathetic. Just to keep going. Just to keep helping girls without breaking."

Mitama looked at them — really looked — and something inside her shifted.

She smiled warmly, tears gathering in her eyes.

"Yes," she said. "That's right."

She chuckled, pressing her soul gem to her chest.

"It's strange, isn't it? Yachiyo and I disagreed on so much about the Wings of the Magius. But at our core... we're the same. We both closed ourselves off to survive. We both carried too much."

She looked up at them, her voice full of quiet longing.

"If Yachiyo has that kind of deeper power... then maybe I do too. Maybe there's something inside me that can help magical girls in the future. Something I haven't discovered yet."

Mifuyu and Momoko smiled.

"She has to live on," Momoko said. "To support her new friends at Mikazuki Villa — Iroha, Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno."

She winked. "And we truly believe we'll talk to her again. With Mel and Kanae. Yachiyo promised she'd figure out how to bring us all together again, even after we're gone."

Mifuyu added with her own wink, "And if she masters it enough... maybe she can bring you in too. A party with all of us. Our living friends. Our fallen ones. Wouldn't that be fun?"

Mitama closed her eyes and chuckled, her voice trembling.

"That's a very optimistic outlook," she said. "But it would be beautiful. And fun."

She opened her eyes, looking at them with love.

“Thank you,” she whispered. “For sharing this with me. For trusting me. For being my friends.”

Mitama could see it in their eyes.

The resolve. The quiet certainty. The willingness to give everything.

She wanted to argue. To plead. To stop them.

But instead, she stepped forward, her voice soft but firm.

“Then I’ll join you,” she said. “I’ll help save the others. We’ll do it together.”

Momoko and Mifuyu turned to her, their expressions kind and sorrowful.

“No,” Momoko said gently. “You should survive. Like Yachiyo.”

Mifuyu nodded. “You have something special, Mitama. You can support so many magical girls in the future. Just like Yachiyo will support her new teammates.”

Mitama looked at them, her eyes full of understanding and sorrow.

She turned to Momoko, a sad smile tugging at her lips.

“And what about what you said earlier?” she asked, half-joking, half-aching. “About being my friend? About sharing my burden? Are you really going to leave after doing it just once? We haven’t even been friends for a full day.”

Momoko stepped forward and hugged her tightly.

“I meant it,” she whispered. “You are my friend. And I’m here to share your burden. To help you carry it. I’m sorry I can only do it once. But I’ll give you everything I have.”

Mitama closed her eyes, her heart aching.

“You’re selfish,” she murmured, voice trembling.

Then she reached out, took both their hands, and connected.

“I’ll share my coordinator abilities with you,” she said. “Use them however you wish.”

The connection flared.

And in that moment, Momoko and Mifuyu saw her.

Not just her magic.

But her soul.

It wasn't light or shadow. It was something deeper — a quiet, trembling core wrapped in layers of silence and service. They felt it like a pulse through their own hearts, a resonance that bypassed thought and went straight to feeling.

They felt the weight she carried.

The frustration that gnawed at her — the ache of not being able to fight witches like other magical girls. The helplessness of watching others battle and fall, while she stood apart, adjusting soul gems in the shadows. The quiet shame of surviving not through strength, but through service. Through necessity.

They felt how her self-worth had eroded, little by little, with every soul she touched. Every girl she couldn't save. Every time she had to smile and nod and pretend she wasn't breaking.

They saw the girls she had helped — flickering memories like lanterns in the dark. Girls drowning in despair. Girls who screamed silently. Girls who clung to her hands like lifelines. And Mitama, trying to hold them all, trying to stay whole, trying not to cry.

They felt the moment she began to close her heart.

The slow, deliberate folding of her soul into something neutral. The apathy she wore like armor. The silence she kept like a shield. Not because she didn't care — but because she cared too much. And it hurt.

And then—

They felt her joy.

The joy that bloomed like spring after a long winter. The joy she felt when Iroha listened. When Kuroe saw her. When Momoko and Rena said, "We want to be your friend."

It was radiant. Fragile. Real.

And finally, they felt the flicker of hope she carried.

The quiet, trembling hope that maybe, just maybe, Lunaria or Kasumi would come. That someone would hear their silent plea. That someone would answer.

And they smiled.

Because they carried that same hope.

They were not alone.

Mitama, Mifuyu, and Momoko smiled together — a quiet, radiant smile that held sorrow and love and longing all at once.

A smile that said: *I see you. I carry you. I believe in you.*

Then Momoko and Mifuyu turned.

Their spirit forms shimmered, still cracked, still fading.

But they flew.

Out into the tent realm.

Toward the other girls.

Toward the despair.

Ready to pull them back.

Ready to give everything.

Mitama watched them go, her hands trembling, her soul gem glowing faintly in her palm.

“Good luck,” she whispered.

And as the tears fell from her eyes, she held her soul gem close.

Not as a burden.

But as a promise.

Mifuyu and Momoko flew through the tent realm like twin comets, their blue spirit forms trailing light and memory. Each tent they entered held a girl drowning in despair — twisted by grief, consumed by her doppel, lost in the storm of her own sorrow.

And each time, they reached out.

They didn’t fight.

They connected.

They whispered to the girls: *You are understood. You are loved. It’s okay to be weak. It’s okay to cry. You are not alone.*

With every soul they touched, the cracks on their spirit forms deepened — thin fractures glowing like fault lines across their bodies. And with each connection, their light grew darker, richer, deeper — shifting from pale blue to the color of the night sky, flecked with stars and nebulae. Ethereal. Beautiful. Fragile.

They could feel it.

Their souls growing thinner.

Their consciousness flickering.

But they kept going.

Mitama watched through tearful eyes, her hands trembling as she clutched her soul gem. The tent realm shimmered around her, soft and surreal — a place of healing and heartbreak. It was beautiful. And it was unbearable.

She wanted to scream.

She wanted to beg them to stop.

But she didn't.

Because she saw their resolve.

She saw their love.

And she respected it.

Finally, Mifuyu and Momoko reached the last tent.

They entered together, hands glowing faintly, voices steady. The girl inside was curled in on herself, her doppel looming like a storm. They knelt beside her, whispered to her, held her.

And slowly—

She came back.

The doppel receded.

The girl collapsed into their arms, unconscious but whole.

And then—

Their spirit forms began to shatter.

The cracks spread like lightning.

Their bodies, now dark as the cosmos, began to break apart — shards of starlight dissolving into mist. The air around them pulsed with quiet magic, like the last breath of a dream.

Rena stepped forward, tears streaming down her face. Her voice trembled, but she didn't hold back.

"Thank you," she said. "For saving Kaede. For being my teammate. For being my friend. I don't know how I'm supposed to say goodbye to you like this."

Momoko's smile was soft, flickering like candlelight.

"You don't have to say goodbye," she whispered. "Not really. You'll carry us. In your memories. In your heart. And I know you'll keep supporting Kaede. You always did. You always will."

Mifuyu nodded, her gaze full of peace and quiet pride.

"She'll need you. And you'll be there. You'll make her proud, Rena. I believe that."

Rena sobbed, her voice cracking. "I'll try. I'll do my best. I promise."

Mitama stepped forward, her soul gem glowing faintly in her hand. Her eyes shimmered with tears, and her voice was barely above a breath.

“Thank you,” she said. “For this memory. For your sacrifice. For being true friends.”

She smiled through her tears, a forlorn laugh escaping her lips.

“I guess Lunaria and Kasumi won’t be coming to help us this time...”

Mifuyu chuckled, breathless and fading. “Looks like they won’t.”

Momoko gave a soft laugh, her voice like wind through leaves. “But we have no regrets.”

Mitama stepped closer, her voice trembling. “You were only my friends for a short time... but it meant everything. You helped me believe in myself. You helped me remember who I am.”

Momoko reached out, her hand flickering. “You’re stronger than you think, Mitama. You’ll help so many girls. You’ll carry us forward.”

Mifuyu added, “And maybe... someday... you’ll connect with Yachiyo again. And she’ll bring us all together. You, us, Mel, Kanae... maybe even Lunaria and Kasumi.”

Mitama laughed softly, tears falling freely now. “A party with all of us. That would be beautiful.”

Momoko smiled. “I want plum rice balls. And a warm drink.”

Mifuyu nodded. “And no more soul gem adjustments. Just laughter.”

Rena wiped her eyes. “I’ll bring Kaede. She’ll want to see you again.”

Mitama placed her hand over her heart. “I’ll find a way. I promise.”

The light around Mifuyu and Momoko began to shimmer, their forms dark as the night sky, flecked with stars and nebulae. Cracks spread gently, like glass surrendering to time.

They closed their eyes.

Their smiles lingered.

And then—

They faded.

Like mist in moonlight.

Like stars returning to the sky.

Chapter 11: Comedic Relief, Now with Heroism

Then, out of nowhere—

A voice rang out, bright and energetic, slicing through the solemn quiet like a party horn at a funeral.

“Wowwwww, you guys *actually* did this, didn’t you? Even though it was dangerous? You clung onto hope that I’d come bail you out. How reckless. How presumptuous. Geez, what am I gonna do with you...”

Mitama and Rena froze.

Their eyes went wide.

Mifuyu and Momoko, barely conscious, their spirit forms flickering and fragile, couldn’t open their eyes or move — but somewhere deep in their fading minds, a spark of recognition bloomed. Hope. Happiness. Relief.

Mitama spun around, voice trembling. “Kasumi? Is that you? Did you really come?”

Before anyone could answer, Mifuyu and Momoko felt a hand grasp theirs — warm, firm, buzzing with life.

Energy surged through them.

Their spirit forms stopped shattering. The mist paused mid-dissolution. The cracks held. The stars within them pulsed brighter.

They both murmured, voices soft and dreamy.

“So this is Kasumi’s energy... so warm...”

“So happy... how fun...”

“Thank you...”

And then they drifted into a kind of sleep — not death, not fading, but comfort. Surrendering to the warmth.

And then—

Kasumi arrived.

In style.

Confetti exploded into the air. Bright streamers unfurled like fireworks. Balloons burst with glitter. The sound of party horns echoed through Mitama’s tent realm like a parade had crashed into a cathedral.

Kasumi descended in a swirl of color, arms flailing, voice shrieking.

“Oh nononononono—!”

She spun midair, grabbed onto the sleeping spirits of Momoko and Mifuyu, and shook them wildly like plush toys on a roller coaster.

“Hold on, hold on, hold on—!”

She landed with a spectacular thud, limbs tangled, hair askew, dragging the spirits down with her in a chaotic heap.

Mitama and Rena flinched.

Then stared, horrified for a split second that Kasumi might've just *killed* Mifuyu and Momoko with her entrance.

But when they saw no harm was done — not even a scratch — they burst into uncontrollable laughter.

Tears streamed down their faces — not from sorrow, but from joy. From the sheer absurdity. From the relief. From the fact that *this* was Kasumi. Exactly as she was.

“This is just like the talent show,” Rena gasped between laughs. “Two nights ago. That terrible recorder music. That fall from the kid toy bicycle—!”

Mitama nodded, laughing so hard she had to clutch her soul gem. “The joy she brings is *infectious*.”

Kasumi groaned, letting go of Mifuyu's and Momoko's hands as she got up. She dusted off her clothes, folded her arms, and pouted dramatically.

“Don't deflect the conversation,” she said, voice sharp with accusation. “You all did something *reckless*. You hoped I'd come bail you out, didn't you? You saw what Lunaria did to Kuroe's witch and thought, ‘Oh, maybe Kasumi will do something cool too! Maybe Kasumi will save them when they are about to die!’”

She pointed at them, one hand on her hip, the other wagging like a disappointed teacher.

“Unbelievable. You just *assumed* I'd show up. You just threw yourselves into danger and crossed your fingers!”

Mitama and Rena, still laughing, wiped their eyes and bowed their heads.

“We're sorry,” Mitama said, grinning. “Yes. After seeing Lunaria... we hoped. Deep in our hearts. That either she or you would come.”

Kasumi's arms remained folded.

Her confetti-streaked hair fluttered slightly in the ambient magic of the tent realm, but her expression had changed. Gone was the flailing, the shrieking, the chaotic joy. She stared at Mitama and Rena with narrowed eyes — sharp, unreadable, almost predatory.

The laughter died.

Mitama and Rena, still catching their breath, slowly straightened. Their smiles faltered.

Kasumi didn't blink.

She didn't move.

She just stared.

The silence stretched.

Longer than it should have.

Longer than was comfortable.

Mitama's throat tightened. Rena shifted uneasily, glancing between Kasumi and the sleeping forms of Mifuyu and Momoko.

Still, Kasumi said nothing.

Her gaze was intense — not angry, not sad, but something else. Something unreadable. As if she were peering into their souls, weighing them, judging them.

Mitama swallowed.

"Kasumi..." she said, voice trembling. "Are you... okay?"

No response.

"You're starting to scare me..."

Still nothing.

Mitama took a shaky step forward, her soul gem pulsing faintly in her hand.

"You're helping us... right? You won't abandon us now that we've admitted it? That we hoped... that maybe you'd come save Mifuyu and Momoko?"

Kasumi's eyes didn't waver.

Mitama's voice cracked.

"That maybe... you'd be our miracle?"

Rena's breath hitched.

The silence was unbearable now — thick as fog, heavy as guilt. Mitama and Rena could feel their hearts pounding, their skin prickling with cold sweat. The joy from moments ago felt distant, fragile, like a dream slipping through their fingers.

Was Kasumi angry?

Disappointed?

Was she going to leave?

Had they asked too much?

Had they hoped too hard?

They stood frozen, afraid to speak again, afraid to move — afraid that the miracle they'd clung to was about to vanish.

And Kasumi...

Just kept staring.

Mitama and Rena were shaking.

Tears streamed down their faces. Their hearts pounded like war drums. Sweat clung to their brows. The silence had stretched too long. Too heavy. Too cruel.

They were starting to believe it.

That Kasumi would vanish in a puff of glitter and mischief. That Mifuyu and Momoko would truly fade. That this was all a cruel joke — a miracle dangled just out of reach.

And then—

Kasumi twirled.

A full, theatrical spin, arms flared like a stage magician.

She beamed.

Her eyes sparkled with joy, her voice bursting with energy.

“Of course I came to help you out! You were *right!*”

Mitama and Rena gasped.

Then collapsed.

They dropped to the ground in a heap, laughing and crying at once, their bodies trembling with relief.

“She came,” Rena whispered, breathless. “She actually came.”

Mitama clutched her soul gem, her laughter bubbling up like a spring. “They’re going to live. We did it. We *actually* did it.”

Kasumi burst into laughter, hands on her hips.

“Oh my god, you should’ve seen your faces!” she said, pointing at them. “The way you went from giggling to sweating to full-on existential horror? *Hilarious*. I should’ve taken a picture.”

Mitama and Rena pouted in unison.

“That wasn’t funny,” Mitama said, crossing her arms. “We *really* thought you were going to abandon us.”

Rena nodded, cheeks puffed. “You scared us half to death! We thought you were going to let Mifuyu and Momoko die just to teach us a lesson.”

“After we admitted we were hoping for a miracle,” Mitama added. “That maybe... you or Lunaria would come.”

Kasumi gave a deep, dramatic bow.

“Guilty as charged!” she said brightly. “I *do* act like this with others. Chaos and good fun — it’s the spice of life, don’t you think?”

She winked, utterly unrepentant.

Mitama and Rena exchanged a look, then burst into laughter again.

“You and Lunaria are so different,” Rena said, wiping her eyes.

Mitama nodded. “You played completely different music at the talent show. Lunaria’s piece was elegant, beautiful. Yours was...”

“Unhinged,” Rena offered.

“Joyfully unhinged,” Mitama agreed.

Kasumi grinned. “Isn’t it great? We’re opposites in every way. But we’re still close friends.”

Mitama and Rena laughed deeply, the sound echoing through the tent realm like wind chimes in spring.

“Friends,” Mitama said softly, her voice warm. “I have friends now. Momoko. Rena. Even Yachiyo and I... we’ve come to understand each other. We still disagree on some things, but maybe one day...”

She looked up, eyes shining.

“Maybe one day, we’ll be close friends too.”

She placed a hand over her heart.

“I hope... that one day, all magical girls can be close friends. Wings of the Magius or not.”

Kasumi smiled.

And for a moment, the tent realm shimmered with something brighter than magic.

Hope.

Mitama and Rena, still glowing with relief, couldn’t help themselves.

The questions came in a flurry.

“What’s going to happen to Momoko and Mifuyu now that you intervened?” Mitama asked.

“And what about Lunaria and Kuroe?” Rena added. “Lunaria said ‘dis-connect’ before that huge light enveloped her and Ichizo. Did you use ‘dis-connect’ here too?”

“Who *are* you and Lunaria, really?” Mitama pressed. “Why did you choose to help magical girls in Kamihama now?”

Kasumi sighed dramatically, folding her arms and tilting her head.

“Not only are you reckless and presumptuous,” she said, “but you’re also *greedy*. Wanting more from me after I just saved your friends. How *ungrateful*.”

Mitama and Rena both gasped, then burst into laughter, hands covering their mouths.

“Sorry,” Mitama said between giggles. “We’re just... curious.”

“I am pretty sure every magical girl you’ve interacted with had the same curiosity,” Rena added.

Kasumi’s expression softened. She smiled — not her usual chaotic grin, but something warmer. Something real.

“I helped you now,” she said, “because I saw everything. I saw how Yachiyo, Mifuyu, and Momoko connected. How Yachiyo finally understood her true ability — how she can open up, form bonds, live freely, unshackled from the fear that her wish to survive was cursed.”

She stepped closer, her voice gentle.

“And yes, I saw how all of you — Yachiyo, Mifuyu, Mitama, Momoko, Rena — hoped deep in your hearts that Lunaria or I would come. But you didn’t rely on that hope. You accepted the opposite. Mifuyu and Momoko were truly prepared to sacrifice themselves. And at the end... you all followed through.”

She winked.

“That’s true strength. True resolve. True love.”

Mitama and Rena felt it — like a warm embrace wrapping around their souls. Kasumi’s words melted through them, unexpected and profound.

They weren’t used to Kasumi being this serious.

“Thank you,” Mitama whispered. “For helping us. For saving them. For seeing us.”

Rena nodded. “And for acknowledging our strength. The hardships we face to support each other.”

Kasumi smiled.

Then—

She tilted her head, tapped her chin, and her voice shifted.

“As for your question about Kuroe...” she said, eyes drifting upward. “She’s probably in a better place now... I think...”

Mitama and Rena blinked.

“You *think*?” they echoed, unimpressed.

Kasumi continued, same tone, same dreamy gaze.

“And Mifuyu and Momoko? They’ll be fine... for now... maybe?”

Mitama’s and Rena’s eyes narrowed.

“*For now, maybe?*” Rena repeated.

“All your answers sound like *questions*,” Mitama added. “Did you and Lunaria really help? Or was this just a fancy show before they die? Another false hope?”

Kasumi grinned, unfazed.

“So many questions,” she said sweetly.

She glanced at her wrist — which had no watch — and gasped.

“Oh look! It’s *that* time!”

She turned on her heel and began to walk away, humming to herself.

Mitama and Rena reached out, arms extended, voices urgent.

“Wait! You’re just going to leave us like that?”

“What do you mean by ‘that’ time?”

“You don’t even *have* a watch!”

“Please stop messing with us!”

Kasumi didn’t turn around.

She just waved a hand over her shoulder.

And laughed.

Then Kasumi stopped walking.

The unconscious spirit forms of Mifuyu and Momoko floated gently beside her, their expressions serene, their bodies glowing faintly like stars at rest. They looked as if they were dreaming — wrapped in warmth, suspended in peace.

Kasumi turned.

She spun in a full theatrical flourish, arms wide, one foot kicked behind her like a stage performer taking her final bow.

“We’ll meet again,” she said brightly. “Very soon. Tata~!”

Mitama and Rena reached out instinctively.

“Kasumi!” they called, voices overlapping, hearts leaping.

But she was already gone.

Kasumi, Mifuyu, and Momoko vanished in a burst of confetti. Party streamers shot out in every direction, swirling through the tent realm like ribbons of laughter. Balloons inflated midair and popped with glitter. A comical party horn echoed through the space — the exact same sound that had heralded Kasumi’s arrival.

Mitama and Rena blinked, stunned.

Then—

Two sheets of paper fluttered down from above, landing gently at their feet.

They picked them up.

Identical notes.

The handwriting was bubbly and erratic, full of loops and stars. The message was simple:

“Live with joy! Be reckless sometimes! Life is more fun that way! —Kasumi”

Below the message were drawings — chaotic, colorful, and utterly indecipherable. One looked vaguely like a cat riding a rocket. Another might’ve been a magical girl doing karaoke with her doppel. Neither Mitama nor Rena could make sense of them, but they could feel the joy radiating off the page.

They smiled.

They brought the notes to their chests, closed their eyes, and whispered together:

“Thank you.”

From the heart.

The clatter of chopsticks and laughter filled Banbanzai.

Yachiyo, Iroha, Sana, Felicia, and Tsuruno sat around a table overflowing with food — steaming bowls of ramen with glistening broth, sizzling plates of gyoza that crackled as they cooled, and colorful side dishes arranged like edible jewels under the restaurant’s cozy amber lights. The air was thick with the comforting scent of soy, sesame oil, and grilled scallions. It was warm. Familiar. Alive.

They talked. They teased. They laughed.

Felicia was already on her third bowl, slurping loudly and declaring it the best ramen she’d ever had — again. Tsuruno was trying to convince Sana to try a spicy dipping sauce that made even her eyes water. Iroha giggled as she wiped broth off her chin, and Yachiyo smiled, quietly watching them all.

And every so often, they glanced out the window.

Beyond the glass, the night sky shimmered with movement. Doppels — once twisted and monstrous — were reverting back into magical girl spirit forms, glowing softly as they floated upward like fireflies returning to the stars. Each one drifted toward the HQ, gentle and weightless.

Each time they saw one, they smiled.

Mifuyu, Momoko, and Mitama were succeeding.

Then the last doppel flickered and faded, its form dissolving into a soft, luminous spirit that soared into the sky.

Yachiyo's smile faltered.

She looked down.

Her soul gem pulsed faintly in her hand — a quiet heartbeat of magic. The golden and silver flickers that had danced earlier, signs of her connection to Momoko and Mifuyu, were now barely visible. Faint. Fragile. Like the last embers of a dying fire.

She clutched the gem tightly to her chest.

Tears welled up and spilled over.

She could feel it.

They were about to die.

Tsuruno noticed first. Her chopsticks paused midair. “Yachiyo...?”

Iroha leaned in, her voice soft. “Are you okay?”

Sana and Felicia looked up, their expressions shifting from playful to concerned in an instant.

Yachiyo chuckled through her tears, wiping her eyes with the back of her hand.

“I’m sorry,” she said, her voice trembling. “I didn’t mean to cry in front of you. You’re all enjoying yourselves. I should be happy too.”

She tried to smile, but it wavered.

“I prepared myself for this. I knew they might die. But when it actually happens...”

Her voice broke.

Tsuruno reached across the table and gently took her hand, her grip warm and steady.

“It’s okay,” she said. “Take as much time as you need.”

Iroha nodded, her eyes shining. “We’re here.”

Sana offered a soft smile. “You don’t have to hide it.”

Felicia leaned in, her voice unusually quiet. “We’ve got you.”

Yachiyo closed her eyes, breathing deeply, trying to steady herself.

She had lost friends before.

She had survived.

But it never got easier.

Then—

A warmth.

A sudden, radiant warmth surged through her soul gem, her body, her heart.

Her eyes snapped open.

She gasped.

The others turned to her, startled.

“What is it?” Tsuruno asked, already halfway out of her seat.

Yachiyo held up her soul gem.

The faint golden and silver flickers were no longer fading — they were swirling, surrounded by tiny flames that danced like fireflies. The colors twisted together in a soft spiral, glowing brighter, then gently dimming, like a candle extinguished by a breeze.

Everyone stared.

“What was that?” Felicia asked, her voice hushed.

“Did you feel something?” Iroha added, eyes wide.

Yachiyo’s mouth was still open in surprise.

Thoughts raced through her mind.

That sensation — it was warm. Happy. Fun.

Did that mean Mifuyu and Momoko had died peacefully?

Or was it... something else?

She closed her eyes and shook her head.

No, she thought. I refuse to believe they died. Someone must’ve come to save them.

“Are you okay?” Tsuruno asked again, more gently this time.

Yachiyo opened her eyes and looked at them, tears still falling — but now, they were tears of joy.

“I felt something,” she said softly. “A strange energy. It flowed through me. Through my soul gem. Through my heart.”

She smiled, radiant and trembling.

“It was warm. Happy. Fun. I believe... someone came to save them.”

The others lit up.

“They’re alive?” Sana asked, her voice catching.

“They were saved?” Tsuruno echoed, eyes shining.

Iroha leaned in, hopeful. “Can you tell who it was?”

Yachiyo closed her eyes again.

Exhaled.

There was only one person she could think of with energy like that. The swirling flames on her soul gem — they looked just like the ribbons on a certain someone’s chaotic, colorful outfit.

She turned to the window.

The sky was clear now — serene, moonlit, twinkling with stars.

“Thank you,” she whispered. “Kasumi.”

The others smiled.

“So she did come,” Felicia said, grinning.

Yachiyo turned back to them, wiping her tears away completely.

“No more sad moments,” she said, her voice bright and steady. “Let’s continue the fun. Mifuyu and Momoko will be here with us one day. I’m sure of it.”

Tsuruno raised her chopsticks high. “To future Banbanzai dinners!”

Iroha, Sana, and Felicia cheered in unison, their voices echoing through the warm, fragrant air.

And the laughter returned — louder, freer, and more joyful than before.

A soft, encompassing light wrapped around Mitama and Rena, dissolving the tent realm’s ethereal glow and guiding them gently back to the real world.

When the light faded, they found themselves standing once again in the Doppel Syndrome Isolation Ward.

The room was quiet.

All of the isolation spheres — once humming with unstable magic — were shattered, their fragments scattered like glass across the floor. The air still carried the faint scent of ozone and grief, but the chaos had passed.

On the ground lay dozens of magical girls, their bodies relaxed, their breathing steady. Their faces were peaceful, touched with faint smiles, as if caught in the middle of a gentle dream.

Mitama and Rena looked around slowly, taking it all in.

The silence was sacred.

The stillness was earned.

And the girls — once consumed by despair — were safe.

Mitama exhaled, her shoulders softening. Her soul gem pulsed faintly, no longer in alarm but in quiet affirmation.

Rena smiled, her eyes shimmering. She knelt beside one of the girls and brushed a strand of hair from her face.

They had done it.

Mifuyu and Momoko had saved them.

Then—

Footsteps.

A pair of voices echoed from the entrance.

“What happened here? Is everyone okay?”

Mitama and Rena turned.

The Amane sisters — Tsukuyo and Tsukasa — stood in the doorway, their eyes wide with concern. They stepped inside, their gazes sweeping across the room, taking in the shattered spheres and the sleeping girls.

“Mitama, Rena,” Tsukasa said. “We saw a bunch of doppels break through the HQ and fly into the air. What happened?”

Mitama stepped forward, her voice calm but tired, like a bell rung too many times.

“After Kuroe became a witch, she broke a hole in the APS barrier. That rupture caused all the doppels here to go berserk and escape.”

She gestured gently to the rows of peacefully sleeping magical girls.

“But Mifuyu and Momoko connected with each other. They saved them all.”

She smiled faintly, pride and sorrow mingling in her eyes.

The Amane sisters clenched their fists.

“Kuroe...” Tsukuyo muttered. “That traitor. Not only did she lead Yachiyo into the HQ, but she caused all this destruction too?”

Tsukasa's voice was sharp. "Becoming a witch is a suitable end for her."

Mitama's and Rena's eyes softened.

They didn't reply.

The words stung — not because they were unexpected, but because they were so final. So cruel. And yet... they understood. The pain. The fear. The need to blame someone when the world breaks.

The Amane sisters looked around again.

"Where are Mifuyu and Momoko?" Tsukasa asked. "Are they okay?"

Mitama and Rena exchanged a glance.

"We don't know," Rena said quietly. "We're still looking."

The four of them began to search the ward, stepping carefully between the sleeping magical girls. The room was quiet, save for the soft hum of residual magic and the occasional creak of the floor beneath their feet.

Then—

"No..."

Tsukasa's voice cracked.

"Please... no..."

Mitama's heart dropped.

Rena froze.

They turned toward the sound.

Tsukasa was kneeling, her shoulders trembling, her arms wrapped tightly around two still forms.

Streams of tears poured down her face.

Tsukuyo rushed to her side, and when she saw what her sister was holding, she collapsed beside her, sobbing.

Mitama and Rena approached slowly.

And then they saw.

Mifuyu and Momoko.

Lying side by side.

Still holding each other's hands.

Their soul gems — shattered.

Their bodies — lifeless.

Mitama brought a hand to her mouth, her breath catching.

Rena's knees buckled, and she dropped to the floor, tears spilling down her cheeks.

The Amane sisters wept openly, their cries echoing through the ward like a lament.

Mifuyu had always been there — a veteran of the Wings of the Magius, a recruiter, a listener, a sisterly presence. She had comforted them, guided them, believed in them.

Momoko hadn't been with the Wings long, but she had been kind. Gentle. Protective. She had looked out for them, for everyone. She was adored.

And now they were gone.

Mitama stood frozen, her mind spinning.

What did Kasumi do?

Did she even save them?

Was it all a dream?

She and Rena looked at each other, eyes wide with confusion and grief.

Then—

A thought.

They both reached into their pockets, hands trembling.

Their hearts pounded.

And then—

They felt it.

Paper.

They pulled it out.

And smiled.

It was the note.

The one Kasumi had left behind — the one that had fluttered down after she vanished with the spirit forms of Mifuyu and Momoko.

It was real.

She had been there.

Mitama and Rena locked eyes, speaking telepathically.

What did she do?

Where did she take them?

Are they really gone... or just somewhere else?

They didn't know.

But they still had hope.

Kasumi had said they would meet again — *very soon*.

Maybe Mifuyu and Momoko would be with her.

Mitama chuckled softly, brushing a tear from her cheek.

If they're not, she said to Rena, I'll just ask Yachiyo to figure out how to talk to her deceased friends sooner. She can bring us in next time.

Or, she added with a grin, I'll unlock my own latent abilities. Like Yachiyo.

Rena laughed through her tears.

"You're strangely optimistic now," she said aloud, her voice warm.

Mitama smiled. "Optimistic and positive... what a great feeling. To look forward to tomorrow with joy."

They turned back to Mifuyu and Momoko's bodies.

And then—

They noticed something.

Tiny glimmers.

Strands of glitter.

A few small strings of confetti, tangled gently in Momoko's hair, caught in the folds of Mifuyu's sleeve.

So easy to miss.

But unmistakable.

Mitama and Rena smiled, their hearts aching and full.

They whispered to each other, telepathically, reverently.

Kasumi...

Thank you.

Chapter 12: Leaders' Reflections

The room was dim, lit only by the flickering glow of magical torches and the pulsing, feverish colors of Alina's canvas. The air was thick with the scent of oil paint, scorched magic, and something faintly metallic — like blood dried into silk.

Alina stood barefoot in the center of the chaos, surrounded by torn canvases and shattered palettes. Her apron was smeared with reds and blacks, her fingers stained like a surgeon's after a massacre. Her brush danced across the canvas in erratic, violent strokes — each one a scream, a wound, a flourish.

"Bellissimo," she whispered, eyes gleaming. "So much destruction. So much *truth*."

The painting was a vortex of agony.

Broken isolation spheres floated midair, jagged and sharp, like shattered halos. Doppels twisted through the sky, their mouths open in silent screams, their limbs contorted in grotesque ballet. Buildings crumbled in the background, Kamiyama rendered as a bleeding ruin. The sky was a smear of violet and black, streaked with fire and despair.

At the center of the canvas stood two figures.

Mifuyu and Momoko.

Alina had taken liberties.

Mifuyu was painted mid-scream, her body torn open by doppel claws, her soul gem exploding in a burst of crimson light. Her eyes were wide, her mouth frozen in a final cry — not of peace, but of horror.

Momoko stood beside her, shielding a group of terrified magical girls. Her arms were outstretched, her body riddled with wounds, her soul gem shattered at her feet. Behind her, the girls she tried to protect were painted with expressions of absolute terror — mouths agape, eyes hollow, hands reaching out as if to beg for salvation that would never come.

Alina added a flourish of black spirals radiating from their corpses, curling outward like vines of despair.

"Perfetto," she murmured. "A crescendo of suffering. A symphony of failure."

She dipped her brush into a pool of deep red and dragged it across the canvas like a blade.

"To die trying... *che tragedia magnifica!*"

She began sketching new figures in the background — faceless crowds of ordinary people, watching the chaos unfold. Their expressions were twisted in horror, their bodies frozen in panic. Some were running. Some were falling. Some were simply staring, as if hypnotized by the spectacle.

Alina smiled.

"Let them see," she whispered. "Let them *feel*."

She added a final detail — a spiral of despair blooming from the center, reaching outward, infecting everything. It touched the doppels, the girls, the city, the sky.

A virus.

A message.

A masterpiece.

“Soon,” she said, stepping back. “Everyone will understand. Everyone will *know*.”

She laughed softly, eyes shining.

“Arte è dolore. Art is pain.”

Touka stood nearby, arms folded, watching Alina’s brush slash across the canvas like a scalpel. Her gaze didn’t linger on the painting — she had already cataloged the destruction in her mind, every doppel surge, every breach in the APS barrier, every casualty. She didn’t need art to understand chaos. She understood it mathematically.

She sighed.

“Mifuyu is gone,” she said, her voice low but clipped. “She was one of our most valuable members. Statistically speaking, she recruited more magical girls than anyone. She gave the Wings its heart — or at least the illusion of one.”

Her tone was clinical, but a flicker of something passed through her eyes. Not sorrow. Not regret. Just... irritation.

“She was gentle. Kind. She understood weakness. She made people feel safe.”

Touka paused, her fingers tapping against her arm.

“And Momoko... even though she wasn’t with us long, she was adored. She played the older-sister role well. She made the girls laugh. She made them believe they could survive.”

She scoffed softly.

“Belief. How quaint.”

She stared at the floor, her thoughts swirling. The deaths were inconvenient. Emotionally disruptive. Logistically messy. But not unexpected. Not unacceptable.

She let herself feel the loss.

Just for a moment.

Then she shook her head, her expression hardening.

“No,” she murmured. “I won’t be deterred.”

She turned to the window, where the moon hung low and pale, casting a cold light over the ruined cityscape.

“Three more days,” she whispered. “Just three more. And no magical girl will ever have to sacrifice herself again.”

Her voice was steady. Almost triumphant.

She imagined the system she’d built — the equations, the architecture, the elegant collapse of suffering into salvation. She saw the endpoint. The perfect solution. The world she would create.

Two deaths?

Acceptable loss.

She clenched her fist.

Let them mourn. Let them cry. Let them paint their tragedies.

She would finish what she started.

And when it was done, they would thank her.

Even if they didn’t understand.

Even if they hated her.

Even if they died.

Alina didn’t respond.

She was still painting.

Still smiling.

Still adding streaks of despair to her masterpiece.

Her brush moved like a conductor’s baton, orchestrating agony. Each stroke was deliberate, erratic, divine. She layered black over crimson, violet over ash, until the canvas pulsed with a kind of living grief.

And then—

In the chaos of color and shadow, a shape began to form.

Not a person.

Not a place.

But a world.

Cracking open.

The fissures spread like veins, jagged and glowing, as if the planet itself were bleeding. From the center of the rupture, a spiral of grief unfurled — elegant, endless, infectious. It twisted outward, touching cities, forests, oceans, crowds. The people she painted were faceless, but their postures screamed: bent knees, clawed hands, mouths open in silent horror.

Alina leaned in, adding fine lines of decay to their limbs. She painted their eyes as hollow voids, their shadows as witches-in-waiting.

“Ahh... *la disperazione*,” she whispered. “So fragile. So pure.”

She added more spirals — smaller ones, nested inside the larger. Each one a seed of despair. Each one a promise.

She imagined the moment it would happen.

When the veil would lift.

When ordinary humans — blissfully ignorant — would feel it.

The weight.

The hopelessness.

The slow, crushing erosion of joy.

The transformation.

She dipped her brush into a pool of gray and painted a girl in the corner — not a magical girl, but a civilian. Young. Smiling. Unaware.

Then she painted her again, beside the first — older, broken, twisted into a witch.

No magic.

Just despair.

“Soon,” Alina murmured. “They’ll all understand.”

She stepped back, admiring the canvas.

It wasn’t just a painting.

It was a blueprint.

A prophecy.

A quiet promise.

To make everyone feel what magical girls feel.

To make despair universal.

To make it... *art*.

She smiled.

“Tutti devono soffrire. Everyone must suffer.”

And with one final stroke — a spiral curling into the heart of the world — she sealed it.

Far from the chaos of HQ, Nemu rested in one of the Wings of the Magius’ satellite buildings — a quiet, repurposed hotel tucked into the outskirts of Mitakihara. The room was modest: a single bed, a desk, a lamp casting a warm amber glow. Outside, the wind rustled faintly against the windows, carrying the hush of midnight and the scent of distant rain.

Nemu sat curled in a chair by the window, a book open in her lap.

She was reading — as she always did before sleep. The story had reached its climax: a group of characters facing impossible odds, standing their ground despite knowing they would die. They fought not for victory, but for dignity. For each other.

Her eyes lingered on the final lines of the chapter.

Her fingers trembled slightly as she turned the page.

So much like magical girls, she thought. So much like us.

She closed the book gently, pressing it to her chest.

Her thoughts drifted.

To Ui.

To the three of them — Ui, Touka, and herself — once inseparable, once full of dreams and equations and stories. They had tried to change the world. They had failed.

And Ui...

Ui had paid the price.

Nemu was the only one who remembered.

The only one who knew what had truly happened.

She had never told Touka.

She couldn’t.

Touka would stop everything if she knew. She would abandon the plan. She would grieve. She would break.

And Nemu...

Nemu couldn’t let that happen.

Even if it meant carrying the truth alone.

Her Magius emblem pulsed softly.

A call.

At this hour?

She picked it up.

“Touka,” she said, her voice quiet.

“Nemu,” Touka replied. “How are things going?”

“Smoothly,” Nemu said. “Everything is on schedule. We should be ready to awaken Embryo Eve in three days.”

Touka hummed. “Good. You’ve done well.”

“Thank you,” Nemu said softly. “How are things at HQ?”

Touka sighed, the sound sharp and impatient. “Annoying. A lot of mess today.”

Nemu tilted her head. “What happened?”

Touka’s voice sharpened, her words clipped and bitter.

“Kuroe. That traitor. She led Iroha and Yachiyo to one of the HQ entrances. Probably trying to help Yachiyo infiltrate again. The Amane sisters caught her in the act and branded her a traitor. As she tried to flee, she was confronted by our members. She resisted. Her doppel took over.”

Touka paused, her voice thick with disdain.

“It broke a hole in the APS barrier. She became a witch.”

Another pause.

“Hmph. A fitting end for a traitor. One less magical girl to lock up.”

Nemu froze.

Her breath caught.

She opened her mouth, moved a hand to her lips.

Tears welled in her eyes.

Kuroe...

She had been the one to send Kuroe on a secret mission — to search for the Eternal Sakura, the rumor she had created to protect Iroha. And it looked like Kuroe had succeeded. Iroha was alive.

But for Kuroe’s end to be like this...

Too sad.

Too cruel.

Nemu felt a heaviness settle in her chest, like a stone pressing against her heart.

Mifuyu told me Yachiyo ran into Kuroe, she thought. Pursued her. Interrogated her. All while Kuroe was trying to fulfill the mission I gave her.

She closed her eyes.

“I’m sorry,” she whispered. “Kuroe... I’m so sorry.”

Touka’s voice broke through, sharp and suspicious.

“Nemu? You’re quiet. Are you okay?”

Nemu wiped her tears quickly, trying to steady her voice.

“I’m fine,” she said, softly. “Just tired.”

Her voice didn’t tremble.

But her heart did.

Touka’s voice sharpened, tinged with frustration.

“Then something happened,” she said. “Something I can’t explain. And you know how much I *hate* that.”

Nemu blinked, her breath still uneven.

Touka continued.

“When Kuroe became a witch — Ichizo, that’s her name now — a lone girl started flying toward her. Not a magical girl. Not one of ours. Just... a girl.”

Nemu’s eyes widened.

Touka’s voice dropped into a bitter scoff.

“She looked like Lunaria. The guest flutist from the Kamihama school talent show. The one who performed with the orchestra.”

Nemu sat up straighter, her heart skipping.

Lunaria?

She remembered the performance vividly — the aching beauty of it, the way the music had wrapped around her soul like a lullaby. It had made her feel at peace. Whole. Even as the world around her frayed.

“So you’re saying...” Nemu whispered. “Lunaria is a magical girl?”

Touka sighed, annoyed. “No. That’s the problem. She doesn’t have a soul gem. Just like Kasumi.”

Nemu’s brow furrowed.

Touka had told her about Kasumi’s visit to the Memory Museum the day before — how Kasumi had spoken with eerie insight about magical girls, despite not being one herself. Mifuyu had run tests. No soul gem. No magical signature. And yet...

They weren’t ordinary.

Nemu spoke slowly, thinking aloud.

“If Lunaria can fly like that... then Kasumi probably can too. They’re not magical girls. But they’re not ordinary people either. So what are they?”

Touka grunted. “Whatever they are, they have powers. That much is clear.”

She paused.

“But that’s not the crazy part.”

Nemu leaned in, her pulse quickening.

Touka’s voice dropped.

“Lunaria landed on Ichizo’s head. Just... sat there. Calm. She put a hand on the witch’s head. Gently. Like she was comforting her.”

Nemu’s eyes went wide.

“That’s impossible,” she said. “Witches can’t be communicated with. They’re beyond saving.”

Touka’s voice was tight. “I couldn’t hear what she said. But it looked like she was talking to Ichizo.”

Nemu’s breath caught.

“Are you sure?”

Touka hesitated.

“From the way she moved... yes. I think she was communicating.”

She paused again.

“Then she said one word. The only word I heard. It echoed through the HQ like a spell.”

Touka’s voice dropped to a whisper.

“**Dis-connect.**”

Nemu gasped.

Touka continued, her tone rising with irritation.

“Afterwards, a bright light enveloped Lunaria and Ichizo. And when it faded, both were gone. No trace. No grief seed. No remains. As if they had never been there.”

She scoffed.

“Very weird, right?! I am *very* confused what happened. It’s infuriating!”

Nemu’s thoughts ignited.

Dis-connect? What was that?

Did Lunaria save Kuroe?

That would defy everything they knew. Everything they believed.

She looked down, her voice trembling.

“Do you think... Lunaria saved her?”

Touka hummed, thoughtful but firm.

“No. That’s impossible. Saving a witch goes against everything we understand. I think ‘dis-connect’ was an offensive ability. She destroyed Ichizo and took the grief seed.”

Nemu nodded slowly.

“That’s the most logical explanation,” she said.

But her thoughts were on fire.

What if they’re wrong?

What if Lunaria did save Kuroe?

If that was true...

Then their entire plan — the sacrifices, the suffering, the locked-up girls, the APS and doppels that had caused so many to be isolated in the Doppel Syndrome Isolation Ward, the harvesting of negative emotions from humans to raise witches, the feeding of those witches to Embryo Eve — might be unnecessary.

All of it.

The pain.

The fear.

The lives lost.

If Lunaria could save a witch with a single word...

Then maybe magical girls didn’t need to be sacrificed.

Maybe humans didn’t need to suffer.

Maybe there was another way.

A better way.

Her heart ached.

Her mind raced.

She said nothing.

But inside, something had shifted.

A quiet fracture.

A question she couldn't un-ask.

Nemu wiped her eyes and offered a soft, trembling smile.

"Thank you for the updates," she said. "It truly does sound like something... annoying happened."

Touka made a sharp sound — not quite a scoff, not quite a sigh.

"No," she said. "That wasn't the worst part."

Nemu's breath stilled.

Her eyes narrowed.

"What do you mean?"

Touka's voice flattened, clinical.

"Remember when Ichizo broke a hole in the APS barrier?"

Nemu nodded slowly.

Touka continued.

"That rupture caused all the doppelified magical girls in the Isolation Ward to go berserk. They broke out of their spheres. Scattered. Free to roam. Free to destroy."

Nemu gasped.

Her eyes went wide.

"That's terrible! Are you and everyone else okay? How did you fix it?"

Touka sighed.

"I didn't."

She paused.

"Mitama, Momoko, and Mifuyu did."

Nemu blinked, stunned.

“They... how?”

Touka’s voice grew quieter, almost reluctant.

“All three of them connected. Mitama shared her coordinator powers with Momoko and Mifuyu. Then Momoko and Mifuyu went to each of the doppelified girls. They shared their burdens. Their suffering. Took it into themselves.”

She paused.

“They saved everyone.”

Another pause.

“But Mifuyu and Momoko died, their soul gems shattered from overuse.”

Nemu’s breath hitched.

Her hand flew to her mouth.

Not just Kuroe.

Now Mifuyu and Momoko too?

She felt the world tilt.

Mifuyu — her colleague, her friend, one of the original Wings members. They had recruited girls together. Shared long nights and quiet hopes.

Momoko — gentle, kind, protective. Not with them long, but beloved by all.

Gone.

Nemu audibly cried.

Her shoulders trembled.

Her voice cracked.

“I... I can’t believe it. This many deaths... in one day...”

Touka’s voice softened, just slightly.

“I understand your sadness. But we can’t be deterred.”

She paused.

“We’re close, Nemu. So close. Just three more days. Salvation for all magical girls. We have to remain strong.”

Nemu wiped her tears, her voice muffled.

“I... I understand.”

Touka's tone returned to its usual clipped rhythm.

"That's all the updates. Good night Nemu. We'll see each other soon."

The call ended.

Nemu gently placed her Magius emblem on the desk.

She lay down in bed, curling into herself.

Silent tears fell.

Three magical girls were lost today.

And what Touka had just told her — it mirrored the climax of the book she'd been reading. The brave ones who stood their ground. Who died for others.

She stared at the ceiling.

Her thoughts drifted.

To Lunaria.

To Kasumi.

To the word "dis-connect."

Was there another way?

Could magical girls live?

Could they escape their fate?

She didn't know.

But she wanted to.

She wanted to meet Lunaria.

She wanted to meet Kasumi.

She wanted to ask them everything.

And maybe — just maybe — find a different ending.

Chapter 12: Another Night, Another Adventure Comes to a Close

A soft breeze stirred the trees as Lunaria and Kasumi appeared at the edge of a moonlit clearing. Before them stood the cabin — their quiet refuge nestled deep within the heart of their realm. The forest around them glowed faintly under the silver light of the moon, its leaves rustling like whispers, its air cool and fragrant with pine and wildflowers.

It was late night.

The stars shimmered above, scattered like powdered sugar across a velvet sky. Fireflies drifted lazily through the underbrush, their golden lights blinking in rhythm with the pulse of the woods.

Lunaria cradled Kuroe gently in her arms, her dark hair cascading like ink over her shoulder. Kasumi walked beside her, carrying Momoko and Mifuyu across her back with surprising ease, their arms draped over her shoulders, their heads resting against her like sleeping children.

They reached the porch.

Kasumi paused, tilted her head back, and took a deep breath of the cool, clean air.

“Ahhh,” she sighed, smiling. “What a day. What a fun and exciting adventure.”

Lunaria chuckled, her voice soft and musical.

“It really was. We saw so much... learned so much. About the Wings of the Magius. About Ui. About the Kamihama girls.”

Kasumi nodded, her eyes reflecting the moonlight.

“I hope they start living with fun and joy now. They’ve earned it.”

Lunaria’s smile deepened.

“And with hope. And peace. I hope they stay safe... until we meet them again.”

Kasumi grinned, shifting her weight slightly to adjust the girls on her back.

“Well, it looks like we might have found an alternate way for Mami to save Sayaka after all.”

Lunaria nodded.

“Yes. Mifuyu, Momoko, and Kuroe — they can help Mami carry Sayaka’s burden. Share her despair. Maybe even bring her back.”

She glanced at Kuroe’s sleeping face.

“None of them know dis-connect... but they don’t need to. Their experiences, their hearts — that might be enough.”

Kasumi winked.

“As we always say — there are many ways to fight. Many ways to solve problems if you use creativity. I’m curious to see what they’ll do together.”

She opened the cabin door, the hinges creaking softly.

“Mifuyu and Momoko already know the basics of a technique — the one that lets them connect with magical girls, share their suffering, and draw out the darkness from their soul gems. They did it when they saved all those doppelified girls.”

Lunaria stepped inside, her voice warm.

“And Kuroe... she’s now a witch who’s touched the deepest despair. And Mami’s learning to wield negativity, to turn it into strength. If they all work together...”

She smiled.

“They just might save Sayaka, without Mami having to learn a small fraction of dis-connect.”

The cabin was quiet and welcoming, lit by the soft glow of enchanted lanterns. The walls were lined with flowers and plants, and the scent of lavender and cedar lingered in the air. A fire crackled gently in the hearth, casting golden light across the wooden floor.

They carried the girls into a cozy room at the back — three beds already prepared, each with a quilt folded neatly at the foot.

Lunaria laid Kuroe down first, brushing a strand of hair from her face. Kasumi followed, gently settling Mifuyu and Momoko into their beds.

They pulled the blankets up to their shoulders, tucking them in with care.

The girls’ faces were peaceful.

Their breathing was steady and calm.

Moonlight streamed through a round window in the wall, casting a soft silver glow across the room. It caught in their hair, shimmered on their skin, and made the whole space feel like a dream.

Kasumi stood back, hands on her hips.

“Well,” she said, smiling. “Looks like things are going to get livelier around here.”

Lunaria laughed quietly.

“I wonder how Mami will react tomorrow when she finds out she has more company.”

They stood there for a while, watching over the sleeping girls.

And in the quiet warmth of the cabin, surrounded by moonlight and the hush of the forest, hope took root.

Kasumi gave a mischievous grin at Lunaria’s mention of Mami.

“Speaking of Mami...” she said, voice curling into a chuckle.

With a flick of her wrist, she conjured a handful of colorful markers — glittery, metallic, and ominously permanent. She tiptoed toward Mami’s room like a cartoon thief, crouched low, her steps exaggerated, her expression gleefully criminal.

Lunaria chuckled softly, her eyes sparkling with amusement.

She knew exactly what Kasumi was about to do.

Revenge.

For what Mami, summoned Kyoko, and Lunaria's clone had done to Kasumi's clone in the spiritual realm — decorating her sleeping face after Mami and Kyoko finished watching the simulation about the origin of Connect, the shadow monster, and the six girls' battle against the six witches.

"Try not to go too far," Lunaria whispered, still smiling. "Mami and Kyoko have their special fight tomorrow. They'll be using Connect for the first time. If you make her look too hideous, she might be too embarrassed to even step into the arena."

Kasumi paused mid-creep, then shrugged.

"If she's too embarrassed, that's her loss," she said with a grin. "Besides, embarrassment is a negative emotion. She can use it to empower her attacks. So really, I'm helping her prepare."

Lunaria laughed — a soft, melodic sound that filled the cabin with warmth.

This was Kasumi at her finest: clever, chaotic, and always ready with a justification that somehow made sense.

As Kasumi vanished into Mami's room, Lunaria turned back toward the sleeping trio.

Kuroe.

Momoko.

Mifuyu.

She walked quietly to the edge of the room, her steps light as moonlight.

The cabin was hushed, wrapped in the gentle breath of night. The fire in the hearth had dimmed to a soft glow, casting golden shadows across the wooden floor. Outside, the forest rustled with a breeze that smelled of pine and dew. Moonlight streamed through the open window, painting the room in silver.

With a graceful twirl of her finger, three orbs of light appeared — soft, glowing spheres that pulsed with gentle magic. They hovered in the air like fireflies, casting a warm shimmer that danced across the quilts and the sleeping girls' faces.

Lunaria smiled.

She leaned down slightly, speaking in a voice just above a whisper.

"This dream will prepare you for what lies ahead tomorrow," she said. "Rest well."

She sent the orbs forward.

Each one floated toward its chosen girl — one to Kuroe, one to Momoko, one to Mifuyu — and gently slipped into their hearts like a breath of wind.

Inside each orb was a dream.

A dream of Mami's and summoned Kyoko's journey earlier that day — their journey through the pyramid of the beginner Connect trial, their viewing of the solemn murals that told forgotten stories, their battles against the mummy forms of the spirits of the executed family members, against Aurellia Mizunagi, and against the six witches: Velmira, Ruinelle, Catastrophia, Thornaria, Noctulisse, and Vexaphra.

All without using Connect.

Then the simulation — the origin of Connect, the shadow monster, and the epic and tragic battle between the six girls: Elira Mizunagi, Sylvette Prothea, Mirielle Calden, Hoshine Tsunagari, and the two girls without soul gems — facing those same six witches in a clash of despair and hope.

A dream of courage.

Of connection.

Of possibility.

Lunaria walked to the door, pausing one last time.

She looked back at their sleeping faces — peaceful, serene, bathed in moonlight.

Their breathing was steady.

Their expressions soft.

She smiled.

“Good night,” she whispered. “Sweet dreams.”

She closed the door gently behind her.

And inside the room, Kuroe, Momoko, and Mifuyu smiled in their sleep.

Maybe from the dreams.

Maybe from the warmth of being wished good night.

Maybe from both.

Outside, the forest rustled softly.

The stars shimmered.

And the cabin glowed with quiet magic.

The day had ended.

But tomorrow — tomorrow would begin something new.

